

The Vise

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1. Twelve Minutes

The calendar at Bellwether ran in twelve-minute blocks.

Kate Merrick gave a reason for this when asked. The medieval English penny divided into twelve. A unit you could split three ways or four and have nothing left over. People liked the reason. It was charming and it was true and it was not why.

Here is why. A half-hour meeting takes half an hour. A twelve-minute meeting is over before anyone has finished being pleased to see you.

9:24, Monday. She was in a room she had no business being in.

Sprint review, returns platform, four levels below her. Second floor, the small room with three glass walls and a print of a whale on the fourth. Everyone called it the Aquarium. Nine people at a table built for eight.

She came in at 9:23 and the room did the thing rooms did. The half-second rearrangement. The tiny weather change of a floor discovering the chief executive has joined the sprint review. A young man called Otis stood up to give her his chair.

“No. No, honestly.” She took it.

Priyanka from engineering was walking them through queue depth on the refund service. Kate watched a dashboard on her phone under the table.

Twelve numbers, black background. They had built it for her in the first year, when Bellwether was two brands and a

warehouse in Erith. Ten green. One amber, which meant nothing — a contractor set that threshold in 2021 and set it slightly wrong, and every quarter somebody said they should fix it, and every quarter it stayed.

One red.

She looked at the red number for two seconds. Two seconds was as long as she looked at anything.

“Sorry.” The room stopped. “Sorry. Go back one. The four hundred and twelve. Is that refunds queued, or customers?”

“Refunds.”

“So some are the same person.”

“Some are the same person.”

“How many?”

The pause. She caused it forty times a day and she knew its shape from the inside: a competent person arriving at the exact edge of what they had prepared.

“I’d have to check.”

“It’ll be one-point-four. It’s always one-point-four.” Kate was already standing. “So we’re annoying two hundred and ninety people, not four hundred. Different meeting. Tom, six minutes at eleven. Not you, Gareth, you’ve got the board thing.”

Gareth Pryce, chief technology officer, two chairs down, asked nothing all meeting, said: “Sure.”

Out of the Aquarium at 9:31. Three minutes over. Three minutes over for the rest of the day.

• • •

The corridor was the only place she was ever alone. She had learned to use it.

Phone at her mouth. Walking.

“Dawn. Hi. Find me twelve minutes with Tom before eleven, and if it has to eat the Ocean Group call then push Ocean to Thursday and tell them it’s because I want to give it proper time, which is true. Also twenty with Harriet before the summit. I know there isn’t any.” At the lift. “So find it.”

Sent. On the second floor a phone buzzed beside a photograph of two children on a beach, in weather that was clearly not warm.

10:52. Tom Ferreira’s part of the floor. She stood at his desk rather than sat. Standing kept it short.

Tom was VP of Engineering. Gareth was CTO. On the org chart a clean line ran from Kate to Gareth and from Gareth to Tom. In the physical world Kate walked past Gareth’s office, which had a glass door with Gareth behind it, to get to Tom’s desk.

“Talk to me about the refund queue.”

He talked to her about the refund queue. He was good. Better at this than Gareth, she thought, and put the thought where she kept the others like it.

Nine minutes and they had it. A retry policy doing exactly what it had been told to do, told the wrong thing eighteen months ago by somebody who no longer worked here.

“Ship it today.”

“Gareth’s got a freeze on until after the summit.”

“Ship it today. I’ll tell Gareth.”

She did not tell Gareth. She meant to. It went on the list she kept in her head of things she would do when a gap came, a list with the structure and permanence of geology.

• • •

7:02, Wednesday. Fourth bullet of a status email. Heading: *Refill — update.*

Following the payments review on 26/6, Refill launch moves to 9 September to accommodate the migration to Marrowbone. Comms updated. No change to Q4 forecast.

She read it twice, standing in the kitchen, no coffee made.

Not the five weeks. The date. *The payments review on 26/6.* A review had happened. A real one, with minutes in it and a decision in it, and she was finding out now, in a bullet, because to the nine people in that room there had been nothing to tell.

She had been in Rotterdam on the twenty-sixth of June.

By 7:20 she had established that the decision was right, and that was the part that frightened her. Marrowbone was better. The incumbent had failed twice in June. Their tokenisation would be a problem in Germany by spring. Gareth ran it, Tom sat in it, the analysis was sound.

And it moved the biggest thing Bellwether was doing this year by five weeks, and nobody walked it past the person who owned the number it landed on, because owning the number was not on anyone's job description except hers.

She stood at the island. Her weight went onto the ball of her left foot. The foot turned out a few degrees, heel down.

Her body did this four times a year. At sinks. In lifts. On station platforms. She never caught it until after.

She caught it. She stopped. She made the coffee.

• • •

She had danced until she was eleven.

Tuesdays and Saturdays, a church hall in Amersham that smelled of hymn books and radiators. A Russian woman called Mrs Volkova who shouted and smelled of hairspray. Kate somewhere in the middle of the class — good, she thought, though there was nobody left to ask — and in the second half, when her body stopped asking permission.

One dinner she still had whole, like a photograph you did not choose to take.

She was nine. She came to the table with a certificate. A real one, distinction, her name in a teacher's italic. Her mother read it and was delighted, warmly, the whole table lifting a degree with the pleasure of it.

“Katherine. That's wonderful.”

And then, still smiling, in the same breath, reaching for the water: “And how's the maths coming? Because it's the maths that's the mountain, isn't it.”

There was no cruelty in it. Kate spent four sessions with a therapist in 2019 defending exactly that — *they were warm, they were interested, nobody was ever cold* — in a voice she could hear going too fast. Her mother had not withheld praise. She had moved the line the moment Kate reached it, without malice, because in that house the line was not a place you arrived at. It was a direction you faced.

The Saturday class went first, for the eleven-plus tutor. The tutor went well. Then the scholarship. The scholarship wanted maths and maths was Tuesday.

Nobody stopped her dancing. There was no scene. There was a diary. There was a list of what mattered. Dancing slid quietly down it, and one afternoon in March she noticed she

had not been in five weeks and that nobody in the house had remarked on it.

She had not been to a class since. She was forty-one. She could still, at a kitchen island at twenty past seven in the morning, feel exactly where her weight ought to be.

• • •

9:15. Gareth in her office. She did it properly, because she had learned to do it properly.

“The decision’s right.” She meant it. “The analysis is good. I’d have made the same call. I’m not asking whether it’s real. I’m asking who decided that five weeks of Refill was the price, and whether they knew what Refill was worth.”

“It came out of the review, Kate. It’s the migration window, we can’t—”

“I know we can’t. That’s not the question.” She heard herself. She did not stop. “Nine people moved the biggest thing we do this year. Not one of them owns the number it lands on. Nobody thought that was worth a phone call.”

Gareth Pryce was forty-eight and had been a CTO at two companies before this one and did not deserve the temperature in the room.

“Then the process—”

“The process is fine. Nobody did anything wrong.”

True. The most honest sentence she would say all week. Gareth heard it as a threat, and was right to.

After he left she stood at the window. Then she sat down, opened the operating rhythm document, and did the thing.

She added herself to the weekly platform sequencing call. Gareth's call, Tuesdays, forty minutes.

Then a new item. A Thursday half-hour. Any decision that moved a date on a top-ten initiative got walked past her first.

She typed the second one and felt a physical relief. A strap pulled tight.

At the bottom she added: *Temporary — through Q4.*

She believed it. She had believed the identical line in November, about the pricing forum, which she still chaired.

Dawn's reply came in four minutes.

That's two more standing commitments in a week where you asked me to find twenty minutes with Harriet and I took it out of your lunch. Saying it out loud.

Noted, Kate wrote. Do it anyway.

Doing it.

14:00. Harriet Nash rang about the summit agenda, and in the last ninety seconds, in the voice she kept for weather and for warnings: "Everyone's terribly excited about Refill for the August peak."

There was the door.

Two weeks to the summit. A chief executive could have said, calmly, on a Wednesday afternoon: *it's moved to September, here's why, it's the right call — and while I've got you, twenty-two isn't going to happen, and I'd like to do that properly, with a plan, not badly, in a corridor.*

"There's a payments migration in front of it," Kate said. "I'll walk the board through the sequencing at the summit."

"Lovely," said Harriet. "You're a machine."

12:36, Thursday. A car going east. She recorded a voice message to Sasha and Bea.

She was good at these. Voice messages were the only communication left with any of her actual voice in it, and she spent them like a currency about to be devalued.

“Right. So. I know. I *know*. Don’t say anything, I can hear you both saying it. Here’s the thing about Thursday.” A lorry pulled out and Vasyl made a small noise of professional contempt. “The summit runs Thursday to Sunday, the board join at the end, Harriet wants a pre-read a week out, so the whole thing has to be finished by the fifth, which means Thursday is —”

She stopped. She rewound nothing. The message kept running.

“Look. I’m not going to make Thursday. I’ll make the next one. Actually don’t book the next one around me. Book it and I’ll come, and if I don’t come you’re allowed to be properly angry rather than the nice kind of angry you both do, which is worse. I love you. I’m the worst. Bye.”

She listened to it back before sending, which she never did with work messages. Then she sent it.

The replies came before the Blackwall Tunnel. Sasha sent a GIF of a woman sighing. Bea sent: *third time K*.

Then, four minutes later, because Bea was constitutionally unable to leave a thing sharp: *joking. come whenever. love you.*

Kate looked at *third time K*. A notification came in over the top of it about the Ocean Group. By the time she surfaced they were at the warehouse.

The problem she had not solved, two weeks away, went like this.

Bellwether had grown twenty-two per cent a year for four years. The board had accordingly written down a number for next year that assumed twenty-two per cent again. The number was not achievable. Kate knew it was not achievable and had known since March.

Three ways to say so.

Early. Which looks like managing expectations, which is the phrase people use to describe a chief executive beginning to fail.

Late. Worse.

Or bring a plan so obviously right that the number changes shape while everyone is looking at the plan.

She did not have the plan. She had four days of work stacked behind the summit, a folder of half-built versions, and the growing unfamiliar sickening sense that this was a problem she could not outwork.

She had never once, in twenty years, failed to outwork a problem.

• • •

17:02. Dawn Fowler put her coat on.

Kate saw it from across the floor and something in her went very still, the way it did four times a year.

Dawn packed her bag. A laptop she would not open. A lunchbox. A second lunchbox. The second lunchbox went onto Kate's desk on the way past.

“That’s the aubergine thing. You said you liked it. It’s better the second day, so don’t eat it tonight, eat it tomorrow, which you won’t.”

“I’ll eat it tomorrow.”

“You’ll eat it at eleven o’clock tonight standing up.” Dawn was already turning. “Marcus has got football and Elsie’s got a thing where I have to buy a shoebox. Not shoes. The box.” She stopped at the top of the stairs. “The Harriet twenty minutes. I’ve got you the eighth, eight-forty. She’s doing it from a car.”

“That’s fine.”

“It’s not fine, it’s a car. But it’s twenty minutes.” Dawn looked at her for slightly longer than the exchange required. “Are you all right?”

“Fine,” said Kate. “Big fortnight.”

“Big fortnight,” Dawn agreed, and went down the stairs and out through the doors, away into a life with a shoebox in it.

Kate stood at the window and watched the top of Dawn’s head cross the car park, and had a thought so unwelcome she put it away before finishing it. Something about how one of them was leaving and one of them was staying, and only one of them had a reason that would survive being said out loud.

Then the phone went. Ocean Group. The thought was gone.

• • •

21:40. The cleaners came out of the lift with the trolley. The woman whose name Kate had asked for twice and lost twice said “All right?” and Kate said “All right,” and the vacuum started up at the far end of the floor like weather coming in.

The tupperware sat unopened. At 22:20 she ate it standing up.

She read the version of the plan she had written on Sunday and thought was good. It was not good. It was a way of saying *we will try harder*, dressed up. She deleted a slide.

She wrote a note to herself in the doc — *the number is wrong, say the number is wrong* — and deleted that too. Documents in a company are not private. And she was not ready to have written it down.

23:14. She opened next week's calendar and looked at it the way a person looks at a wall.

She typed: *Dawn — sorry, I know. Can we get Ocean and the ops review into next week somewhere.*

She deleted *sorry, I know*. It was eleven at night and an apology would only make Dawn feel she had to reply.

She sent: *Dawn — Ocean and the ops review need to be next week. Anywhere.*

Delivered. Nobody read it. The person it was sent to was asleep in a house with a shoebox in it.

Kate put the phone face down.

Forty seconds later she turned it back over.

2. Football

The office had a sound and the sound was the air handling.

A long slow animal breathing somewhere above the ceiling tiles. You stopped hearing it around nine and heard it again around eight. After midnight it dropped a tone and a half and went quieter, and that was the version Alex Wójcik knew best.

Forty desks. A wall with VELUM on it in letters two metres high and, underneath, smaller, in a different hand, *ship it*.

He worked with his shoes off.

He had moved desk twice in two years, once because of people and once because of a laptop charger two seats down that sat a semitone under the building and beat against it every nine seconds. Eleven days of that. Then he picked up his monitor and moved. He had explained why, once, because he was asked, and it had gone into the company as a funny thing about Alex.

Tuesday.

• • •

There was a fault in the interceptor.

He had known for five months, in the way of a tooth that is going to need work. Four thousand lines of C, most of them written in eleven days two years ago in a state he had never been able to get back to, and thirty-one million dollars of other

people's money sitting on top of them like a cathedral on a canoe. It ran on nine customers' machines. One of the nine was a payments company, and the payments company ran it on the boxes that did the second leg of a card authentication, which were the hottest boxes anybody had.

It was not a crash. It was worse than a crash. Once in about a million teardowns, on a machine that happened to be running hot, two things that had never in eighteen months arrived in the wrong order arrived in the wrong order.

Fenella asked him at the kettle how the hunt was going.

"It's not the barrier," he said. "The barrier's correct. That's the annoying part. Everything in there is correct."

"So what's wrong with it?"

"Nothing's wrong with it."

She waited for a moment to see whether that was a joke.

"Well," she said. "Good luck."

• • •

The deciding meeting was Thursday, and Alex was right, and lost.

Build the multi-tenant control plane now — six weeks, two engineers, the thing that would let them sell to companies with more than one subsidiary. Or the compliance reporting module, which took two weeks, looked spectacular in a demo, and was, in his private and precise judgement, a mannequin.

He had prepared. That was the part he came back to at two in the morning. This time, for once, he had actually fought.

He had written it out the night before in the small square handwriting he had had since he was fourteen. Four

numbered points and a diagram. He made all four. He got the whole argument into the room, out loud, in order, which for him was close to a personal record. The control plane wasn't a feature, it was the shape of the thing. The report would sell to companies they physically could not then serve. Every customer it won would arrive in Q4 with subsidiaries and a wall.

"Can I just—" said Saul, twice, and both times Alex said "hang on, one more," and kept going, and the second time his voice did something he had not heard from it before, which was to get slightly louder rather than quieter.

He finished.

There was a pause. He could feel that he had landed it. For a moment he thought he had won.

"That's completely right," said Ben Farrow.

And then Ben talked for four minutes about timing.

It was good. None of it contradicted anything Alex had said, and that was the trouble. It accepted the whole argument and set it gently to one side, the way a chair is moved. Q4 was a risk they'd be lucky to have. February was a certainty. A platform is what you call an engine after somebody has paid for it.

By the end the room's centre of gravity had gone. There was no vote. There was never a vote.

"Alex, you're the one who has to build it — what do you think?"

"I mean. We can do the compliance thing quickly."

"That's what I thought too," said Ben warmly.

It was minuted as *compliance module, 2 sprints, Alex to scope*. A minute later Ben went past and put a hand on his shoulder and said, "Good meeting."

That night he was alone in the office, the way he was two or three nights a week. Far lights off, one lamp. The building down a tone and a half.

The extractor over the kitchen had been rattling since March.

It was not loud. It was a dry knock every four or five seconds where something in the housing had come adrift, and it went through the floor and into the desks, and he had raised it with the office manager in March and again in May, and in May she had said she would chase it, and had chased it.

He got a screwdriver out of the drawer where the chargers went to die and stood on a chair.

The cover came off in one piece and hung by its own weight on the last screw, and inside it was exactly what he had thought it would be for five months, which was nothing dramatic at all, a bracket with two fixings and one of them backed out about four turns and the whole assembly hanging on its friction and knocking against the flange every time the blade passed a particular point in its rotation, and he stood on the chair with his head and one shoulder inside the housing and turned the fixing until it stopped, and then a quarter turn more, and then took the blade in two fingers and moved it through a full revolution to hear the whole circle of it, and there was nothing, and he did it again to be sure, and there was nothing, and he came down off the chair and stood in the middle of the dark kitchen with the screwdriver in his hand and listened to a building that had one fewer thing wrong with it than it had had eleven minutes earlier, and nobody would ever know, and nobody would ever mention it, and the pleasure of that went through him like something warm gone down too fast.

He was still standing there when he saw it.

Not the fan. The other thing, the five-month thing, arriving sideways from underneath the way they always did, ninety seconds after he had stopped hunting for it and while his hands were full of somebody else's screwdriver.

He went back to the desk.

It took the rest of the night, because he did it the plodding way, being stubborn at it, the seventy-minute state never coming back on demand. He took the lock out. He drew the two threads on paper with their little vertical strokes and went looking for the gap and could not build one, and tried for a long time to build one, and could not, and that was the best part of the whole night.

Nobody would ever know that had been broken either.

The fix went into a branch called *teardown-order*. The next release was the compliance module, and the one after that was the compliance module, and he did not ask for a slot.

• • •

The notebook took nouns. That was not a rule he had made, it was a rule he had noticed, going back through the four of them. *Teardown, recount, ordering. Quiesce. Arena, then bump, then never free.* Names of things. In three years there were two sentences in it.

He got it out and sat with the pen a long time and wrote the third.

I was right today and it didn't matter, and I need to work out whether that's because I was wrong.

• • •

The estate behind Roman Road had a strip of grass between two blocks that everybody called the pitch. From four o'clock every afternoon of his childhood it had fourteen or nineteen boys on it and the noise came up through the window of the flat like something boiling.

"Alek. Go out."

"I'm doing something."

"You're always doing something. Go out and do something with legs."

The something was a Compaq Presario his father had brought home in the boot of a Vauxhall from a print works that was throwing out four of them. Three worked. The fourth did not, and Marek Wójcik, who could rewire a flat and rebuild a gearbox and could not spell the word *rebuild*, put the broken one on the kitchen table in front of his eight-year-old son and said, in Polish:

"This one's yours. It doesn't work."

It took eleven weeks.

Somewhere in the eighth week he understood a thing he was never afterwards able to explain to anybody without their face going polite. The machine was not withholding anything. Everything it did, it did for a reason, and the reason was findable, and when you found it the reason was simply there, and did not change depending on how you had asked.

On the pitch he was the small one with the accent his parents had and he did not, picked eleventh out of fourteen. Once — properly, actually — he scored, and turned round into a silence in which a boy called Dean said, "Off Robbie's leg."

It went into the record as off Robbie's leg. No referee. No replay. No reason. A room deciding.

He went back inside. He went back inside on a great many afternoons, and his mother stood in the kitchen doorway with a tea towel and reported him to his father like a symptom.

"He's inside again."

And his father, not looking up, doing nights at the bakery on Bethnal Green Road and days at the print works, eight years in and two to go:

"Leave him. He's building something."

Four words. It cost Marek Wójcik nothing to say and everything to be able to say.

• • •

The second time was smaller and worse.

The following Tuesday. A design session about how the agent would carry state across a restart, and Alex had drawn the thing he had been turning over for a month.

He said it well to begin with.

"You don't keep the state at all. You keep the *inputs*, in order, and run them again on restart. Then there's nothing to corrupt, because there's nothing left to be wrong — there's a log and a function. It's slower to start and it can never lie to you. That's the whole trade, and it's the right way round for us, because what kills us in the field is state that's quietly wrong six weeks later."

He could feel it being good. The rare physical sensation of a sentence leaving his mouth in the shape it had held in his head.

“Right,” said Ben, already up and moving to the board, which was how it started. Red pen. A box drawn around what Alex had drawn. “So the way I’d frame this is — do we need it now, or is it a v2 thing? It’s elegant, genuinely. But the customer never sees a restart, and we’ve got forty people and a runway that ends in February, and I don’t want to gold-plate the engine while the thing that closes deals sits in a backlog.”

The room settled. Alex watched it happen. Saul leaning back. Fenella turning her laptop round. A pen going down.

He had one move left. He knew what it was, because he had made it before. *Ben, hang on, give me ninety seconds and nobody talk.* It worked. It cost him hours of the afterwards, lying awake replaying the faces of people who had watched him ask a grown man for silence in his own company.

“So—” he said.

Ben turned. Pen down. Open, and willing to wait however long it took. Every face came round.

It was the patience that did it.

“So the thing is that it isn’t gold-plating, it’s the difference between an engine that fails loud and one that fails quiet, and the quiet one is the one that—”

He heard the volume go out of his own voice in real time. The sentence trailing toward a word he had not chosen yet.

“—it’s fine,” he said. “Never mind. It’s a v2 thing. You’re right.”

“You sure?”

“Yeah.”

“Good man,” said Ben, and clapped him lightly on the arm, and the meeting ended eleven minutes early, which everybody was pleased about.

He sat at his desk afterwards, not working, turning the notebook over in his hands without opening it.

Above the ceiling tiles the air handling went on with its long slow breathing, and one floor over, in the kitchen, the extractor ran without a knock in it, and no one in the building had said a word about that either.

. . .

They rang that evening, both at once, from different distances, the way they did.

“Ale! We booked it. The flights. Marek said don’t tell him until it’s booked, so — it’s booked. The fourteenth.”

“The fourteenth of this month?”

“Two weeks!” His mother’s voice went up. “We come Saturday morning, we stay at the hotel by you — no, not by you, we found one, Marek found one, it’s cheap—”

“Send me the link.”

She sent the link. He looked at it standing on Old Street with a finger in one ear.

“Mama. That’s Birmingham, Alabama.”

“What?”

“It’s in America. The one you’ve booked is in America.”

A long pause. Then, distantly, his mother saying to his father, in Polish, “He says it’s in America,” and his father saying something back, and his mother returning: “Papa says how can it be in America if it’s twenty-nine pounds.”

“Don’t book anything. I’ll book you into the one where the thing is.”

“No, no, no. Too expensive.”

“Mama.” He was already on the site. “There’s an offer.”

So he booked The Ardenne and lied about the price, and his mother said, “Twenty-nine pounds?” and Alex said, “There was an offer,” and his mother said, “You see, Marek! An offer!”

Then his father, close to the phone now, four words at a time.

“You will have time. For us. That weekend. You are not too busy.”

“I’m not too busy.”

“Because if you are busy, we come anyway, we sit in the hotel. It’s fine.”

“Papa. I’m not too busy.”

“Good,” said Marek. “Because your mother has bought a coat for this.” A pause. Then, flat and clear, the way it always was: “How is the work.”

Alex looked around him. Traffic going past. The office behind him with forty desks in it and the wall with VELUM on it. Thirty-one million dollars of other people’s money and four thousand lines of C and a decision taken past him with a hand on his shoulder.

“It’s great,” he said. “It’s going really well.”

There was a pause on the line of exactly the length that meant his father had heard him.

“Good,” said Marek Wójcik. “That’s good.”

3. Deep Breath

Lauriston had been founded in 1786 by two brothers who fell out soon afterwards, and the bank had been managing disagreement quietly ever since; and on the fourth floor of its headquarters, in an office that had once belonged to a man with a knighthood, Michael Halloway approved things.

He began that morning with a statement of work for the branch-estate programme, of which he read the schedule of rates and the termination clause and nothing else; for he had learned long ago that a statement of work is a poem about money, and that only two of its stanzas are load-bearing.

He signed it. He watched the little animation of the signature going on.

Then he sat back, and took a long breath in through his nose, and let it out.

There was a call from Group Risk about a supplier, in which he said the sentence he had been saying in one form or another for most of his career — *we're not going to solve this in this call, so let's agree what would make us able to solve it in the next one* — and heard the relief come down the line, and put the phone down.

He breathed in. He breathed out.

At 8:27, on a one-page note, he approved the repricing of the commercial overdraft book, forty basis points across the whole of it; the only sentence in the note that mattered was

the one about the letter, which would use the word *partnership* twice, since somebody had established that this reduced complaints.

He breathed in, and out.

He declined a request to sit on a steering group; and then, a few minutes later, having thought about who had asked and what it would cost her to be declined, accepted it after all, which is a different and worse thing than saying yes in the first place.

Breathed in. Breathed out.

The morning went on in that manner until the review.

• • •

The programme review was at ten, in Cathedral, the big room, with the screen that never worked first time.

There were too many people in it, and Michael had said so, and had been told that this was a matter of inclusion in the change journey, a phrase that had come into the bank some years before in the manner of Japanese knotweed and had since gone under the foundations. He sat halfway down the long side, because sitting at the head makes people perform; and he made a joke about the screen while Callum Deitch fought it, and got his laugh, and the screen came on.

Callum Deitch was thirty-four and extremely good. Michael wished, with an old man's unrepeatable envy, that he were less good, so that this would be easier.

"So, just to level-set for everyone," Callum said, "Atlas is the migration of the core ledger off the mainframe. We're in wave two. Wave two is retail current accounts, and the cutover

window is the August bank holiday, which gives us seventy-two hours.”

Seventy-one, thought Michael. *You lose an hour to the freeze at the front and you never get it back, and everybody said seventy-two last time as well.*

“Wave one delivered in March, slightly behind plan—”

Nine weeks behind plan.

—and the critical path runs through the settlement interface, which is the piece that talks to the payments gateway.”

The Ledger Gap. We have called it the Ledger Gap for ten years, and it is still there, and up a third since June, and nobody at this table has asked why.

“The three amber items are data quality in the dormant-account population, vendor resourcing for the September window, and the interface spec sign-off, which is — Michael, actually, that one’s with you.”

The faces turned, politely, at the speed of a wave going round a stadium.

“It’s on my desk,” Michael said. “It’ll be back to you Friday.”

“Brilliant. So the RAG status overall we’ve kept at amber-green—”

Michael had built the settlement interface. Not the code; but in 2013 he had sat in a room like this one with a whiteboard and drawn the shape of the thing, and had argued for it against a Group CIO who wanted to buy something instead, and had won, and had been right; and a decade later the bank still ran on the drawing. He knew the dormant-account problem down to the year the data went bad. He knew the vendor resourcing was not amber but red, because he knew what that

vendor's office looked like in September, when the graduates arrive.

He could have said all of it in ninety seconds; the room would have gone very quiet; and Callum Deitch would have had a bad afternoon.

He let him finish.

He let him finish for two reasons, and the first was the reason he would have given had anybody asked: that a thirty-four-year-old presenting his own programme in front of a full room should not be corrected by the chief operating officer, since he will present it worse for the rest of his life. That reason was genuine. Michael had believed it for years, and had built two careers on it, including Terry Nwosu's.

The second reason was that Michael was tired. Not sleepy; tired in the joints of the thing, tired in the place where the willingness lives. To say it he would have had to gather himself, and to gather himself in front of that room would have shown them what it cost to gather himself; and he would rather have been shot than let that room see how tired he was, and how fed up, and how long it had been since he last cared what colour the RAG status was.

So he sat, and nodded at the correct moments; and at the end, when the pack was closing and there was a shuffle of laptops, he heard himself begin a sentence.

"Callum. The vendor resourcing—"

The faces came back round.

He had, at that moment, the whole of it available to him: the two names worth ringing, the fact that he could pick up a telephone that afternoon and have the thing solved by the end of the week, and that solving it would put him back inside a programme he had drawn the shape of and had not been con-

sulted on since the spring. It would have taken one sentence. He had said harder ones in worse rooms.

“—it’s the graduate intake, isn’t it. Watch the second week of September.”

“Noted,” said Callum, writing it down. “Thank you.”

“Good pack,” said Michael. “Send me the dormant-account numbers; I’ve got a feeling about the 2009 tranche.”

Which was, at least, a door left open in a wall.

He waited until the room emptied. Then he sat for a moment at the long table with the screen still glowing behind him, and took a breath in, and let it out, and went to lunch.

• • •

Lunch was a sandwich at his desk, and the post.

Actual post; Lauriston still had it, in a wire tray, brought round by a man called Errol who had been doing it for years and had a system for which floors got theirs first that nobody had ever formally approved. A charity thing. A wine merchant. A brochure from a wealth manager who had somehow got hold of his date of birth and had put on the front, in a serif font, *The next chapter deserves a plan*, which Michael read twice, then dropped in the bin from a height; then, after a moment, took out of the bin and put in a drawer.

And the invitation.

Heavy card, embossed, the kind that exists so that a conference can charge two thousand a head. *The Ardenne, Birmingham. The Banking Operations Forum. We would be honoured if you would deliver the closing keynote. Forty minutes, at two o’clock on the Monday, the last afternoon of it:*

which is a graveyard slot dressed in a dinner jacket, and Michael knew it, and was not certain that he minded.

He turned it over. On the back, in biro: *Michael — they asked for you by name. It'd be nice for the bank. F.*

Fiona Redgrave, chief executive, who wrote on the back of things in biro.

Michael read the sentence *they asked for you by name*, and something happened in his chest that he chose not to look at directly, and that was not pleasure.

He thought about it. If he went up for the whole of the forum he would be away the best part of a week; and there was nothing in it he could not move; and the alternative to being at The Ardenne was being in this building, and the two of those, laid side by side, were not close.

He wrote *Delighted — MH* under the biro, and put it in the tray for Errol.

• • •

In the spring of 1975 a man came to the house in Watford and put a sticker on the television.

Michael was thirteen. He remembered the sticker better than he remembered his father's face that year: a printed label about the size of a playing card, gummed onto the top-right corner of the screen where you could see it from the sofa. It stayed there eleven days. Nobody in the house said anything about it. His mother went on wiping around it.

His father had been a partner, one of three, in a builders' merchant on the Dunstable Road. Halloway & Grieves. There had been a van with the name on it, and Michael had once

been allowed to ride in the van, standing up, holding the dashboard, which in 1971 was a thing that could happen to a boy.

What Michael did not learn until he was nineteen was that all three partners had signed personal guarantees on the overdraft, which is a sentence that means nothing at all until it means everything. When the property market went over in 1974, and the builders stopped paying and then stopped existing, the firm went down owing forty-one thousand pounds. The largest of the builders had been a consortium putting up a conference hotel beside the new exhibition centre outside Birmingham, twelve storeys of it, which Halloway & Grieves had supplied on ninety days' credit through the whole of 1973; it stopped paying in the February and stopped existing in 1976, and nineteen thousand of the forty-one was its. And the bank — some bank, some quiet, decent, reasonable bank — went to the guarantees.

They lost the house in the November. They moved to a maisonette in Bushey with a smell in the hall.

The thing he carried was not the maisonette. It was two things, and he had never told anyone either of them, including Ruth, in forty years of marriage.

The first was that his father, Ken Halloway, who had been a loud man, a man who sang in the car, stopped talking at meals. Not sulking; Michael had understood at the time that it was not sulking, and had not had the word for what it was, and had it now. It was arithmetic. He was doing arithmetic, at the table, all the way through dinner, every dinner, for two years.

The second was that Michael, aged thirteen, sitting at that table, had made himself a promise with the total, stupid, unbreakable seriousness of a child, and had then gone and kept

it for half a century. The promise had no words at the time. If you made him put words to it now he would say something like: *nobody at my table is ever going to have to do that sum.*

He went into a bank at twenty-two. Not because he liked banks; because a bank was the largest, dumbest, slowest, most survivable thing he could find, and they paid on the same day every month, and there was a pension, and there was no guarantee on earth that anybody could ask him to sign.

Forty-two years. Three institutions. Two mergers survived, one restructure run, six hundred and forty people made redundant by his signature over the years, and every one of them, he had made sure, with the outplacement and the extra month. He had never once been out of work. He had never once been overdrawn. He had put two children through school and a daughter through a wedding, and had bought a house in 1994 that was now worth an amount of money that embarrassed him; and he had, at sixty-four, precisely the life that a boy in a maisonette in Bushey had set out to build.

He had also, it turned out, missed most of it.

• • •

Keynote — draft.

The cursor had been sitting in that document for nine days.

He had a structure. Getting a structure was easy; he had watched a great many people present a great many things, and could build a forty-minute arc out of nothing in an afternoon. *Where we've been* — the operational history of retail banking since the branch closures started, which he could do drunk. *Where we are* — the cost line, the third-party risk, the fact

that every bank in the room was running its actual business on something written when the audience's junior staff were unborn. Both were written; both were good; and there was a joke in the second one about the mainframe that would land in a room like that the way a joke lands in a room that is frightened.

And then the third section, which every keynote of this kind has, and which the organiser had actually named for him in a bullet in a Word document: *A closing reflection — why we do this.*

He typed: *So why do we do this.*

He looked at it. He typed: *I've been asked that question a lot recently, and* — and deleted *recently*, because nobody had asked him; and typed *a lot over the years*; and then deleted the whole line.

He got up and made a coffee. At his desk with the coffee he tried the honest version, on the grounds that honest usually opens the door to something usable, and typed: *I do this because when I was thirteen a man put a sticker on our television.*

Which was true, and unusable; and also — this was the part that made him sit back and look out of the window at the top of a crane over towards Bishopsgate — no longer a complete answer.

Because there was a question underneath it that he had never once, in half a century, permitted onto the agenda, and it went like this. Suppose the boy had been asked. Suppose you could have sat the thirteen-year-old down at that table in Bushey and said: *right, here's the deal. You will never be poor. Nobody at your table will ever do that sum. In exchange, you will spend the years between thirty and sixty in*

rooms; and your daughter will grow up in the gaps between them; and you will become extremely good at something that will not, in the end, need you.

Would the boy have taken it?

Yes, obviously. Instantly. The boy would have taken it before you finished the sentence.

And was he right?

That was the question; and Michael, sincerely, at sixty-four years old, with a document open in front of him and a conference in two weeks, did not know the answer. He could not get it to come out the same way twice. Some days he ran it and it came out *of course he was right, look at Claire, look at the house, look at the fact that nobody in this family has ever been frightened of a letter*; and other days he ran it and it came out, quietly, in the voice you use for things you are not going to act on: *he bought forty years of safety with the only forty years there were.*

A man who does not know why he does something cannot write four hundred words about it in a Word document.

He typed: *We do this because*

At 11:04 he got up and went to a meeting about card fraud; and at 11:52 he came out of it; and at 11:53 he stopped in the corridor with his hand on the wall and took a long breath in and let it out, and went to the next one.

. . .

Alan Weir got into the lift with him at three that afternoon, going down, holding a cardboard cup.

“You in the Atlas review this morning?”

“I was.”

“Any good?”

“Callum’s very good,” said Michael.

“He is, isn’t he.” Alan pressed the button for the ground floor, which was already lit. “They’re putting him up for the Group thing, apparently. The transformation office. Well — you’d know better than me.”

Michael watched the numbers.

“I don’t, actually,” he said, pleasantly. “Nobody’s mentioned it.”

There was a floor and a half of silence, which in a lift is a considerable amount of silence; and then Alan said, “Ah, it’s probably nothing. You know what it’s like now, everything’s decided in a call you’re not on.” He laughed. “Half my job is finding out what I’ve agreed to.”

“That’s the best half,” said Michael. “The other half is doing it.”

Alan laughed properly at that, and got out still laughing.

Fiona Redgrave caught him by the lifts at ten past four. She was carrying her shoes, which she did about once a fortnight, and which the entire fourth floor found so humanising that Michael had privately wondered for two years whether it was deliberate, and had concluded that it was not, and that this was precisely why it worked.

“You’re doing the Ardenne thing.”

“I am. Thank you for the biro.”

“I meant it. They did ask for you by name. Colin somebody rang me up and said—” she did an impression, quite a good one, of a man being emphatic on a telephone “—*we’d like Halloway, he’s the only one of you lot who tells the truth about operations.*”

“He should hear my forecasts.”

“He probably has.” She pressed the button. “How’s the speech?”

“Going beautifully. Practically finished. I’ve written the whole of the middle and both edges.”

Fiona laughed; a proper laugh, used economically, which made it worth something. “Michael. Can I say a thing.”

“That’s never a question.”

“You have been — genuinely — the reason this place has held together for the last six years. I don’t say it enough because you make a joke every time and then I feel silly. Atlas is a disaster in nine other banks and it’s amber-green here, and the reason is that in 2013 you drew that thing on a whiteboard and refused to buy the American one.” The lift came. She let it go. “You’re the soul of this bank. Truly. Everyone knows it.”

And here, again, was the sentence, standing open in front of him: *Fiona, put me on the transformation office. Not to run it. To be asked.*

“Well,” said Michael, “the soul doesn’t have to do the RAG report.”

Fiona laughed again, and got in the next lift, and went down.

He stood there.

The thing about a compliment, he thought, is that it has a tense.

You have been. Not *you are*. And *the soul of this bank* — he turned it over the way he had turned over a hundred board papers, looking for the load-bearing sentence, and found it: that a soul does not appear on an org chart, and cannot be assigned an outcome, and is not something you would consult about the

Group transformation office, or the promotion of Callum Deitch, or, come to that, the shape of next year.

She had told him the truth. That was the trouble. She had told him, warmly and sincerely and in her own time, that he was deeply respected; and he ran the sentence twice more standing by the lifts and could not find, anywhere in it, the word *needed*.

He went back to his office and sat down and read the last line of the document, which said *We do this because*; and then closed the laptop, and put both hands flat on the desk, and took a breath in, and let it out.

Then he went down, and out through the revolving door into the evening; and on the pavement, out of sight of anyone from the bank, he stopped and took another one, and went to find his train.

4. The Exchange Rate

There is a kind of true that is not honest, and Nikhil Raghavan had made a career of it.

Lodestone had no boardroom. Gus Delaney believed boardrooms made people behave like a board, so the quarterly numbers were given in the games room, standing, at the end of a long table, eighteen inches from a plush rabbit. Behind the rabbit was a cabinet of trophies for games that no longer ran on any hardware you could buy. Nik had priced the cabinet once, on a slow Friday. Two hundred and sixty pounds, and about nine thousand pounds of shelf space at the Guildford rate, and he had never mentioned either figure to anybody, because there is no way to say that sentence and come out of it well.

Four numbers on the slide. Every one correct.

“Cash at quarter-end, eleven-two. Runway on current burn, fourteen months. That’s before Sunward lands in November, and if it lands on time we’re at nineteen.”

“Nineteen months,” said Gus, to the room, with satisfaction.

“If it lands on time,” said Nik, and went to the next slide before anyone could weigh the *if*.

He had a line ready about the rabbit. He used it. Something about the only board member with tenure — and the video lag took the first three words, and what arrived in the room was a

small noise with no shape on the end of it. Two people smiled a beat late, out of kindness, which is worse than nothing.

A joke that fails costs four seconds, which he had.

And about a tenth of a point of the room, which he did not.

So he did the thing he did. He put a number in front of the silence and let the number carry it, and by the second bullet the room had forgotten there had been a joke, and only one person in it knew there was anything to forget.

The unsaid version went like this. The eleven-two had two-point-four of publisher prepayments in it, and those came back if Sunward slipped past November. The runway assumed a headcount nine people short, and an open role lengthens a runway the way a skipped meal lengthens money. Sunward had been given three dates and had missed three dates.

None of it was a lie. All of it was in the pack, on page nineteen, in a table, correctly labelled, put there by Nik so that it would exist quietly.

He said *healthy* once, about cash. He said *we're comfortable* about the Q3 position. Two words in forty minutes. Each did the work of a small load-bearing wall.

Then Bridget spoke. Bridget had run a studio in Dundee in the nineties and was the only person present who had ever read an appendix.

"Nikhil. The clawback on Sunward. That's the thirtieth of November, is that right?"

Nik felt his whole body go still and warm, the way it does when the thing you have arranged to be invisible turns out to have been visible the entire time.

"That's right. Page nineteen."

"It's a big number."

"It is."

“But you’re relaxed.”

A second, maybe a second and a half. Long enough to say: *no, I’ve been awake at four in the morning since March, I put it at about even, and we should be talking to the publisher now and not in October.*

He looked at Gus on the screen. Gus, who had made a game about a rabbit, and had put his own house into this company in 2016, and had the rabbit behind him on a shelf, watching.

“I’m watchful,” said Nik. “That’s my job. But yes. Relaxed.”

“Good,” said Bridget. “Then I am.”

Gus rang him afterwards, on the phone rather than the video, which he did about twice a year.

“That was excellent. Honestly. You just — you make it feel like there’s a floor under everything. I don’t know how you do it.”

Nik looked at the car park.

“Practice,” he said.

• • •

The rest of the day arrived as numbers, which was the only way anything arrived.

Lauriston renewed the Dublin overdraft forty basis points worse than last year, in a letter that used the word *partnership* twice. Forty points on eight hundred thousand is three thousand two hundred a year. Not a catastrophe. Also a junior QA contractor for a month, and he had both before the second paragraph.

Priyesh sent a forecast revision. He was twenty-eight and thorough, and he had found a marketing accrual sitting in the wrong quarter since March, eleven thousand four hundred of it. He presented this with the shining face of a man who has not yet discovered that being right about the accounts is a hobby and not a career. Nik told him it was good work, and meant it. He watched him leave lit up, and thought about how many years that lasts.

HR wanted the salary bands finalised by Friday. He could not do it. Finalising them meant telling nine people a number, and he had not decided which of two numbers to tell them. Across nine people the gap between the two was thirty-one thousand a year, which is one senior artist, or four hundred pounds a head, depending on which way round you needed it to sound.

Then he went out for a coffee, because he had eaten nothing, and stood in a queue in Pret behind a man explaining to somebody that the flat white here was inconsistent.

He got to the front. He asked for a flat white and a bag of the crisps with the black label.

And the girl at the till said: "Sorry?"

• • •

Nothing had happened. That was true of it either way. She was nineteen and there was a coffee grinder going and a man behind him talking about consistency, and she had not heard the second half of a sentence in a loud room, which is a thing that occurs four hundred times a day in that shop to people from Kent.

He said it again, slightly louder. She got it, and smiled. That was the whole event.

He paid three pounds forty and went and stood outside on the Guildford road with the coffee going cold in his hand, because he was nineteen years old and standing in a room in Croydon.

Five years of it, 1999 to about 2004. He would say a sentence, and there would be a beat, and the other person's face would do a small thing — a fractional leaning-in, nothing rude, nothing anybody could have been accused of — and then *sorry?* And he would say it again, and it would land in the room four seconds late and about ten per cent smaller than the sentences on either side of it.

Four seconds and ten per cent. Forty times a week. For five years.

He had totalled it once, at a desk, in a bad week, and got something over eleven thousand sentences. Then he had stopped, because that is the kind of sum a man does when the sum is not the point.

He tried going quiet first. That cost him a promotion in 2005 to a man called Duncan who was worse than him and had said four thousand things to Nik's sixty. The company was not wrong to do it, either, which he had understood at the time and had never stopped understanding.

So he tried the other thing.

And the other thing worked immediately, which was the disaster. You take a true thing and you press it. Not falsify. *Press*, the way you press a shirt. And it lands, and when it lands nobody leans in, and when nobody leans in nobody says *sorry?*, and the four seconds are gone.

Twenty-six years later a girl in a sandwich shop had not heard him over a grinder, and he had spent three pounds forty and a quarter of an hour of an afternoon standing on a pavement about it.

He put the coffee in a bin without drinking it. Three pounds forty, and he registered the waste, and there was not one single thing he could do about any of it.

• • •

The commute was fifty-one minutes on a good day and had been the honest hour of his life for four years, because nobody could reach him on the A3. After the Wisley interchange the phone lost signal for ninety seconds. He had come to look forward to those ninety seconds the way other men look forward to a drink.

He did the real arithmetic there. Not the studio's. His own.

Take-home after tax and pension, just under seven thousand a month. A number that sounds like the end of a problem and is the beginning of one.

Rent on the house in Woking, twenty-one fifty. A house and not a flat, three bedrooms, because Anaya needed a room and Rohan needed a room and Meera had asked for neither. Nik had decided them.

Anaya's school, eleven-forty a month, chosen when she was six and impossible to undo without explaining to a nine-year-old why she was leaving her friends.

Chennai, nine hundred in a normal month.

The car, the insurance, the nursery days, and a food shop that had climbed from a hundred and sixty a week to two hun-

dred and thirty without anybody agreeing to it and without anybody eating noticeably better. Rohan alone was forty pounds a month, and ate, as far as Nik could establish, four things.

Four hundred pounds left in a good month. Not four hundred of savings. Four hundred of *slack*. The margin between a family and an event.

The boiler was eleven years old.

He was the chief financial officer of a company with eleven million pounds in the bank, and he was about seventeen hundred pounds short, and there was nobody alive he could say it to.

He checked it for self-pity every time, the way you check a bag for keys. It came back a fact about the shape of a life and nothing more. Tell Gus, and he was a CFO with money trouble, a phrase that ends a career regardless of the arithmetic under it. Tell Meera the real version, and she would go back to work with Rohan at three, and the nursery would cost more than the job paid, and she would do it anyway, and he would have to watch her do it.

Signal came back past Ripley. Eleven things arrived at once and he was grateful for all of them.

• • •

Meera was on the sofa with the baby monitor on the arm and her eyes shut, not asleep. Resting with the tension of a woman who expects to be needed in ten minutes.

“He went down at seven. He’ll be up at nine, and again at one.” She opened her eyes. “How was work?”

“Good. Busy. Gus is happy about Sunward.”

“Is Sunward going to be fine?”

“Sunward’s going to be fine.”

She nodded slowly, and looked at him a beat longer than the answer needed, and said, “There’s dal. It’s not very good. Rohan put a car in it.”

They ate. The car had been removed but had left an opinion.

Anaya came down in pyjamas to argue about a school trip. Nik said yes before he heard the price, then heard the price, then said yes again in a slightly different voice.

“It’s fine if it’s too much,” said Anaya, who was nine and had radar.

“It isn’t too much.”

A hundred and forty-five pounds. Thirty-six per cent of the slack. He had the percentage before she was out of the room, and hated having it, and had it.

• • •

The maroon suitcase came down off the wardrobe on the Wednesday with a smell in it that was thirty years old.

There had been two. Bought on the Mount Road in the August of 1999, cheap hard shells, one grey and one maroon, three hundred and forty rupees the pair, which his mother had negotiated over eleven minutes and had described afterwards to four separate people. The grey one died in 2014. This one had a shell scratched matte, a corner crushed by a baggage system in Frankfurt in 2009, and a front left wheel so worn

that the whole case pulled to one side and had to be leaned against, like a difficult dog.

Inside the lid, a fabric name tape, sewn by hand. A woman at the temple had told Shobha Raghavan that bags get swapped at Heathrow. No source, no mechanism, no evidence. It had nonetheless determined the interior fittings of the case that would follow her son for twenty-six years.

His father had come to the airport in the good shirt and said very little. At the gate he pushed an envelope down into Nik's shirt pocket — into the pocket, not the hand, so it could not be given back — and put his palm flat over it, and said, in Tamil:

“Don't call for money. Call for anything else.”

He had never once called for money. He had also never called for anything else, but the instruction had only covered the one.

Anaya sat on the end of the bed with her chin on her fists and watched him fold shirts.

“Appa. Why don't you just buy a new one.”

“There's nothing wrong with this one.”

“The wheel's broken.”

“The wheel isn't broken. The wheel is worn.”

“That's the same thing.” She got up and pulled it two feet across the carpet and it went sideways into the wardrobe door. “See. In Dubai they have suitcases with four wheels. You just push them. They go anywhere.”

“When have you been to Dubai?”

“Sofia went to Dubai.”

“Ah,” said Nik. “Sofia.”

She flumped back onto the bed. “It's not even a nice colour.”

And he opened his mouth to tell her — *this case came here with me, my mother sewed that tape in with her hands, at a table, in a flat you have never seen* — and heard in advance exactly how it would land. The immigrant father. The parable. The story with a moral on the end, handed to a girl in a school uniform who has been asked to feel something on cue. He had done it twice. He had watched her face do the small polite arrangement both times.

“It’s maroon,” he said. “It’s a very good colour. Go and do your reading.”

“It’s *brown*,” said Anaya from the door, having got the last word, which was fair. She had won on the merits.

He stood in the bedroom holding a shirt for a while.

Then he went down and moved seventeen hundred pounds to Chennai out of the account he was not supposed to use for it, and typed in the reference box, as he did every month, the word *ROUTINE* — so that if Meera ever went through the statement it would sit in the column with all the others and not put its hand up.

• • •

At eleven, the house quiet and Rohan not yet awake, he sat at the kitchen table with the laptop and did not open the family budget.

He opened the registration page for the Midlands Open. Five days at a hotel outside Birmingham called The Ardenne. Seven rounds across a long weekend. Entry forty-eight pounds.

He had played it twice. It was the only thing in his year he did not exaggerate about in either direction. He did not tell people at work that he played chess, because he could not have borne their finding it charming. He did not tell his mother he was going, because she would tell the neighbours, and by the second telling he would be in a tournament in London, and by the fourth he would be winning it.

The form wanted a name. The box said FULL NAME AS IT WILL APPEAR ON THE PAIRING SHEET.

Nik sat with his hands over the keys. Then he typed the whole thing, slowly.

Nikhil Raghavan.

Nobody had called him Nikhil at work in six years. He had shortened it himself in 2018, in a meeting in Reading, where a man had said “Nick? Nick-hill? Sorry, mate—” and Nik had said “Nik’s fine,” and it had been fine.

It cost so little at the moment of the transaction that he had not noticed the transaction. He had thought about it perhaps a thousand times since. There is no exchange rate for that. He had looked.

He paid the forty-eight pounds. Two point four per cent of a month’s slack, and the best value in the portfolio.

Then he set up a position on the board in his head — the one he had lost to an old man two years ago from a winning position, because he had spent forty minutes making sure he could not lose — and played it through, both sides, in silence, until a small voice upstairs began to complain about the dark.

5. The Third Time

There is a moment in the setting of concrete, the engineers say, when it is still technically workable and no longer in any real sense wet.

• • •

11:06, Sunday. Tom Ferreira. Which meant it was real. Tom did not ring at eleven for practice.

“We’ve turned off Marrowbone in Germany.”

“Since when?”

“Forty minutes. Their step-up authentication’s failing about one in nine on German cards and we didn’t see it because our alerting’s on the aggregate and Germany’s eleven per cent of volume. It’s not their code. Their step-up hosts run hot, and something under the runtime on them stalls a connection in nine when they do. Their words, not mine.”

“How long’s it been going on?”

A pause. The pause was the answer.

“Since Thursday.”

She was standing. Thursday, Friday, Saturday, Sunday. Four days. The biggest weekend of the month. The number came out of her instantly, and it was large, and she put it down and went to work.

They had Germany back on the incumbent by two in the morning. Good work by tired people, most of whom had been at it since eleven. Priyanka found where it was, which was not in anything Bellwether owned. Tom ran it. Kate did almost none of it, and stayed for all of it.

What Kate did was be there.

The reversals went to Marrowbone, and from Marrowbone to the bank that settled for them, and stopped being hers.

02:10. Alone in the flat. She opened the operating rhythm document and looked at the two review layers she had added a fortnight ago, and thought, with the flat clarity that comes at the end of a night like that: *it isn't enough*.

She added a third.

09:10, Tuesday. She did a thing she had never done in nine years at Bellwether. She asked for a decision to be re-taken.

Small. The warehouse in Kettering, whether the new pick-face layout went in during August or after peak. Operations had decided August. The decision was two weeks old. The racking was ordered.

She got the ops director on a call. "Walk me through it."

He walked her through it. It was a good decision, and by the sixth minute she had stopped listening to the content and was listening to the thing underneath. A competent man in his fifties, explaining to his chief executive, in careful ascending detail, why he had been permitted to do his job.

"Fine. Do it. I just wanted to understand it."

"No, no. Always happy." And then, in the friendly way people say the thing that costs you most: "Do you want me on the racking schedule? I can put you on the distribution."

Yes, said the whole of her body.

“God, no,” said Kate. “You don’t need me on that.”

She thought about it all afternoon. What she thought was: *if I’d been on that distribution I’d have known.* And she watched herself think it. And the watching changed nothing.

A belief had finished forming in her at some point in the last six weeks. She was now simply somebody who held it.

The belief was: *anything I am not personally holding will eventually be dropped.*

Not a mood. She had had moods. This had the texture of arithmetic. The payments review. The German cards. Ocean in March. The returns copy in 2023. Four times she had not been in the room, four things gone wrong.

She never said it aloud. Saying it aloud would have insulted two hundred people who worked very hard.

19:48, Tuesday. She declined a dinner with a woman who ran a much larger business and had been trying to have dinner with her since February.

Then she opened the thread.

Sorry sorry sorry. Can’t do Thursday. Genuinely can’t. Next one, I promise, and I’ll come to you.

Sasha sent a thumbs up.

Bea did not send anything.

Kate looked at that for a while. It was fine. Bea was busy, Bea had a thing, Bea would send something rude in the morning.

Bea sent nothing in the morning either. Four weeks later Kate would notice that the thread had stopped proposing dates, and that this had happened without anybody deciding it, and she would be unable to establish exactly when.

The flat in Bow had a fridge in it and the fridge had a compressor, and on a Sunday with nothing else running you could hear it come in and go out.

Alex found out about the customer call the same Sunday, by accident, in the most boring way imaginable.

He was tidying the shared drive because he could not face the compliance module.

There was a folder called *Marrowbone* with a file in it from Friday, P1 – auth hosts – closed (config), Ben's initials on it. He read it. Two of Marrowbone's hottest machines, a week of one connection in nine stalling on teardown, and a customer's engineer who had used the word *ordering* four times on the Friday call. Closed, config.

He knew what it was. It was on his laptop, in a branch called *teardown-order*, where it had been for eleven days.

Then he opened a folder called *Meridian*. There was a file in it four days old. *Meridian – follow up*, Ben's initials on it, from a Wednesday on which Alex had sat eleven feet from Ben all day and heard nothing about a call.

He read it. It was ordinary. *Meridian* wanted the report. *Meridian* was happy. *Meridian* had asked about multi-tenancy and Ben had said *on the roadmap*.

He texted. *saw the meridian notes – was that a call? did I miss an invite?*

Ben replied inside two minutes, on a Sunday, because Ben always replied.

Ah mate sorry, Suraj rang me direct, 15 min thing, wasn't worth pulling you out of the fix. Should have told you. My bad.

And then, forty seconds later: *Genuinely my bad. Won't happen.*

It was fine.

It was obviously fine. A short inbound call to the CEO on a day Alex was buried in a fix. The apology instant and unasked for.

no worries at all, Alex typed, and sent it.

It was the third time. Each one had been fine.

He sat for a long time with the fridge going. Then it cut out, and the room was louder without it.

At ten past one he merged `teardown-order`, alone, and did not put it in the channel, and the file in the Marrowbone folder went on saying `config`.

He had not opened the notebook in eighteen days.

The ideas had not stopped.

On the Central line on the Monday he had had one, and it arrived whole — because if you stop flushing the audit buffer on an interval and flush it on the quiesce instead, then the cost does not get smaller, the cost *disappears*, it goes into a thing the runtime is already doing and has already paid for, and the interval was only ever there because somebody two years ago wanted a number they could put in a config file and nobody had asked since what the number was buying, and the answer was nothing, the answer was that four months of latency work had been sitting behind a default that a person picked in an afternoon.

He reached for the pocket.

And thought: *what's the point*.

By Liverpool Street it had gone, leaving only the knowledge that there had been one. He tried for a week to get it back. He got the shape of it and never the middle. It was, as far as he could establish, the first idea he had ever lost on purpose.

• • •

Michael's family calendar was a shared one that Ruth had set up in 2019, and to which he had never once added anything.

There it was, in the pale blue that meant Claire: *Iris — piano recital, St Barnabas, 6.30, Sat 27th.*

He knew at once that he wanted to go; that was not the difficulty. The difficulty was what his mind did next, which was to run, faster than thought, a check against the twenty-seventh, and find nothing there — and still not put himself down.

He sat with the remote and worked out why.

In September there had been Sam's assembly, and he had put himself in the calendar on the Sunday; and on the Tuesday night Group Risk had blown up; and at a quarter past eleven on the Wednesday morning he had sent Claire the message, and it had been fine, everyone understood, Claire sent a photograph and three words. But there existed, in the world, a five-year-old boy who had looked at a row of chairs.

And Michael had found a way to be safe from that, which was not to be in the row at all. If he did not put himself down, nobody expected him; and coming was a bonus, and not-coming was nothing.

He had described this to himself for years as *not over-promising*, which was the phrase he used in the office for the same manoeuvre; and it had the great advantage of being, in its own terms, true.

Ruth came in with tea and looked at the screen over his shoulder; and Michael, who had spent forty years reading a room for a living, found that he could not read this one, and did not try.

"You're not on it."

“There’s a chance the Ardenne thing runs over.”

“The Ardenne thing’s on the Monday.”

“They do a follow-up. There’s usually a follow-up.”

Ruth put the tea on the coaster, and looked at the back of his head for a moment, and said, “Right,” and went out.

On the Wednesday he heard his own laugh from the outside.

It was in the atrium at lunchtime, with four from Treasury; and somebody did the line about the chief executive and the boat, and Michael supplied the follow-up he had been carrying for a fortnight, and the four of them went up like a struck match. And Michael laughed too, and heard it — coming from somewhere out to his left, about a foot away, a bark with a rise on the end, a convincing noise made by a professional — and stood in the middle of the atrium with a plate in his hand and thought, with total detachment: *whose laugh is that*.

The group broke up. Vanessa Okoro stayed behind, and said, in a different register: “How are you, though?”

There are perhaps four people in any organisation who will ask that with the *though* on the end, which is the load-bearing word; the *though* means *I have noticed something, and I am giving you a door*. She was in a hurry and she had stayed behind to use it.

Michael took a small breath.

“Well,” he said, “I’m about to write four hundred words on why banking is meaningful, so — physically I’m fine, spiritually I’m on a ventilator.”

Vanessa laughed. She really laughed; she put a hand on his arm. “Send it to me. I’ll tell you if it’s rubbish.”

“You’ll tell me it’s marvellous and then not come.”

“That is exactly what I’ll do,” she said, delighted, and went.

And Michael stood there holding the plate.

It had taken about a second and a half, and he had done it without deciding to; and the extraordinary thing — the thing he turned over on the train that evening and could not put down — was that he had felt *relief*. Physical relief, at the sound of her laughing.

• • •

They rang Nik at twenty to ten, which was past two in the morning in Chennai, which meant his parents had waited up.

“Nikhil. Listen — the hospital wants the whole thing in advance. Not just the operation. The physiotherapy, twelve weeks, they’ve put it in a package. Appa says it’s too much.”

“How much.”

“One lakh sixty more.”

One lakh sixty. Fifteen hundred and twenty pounds, plus the fee, plus the spread they took and did not print, call it fifteen eighty by the time it landed. He had it before she finished the sentence, in three currencies, and as a fraction of the boiler, which was two-fifths of a boiler.

“That’s fine,” said Nik.

“It’s not fine, it’s—”

“Amma. It’s genuinely fine. Things are good here. I got a bonus in June.”

He had not got a bonus in June. The words simply arrived, complete, in the right voice, and stepped out of him as they had for twenty years.

“I’ll send it Tuesday.”

“A bonus!” His mother’s voice went up like a bird.
“Raghava, he got a bonus.”

And in the background his father, so quiet Nik could barely catch it, saying something that was probably *don’t tell everyone*.

He put the phone down. Meera came in for a glass of water and said, in the flat voice of a woman on four hours’ sleep who is not accusing anybody of anything:

“Anaya’s school fees went up. It’s eleven-forty now, not ten-eighty. There was a letter in May. First of August, the next one. Just so it’s not a surprise.”

“It won’t be a surprise,” said Nik.

She went up.

And on the Saturday the house was empty. Rohan at his grandmother’s, Anaya at a trampoline party. It happened about six times a year. He had costed it once at forty pounds an hour in childcare and worth about four hundred, and had never told anybody that either.

He made a coffee, and sat down at the kitchen table, and opened *2020 household v3*, because he was going to do this properly.

He updated the income tab. He updated the fixed costs. He made a new row for Chennai and called it *one-off*. He typed two numbers into it. Then he looked at the row title, and knew perfectly well what a category called *one-off* containing two entries is going to be next year.

Then he opened the credit card statement, because to do it properly he had to bring the card in.

He looked at the balance for about forty seconds, which at his hourly rate was worth about a pound ten, and which was the most expensive forty seconds of the month.

It was not catastrophic. That was somehow worse. It was a number a man in his position should not have. Arrived at in increments of two and three hundred pounds over fourteen months. Every one of which he could have named, and none of which had been extravagant.

And he found that he could not type it into the cell.

Not *would not*. Could not. He sat with his hands on the keys in an empty house on a Saturday morning, and there was a physical block between the number on one screen and the empty cell on the other. If he typed it in, the model would recalculate. The twelve-month view at the bottom would turn. And then it would be true in writing.

He closed the tab. He drank the coffee, which had gone cold, and said out loud, to the empty kitchen:

“I’ll do it at the hotel.”

It sounded reasonable. Five days of quiet, and evenings in a room with nothing in them. He would do it properly, with time, the way it deserved.

He saved the file, and closed it.

• • •

Then they packed.

6. Check-In

The Ardenne was built in 1974 by a consortium that went bankrupt in 1976, and its architecture is therefore a complete and honest record of a mood that lasted about eighteen months: a twelve-storey slab of bedrooms; a low podium wrapped round it containing everything else; and a porte-cochère held up on four concrete columns of a girth suggesting that the architect expected weather from below.

It was refurbished in 1998, and again in 2016. The 2016 refurbishment installed, in the lobby, a fireplace that does not work, an installation of nine hundred glass rods, and a smell.

The smell was vanilla over chlorine over carpet. It came out of a diffuser above the desk, and underneath it was the pool two floors down, and underneath that was 1974. Guests noticed it on arrival and stopped noticing it within the hour, and then smelled it again on the last morning while settling the bill, and could not have said what had changed.

On the Thursday it was hosting three things at once.

In the Warwick Suite: the Bellwether strategy summit, sixty-one delegates, private, with its own coffee and its own lanyards in a colour the events team described as *fern*.

In Halls 2 and 3: the Banking Operations Forum, four days, four hundred delegates, twenty-two exhibition stands, of which twelve were selling essentially the same fraud product.

And in the atrium, on eighty-eight trestle tables hired from a firm in Coleshill: the Midlands Open, seven rounds, a hundred and seventy-six players, an easel saying SILENCE PLEASE — GAMES IN PROGRESS, and a man on the door with a metal cash tin.

The events team had raised the collision with the general manager in April, and the general manager had said the thing general managers say, which was that the building had four separate circulations. This was true on the drawings.

• • •

Nik arrived first, at 1:40, pulling the maroon case, which meant walking with a slight lean, like a man in a headwind.

Check-in took nine minutes, because the woman ahead of him was disputing a charge from 2023 with the stamina of somebody who has retired and found a purpose. Nik stood behind her with the case against his leg and read the tariff card in its little perspex holder, which he had not looked at when he booked.

Standard double: £141. Per night. Five nights.

Seven hundred and five pounds. He had known that. He had paid it. What happened at the desk was not the discovery of a number but the arrival of one number in the same room as another, which is a different event, and the other number was £1,140, due on the first of August.

He did the division before he could stop himself. Five nights here was two-thirds of a month of his daughter's school. Then he did it per night. Worse. Then per hour, which

was ridiculous, and he stopped, and the stopping took an effort he would have been embarrassed to describe.

“Sir? Sorry to keep you.”

“Not at all,” said Nik warmly.

“Just the one guest? And it’s — Nik-heel? Sorry.”

“Nikhil,” said Nik. And then, because it had been twenty-six years: “Nik’s fine.”

“Lovely. You’re on eight; chess is through the double doors past the fireplace. Do you need a lanyard?”

“There are lanyards?”

“There are *three sorts* of lanyards,” she said, with feeling.

• • •

Kate arrived at 2:15 and was still talking when the car door opened.

“—so tell Tom the answer’s yes but he has to write down what happens in November, not what happens in August, and if he says the word ‘directionally’ I want you to laugh at him, out loud, on the call, as me—”

Through the revolving door at a speed that made the door-man step back. Phone at her collarbone. Bag sliding.

“—and I’ll have signal all weekend, so if it’s genuinely urgent, genuinely, then ring. But Dawn, I mean *genuinely*—”

The clerk had a form and a pen. Kate took the pen without breaking stride, in the hand not holding the phone. Began to fill in a car registration she did not know. Stopped. Made a gesture of such universal meaning — *one moment, I am very sorry, I am aware of how this looks* — that the clerk, who was twenty-three, felt obscurely flattered.

“Right. I’m at the hotel. I’m going to go and be strategic at people. Love you, bye.”

She sent it. Put the phone face down on the marble. It lasted four seconds.

“Sorry. Merrick. M-E-double-R-I-C-K.”

“You’re the fern lanyard.”

“I’m the what?”

“Bellwether. Fern. You’re on eleven, there’s a thing in the bathroom, I’ll let you find it.” He slid the card over. “And your team have the Warwick Suite from four. And — sorry, there’s a note — a Ms Nash asks whether you can do a call at six rather than seven.”

Kate looked at the note.

“Of course she does,” she said pleasantly, and picked the phone back up.

Six minutes at the desk. She had given it two. The four would come out of something.

• • •

Alex arrived at 4:50 and did not speak to a human being for eleven minutes.

He had the big headphones on. He had not been listening to anything for the last half hour of the train, because he had been thinking about a problem, and the headphones had stayed on as a wall rather than a speaker.

He joined the wrong queue twice.

First the atrium, which turned out to be chess registration, where a man with a cash tin said something Alex could not hear and did not remove the headphones for.

Then the Banking Operations Forum desk, where a woman said, brightly, “Have we got you on the delegate list?”

“I’m — no. Sorry. I’m a hotel.”

“You’re a hotel?”

“I’m *staying* in the hotel,” said Alex, going red, and left.

At the actual desk he gave his name and had to give it twice.

“Voy-chick. It’s a W. It’s spelled with a W but it’s a V.” A sentence he had said perhaps nine hundred times, and which came out, as always, slightly too fast.

“And is it just yourself?”

“My parents come Saturday. Different booking. Wójcik as well. Also with a W.”

“Aw,” said the clerk. “Family weekend.”

And Alex — who had come for five days because it was ninety minutes from London, and because if he stayed in the flat he would go to the office, and who had told his parents this was a break he had been planning for months — said, “Yeah.”

He went up to the ninth floor. Put the bag down. Opened the laptop. Connected to the wifi. Ran a trace to check the latency, and got forty-one milliseconds to London. Terrible. He ran it again in case it had been unlucky, and it had not.

There was an extractor somewhere above the ceiling doing the long slow breathing.

He started working.

• • •

Michael arrived at 5:20 and was, within ninety seconds, on excellent terms with everybody behind the desk.

“Right. I’m going to warn you now: my name’s Halloway, and there’ll be two of me on that system, because I booked it myself, badly, and then the bank’s travel department booked it again, properly, and the bank’s version has me arriving yesterday.”

“Ah,” said the clerk, whose badge said FOLA. “Yes. There are two of you.”

“There are. One of them has been here since Wednesday having a lovely time, and the other one is me.”

“Do you want me to cancel the—”

“No, no. Leave him. He’s no trouble.” Michael put his card down. “Give him a nice view.”

Fola laughed properly, which is rarer at a hotel desk than people think; and then spent four minutes doing something complicated with two reservations and a rate code, while Michael leaned on the desk and watched the traffic of the place, and smelled it: vanilla out of a diffuser, and under the vanilla what every conference hotel had smelled of since 1986, carpet and chlorine from somewhere below and hot dust off a screen. A man going past with a chess clock in each hand. Two women in fern arguing amiably about a slide. A great shuffling release of banking delegates out of Hall 2 at a quarter past five.

Nobody looked at him. He noticed it, and did not, at the time, give it a name; he had walked into buildings for a dozen years and been the most senior person in them, and here he was a man in a good coat at a desk.

“You’re on the fourth, Mr Halloway.”

“Michael.”

“Michael. And you’re speaking, it says here. Closing keynote.”

“I am. Two o’clock Monday — which is the slot they give you when they still want you at the conference, but they’ve stopped being frightened of you.”

Fola grinned. “I’ll come.”

“You will not.”

“I might.”

“Fola,” said Michael, taking his key card, “nobody has ever come.”

• • •

At 5:22 the four of them were in the lobby at the same time. This was noticed by nobody, and is recorded here only because it happened.

Nik was at the noticeboard reading the round-one pairings, which had just gone up: white on board thirty-one. Behind him a woman in fern was saying “—but the Kettering number is the number—” into a phone.

Kate was at the lift, four metres away. Thumb moving. Bag sliding off her shoulder. She hitched it up without looking.

Alex came out of the second lift as she got into the first. He had come down because there was no signal on nine, and had discovered there was no signal in the lobby either, and he stood in the middle of the floor holding his phone up at an angle, turning slowly, in a posture with no dignity available to it.

And Michael, walking away from the desk, stopped, because his shoelace had come undone; and set down his case;

and knelt to tie it.

Kneeling took him a second longer than it used to. Getting up, he put a hand on the case.

Then he took a breath in, and let it out, and went to find the lift.

7. Post-Mortem

Round one began at seven, and by twenty past the atrium of The Ardenne had gone quiet in a way that no other sort of gathering manages.

It was not silence. There was the air handling. A chair. Somebody's stomach. Every ninety seconds or so the small plastic *tock* of a clock being pressed. But a hundred and seventy-six people had stopped talking at the same moment and stayed stopped, and the effect on a man arriving from open-plan offices and video calls and a three-year-old was roughly that of stepping into cold water.

Nik sat down at board thirty-one, set out his pieces, and felt his shoulders come down two inches.

This was the thing, and it was not the winning. He had tried to explain the winning to Meera once, four or five years ago, and had heard himself doing it about eleven words in, and had stopped.

The thing was that for the next four hours nobody was going to say *sorry*? Nobody was going to lean in. There was no accent in here, because there was nothing to have an accent in. His opponent was a boy of about nineteen with a fringe and a Lidl bag, and he was not going to form a view about Nikhil Raghavan's competence off the first four seconds of a sentence, because there would be no sentences. There would be a position, and the position would be true.

Entry, forty-eight pounds, seven rounds, call it four hours a round. Twelve pounds an hour of not explaining himself, against a nursery that charged nine-fifty and a therapist Meera had once suggested who charged ninety, and of the three it was comfortably the best value in the portfolio.

The boy had a digital clock that cost about thirty pounds and a set that had come out of a school cupboard. Nik had brought neither, because you never need to.

He shook hands. He played e4. The boy played c5.

• • •

It was not a good game.

He got a slight edge out of the opening, the way he usually did, because he had prepared and the boy had not. The boy was graded 1840 against Nik's 2005, a hundred and sixty-five points, about a seventy-two per cent expected score, and Nik had all three figures before either of them had castled. He always did. Twelve pounds an hour of not explaining himself, and the machine still came to the board and sat down beside him and got its pencil out.

Then on move seventeen the boy did something loose on the queenside — a pawn push that was, Nik saw immediately, over-ambitious and probably losing.

And Nik did not take it.

He looked at the position for twenty-eight minutes, which was a third of his clock, spent on a hundred and eighty pounds of prize fund he was not going to win, on a decision he had in some real sense already taken. There was a line, and he could see the first six moves of it, clean as a rail: open the centre,

rook comes to d7, and it is not quite winning but it is extremely uncomfortable to be the boy. It required calculating a knight sacrifice four moves in.

He got to the fourth move and could not see the end of it.

What happened next was so familiar that he could have narrated it while it was going on.

He thought: *and if it doesn't work.*

Then a small piece of machinery turned over inside him and produced, as it had been producing for twenty years, the alternative. The solid move. Rook to c1. Nothing whatever wrong with it. It kept everything defended, and it kept the small edge, and it kept the position closed and safe and — this was the honest word, the one he used only in his own head — *unexposed.*

He played Rc1. Twenty-eight minutes of thought, and the move itself took four seconds, and the four seconds were the only part of the whole transaction that had ever been in doubt.

He won anyway. It took another fifty-one moves and was, by the end, mechanical. The boy overpressed on move forty-two out of frustration at not being able to get anything going, and dropped a pawn, and then another. He resigned in a dead position with a good grace that made Nik feel obscurely ashamed of himself.

“Well played,” said the boy.

“You were fine. The pawn on move seventeen.”

“I know. I knew as soon as I let go.”

They shook hands. It was ten past eleven.

One point. On the prize table a point was worth about thirty pounds if you finished on five and a half and nothing whatever if you finished on five, which is the sort of distribu-

tion Nik dealt with all day and had never once found funny in his own accounts and found extremely funny here.

• • •

The analysis room was the Kenilworth, a function room off the atrium with a carpet from 1998 and fourteen tables of people replaying games at speed. There was a tea urn. There was a plate of biscuits the hotel had put out at seven, which had reached the state biscuits reach, and which Nik costed on the way past at about four pence each and not worth it at the price.

He took his score sheet in, because that is what you do.

At the far table an old man was sitting alone with a board already set up, moving pieces about with one hand and writing with the other. He looked up when Nik came in.

“Raghavan. Board thirty-one.”

Nik stopped.

“You beat me,” Nik said. “Two years ago. Round four.”

“I know.”

“You had a rook on the seventh and I—”

“You had a rook on the seventh,” said Wilf Tanner, “and you offered a draw, and I refused it, and then I lost. Sit down.”

Wilf Tanner was eighty-three. He had been a structural engineer in Coventry for forty-one years and had played tournament chess since 1958. He had the build of a very old man who has stayed exactly the same height all his life. His hands shook slightly, except when they were moving a piece, at which point they did not shake at all.

Nik sat down and set up.

“I checked the calculations on the slab you’re sitting under,” said Wilf, to the board. “Nineteen seventy-three. They never paid.”

“The hotel?”

“The hotel.” He straightened a rook. “Move one.”

The set was a Jaques from about 1970, weighted, worth four hundred pounds on a good day. Nik knew that within a second of touching a rook and said nothing, because there is a kind of man who prices another man’s chess set out loud, and Nik had spent twenty years not being him in public.

It took twenty minutes to get to move seventeen, and Wilf did not say a single thing on the way. He put the pieces where they had been, in silence, with his eyes on the board, and Nik found himself narrating a little, apologetically — “he’d been quite quick up to here” — and being met with nothing, which taught him quickly to stop.

At move seventeen Wilf stopped.

“There,” he said.

“I know.”

“What did you look at?”

“Knight takes on d5, and then if he recaptures, rook to d7.”

“How long?”

“Twenty-eight minutes.”

“And you played Rc1.”

“I couldn’t see the end of it.”

Wilf nodded slowly. Then he did a thing that nobody in Nik’s professional life had done in six years, which was to sit, and think about the answer, and not fill the gap with anything at all.

Thirty seconds went by. Someone at the next table said “no, no, no, *bishop*”, and there was laughter.

“Show me,” said Wilf. “Knight takes d5. Go on.”

Nik played it. Wilf recaptured. Nik played Rd7, and Wilf found the defence, the only defence, the one that involves giving back the exchange, and Nik played the follow-up and Wilf played the second-only-defence. Eight moves into a line that Nik had not been able to see the end of at the board, they arrived at a position so plainly winning that neither of them said so.

“Ah,” said Nik.

“Yes.”

“I mean, at the board—”

“At the board you had twenty-eight minutes,” Wilf said. “It took us four.”

Nik looked at the position.

“Right,” he said. “So I’m a coward.”

He said it lightly, in the tone he used for things like this — the little self-deprecating shrug he had been deploying for two decades, which had never once failed to make an English person say *oh, no, not at all*.

Wilf did not say *oh, no, not at all*.

He put the pieces back to move seventeen and set the position out again neatly, and looked at it rather than at Nik.

“No,” he said. “You’re not a coward. A coward would have offered a draw.” He straightened a rook a fraction. “You won the game. You’ll win the next one too, probably, if you get white.”

“But?”

“You’ve got the best defensive technique of anyone in this room under seventy,” said Wilf. “Genuinely. It’s a real thing, you’ve built it, it’s taken years. And you use it in positions where there’s nothing to defend.”

Nik said nothing.

“That’s not the seventeenth move,” Wilf went on. “That’s every game of yours I’ve ever seen. You play like a man guarding a door long after the room behind it has emptied out.”

Somebody dropped a chess clock at the next table and there was a general noise.

Wilf reached for a biscuit, found it was one of the bad ones, and put it back.

“So what is it you think you’re protecting?” he said.

And Nikhil Raghavan opened his mouth to answer.

It was the tone that did it. Asked kindly, with the head on one side, in the voice people use when they have decided you are a bit sad, and Nik would have had four answers ready and one of them funny. Asked as a challenge, and he would have had a different four.

But Wilf Tanner asked it the way he had said everything else. Flatly, as a technical question about a position. The manner of a man who has spent forty-one years asking *what is this column actually carrying*, and has learned that the answer is very often *nothing*, and it has been in the way since 1974.

He wanted the load path. He was not interested in Nik.

“I don’t—” said Nik.

He stopped.

He sat in a function room called the Kenilworth with his hands flat on the table on either side of a chessboard, and went looking, and priced what he found. Nothing. No secret. No wound with a story attached that he could produce and be understood about. A door, and twenty years of standing in it, and behind it a room he could have let anybody walk through at any point since about 2004, at a cost of nothing.

“That’s a very good question,” he said at last, in the wrong voice. The board voice. The one that means *I’ll come back to you on that*.

Wilf Tanner nodded, satisfied, and began putting the pieces away.

“Round two’s at two,” he said. “Don’t eat the fish.”

8. The Lobby Bar

The bar at The Ardenne was called The Long Room and was not long. Nine stools. A marble counter installed in 2016 over a mahogany one from 1974. A barman called Denny who had worked there nine years and had developed the skill of being present and absent at the same time.

Kate came down at 9:40 with a laptop she did not open and a folder she did.

She sat at the end of the counter with her back to the room and ordered a glass of the second-cheapest red. She had done this in bars since she was twenty-six, on a theory she had read somewhere and never checked: the second-cheapest is where the margin is worst and the wine is therefore best.

She drank a third of it in four minutes. Then she made the rest last an hour.

The problem was in the folder.

Twenty-two per cent. Four days of material. Eleven versions. What she had at 9:40 on the Thursday was a presentation that said the number was hard, which every chief executive in Britain said in July, and which Harriet Nash had been listening to for thirty years.

The board joined Saturday evening for dinner and sat properly on the Sunday morning. Sixty hours.

She wrote on the back of a sheet, in the handwriting she used when nobody was going to see it:

Options. 1. Say it's hard. (Cowardice with slides.) 2. Say the number is wrong. (Then what.) 3. —

She was still looking at the 3 when a voice beside her said:

"That's the face of somebody trying to write the third one."

• • •

He was about sixty-five, in a jacket with no tie, holding a gin and tonic. He had sat down two stools along, which is the correct distance: near enough to speak, far enough to be ignored.

"Sorry," he said. "I'm not going to do this. I'm going to say one thing and then leave you alone, and the one thing is that there are always only two options, and the third one is a fiction invented by consultants."

Kate looked at him with the face she had spent twenty years perfecting for men who spoke to her in bars.

"Is that right."

"No," said the man. "It's completely wrong. But it's a good line, and I've been waiting three years to use it."

And Kate — who had had four hours' sleep, and a day of sixty-one people, and a call with Harriet at six that had gone badly in the way that only pleasant calls can go badly. She laughed. Properly. Out loud, in a hotel bar, before she had decided to.

"Michael," said the man.

"Kate."

"Right, Kate. I'm going to look at my phone now, and you're going to go back to your third option."

He did. He actually did. He turned slightly away and got his phone out and read something on it for a full ninety

seconds.

Kate looked at her sheet of paper. At the 3. And discovered that she had lost the thread, and that what she wanted, with an intensity that alarmed her, was for the man to say something else.

“What are you here for?”

“Banking conference. Hall two. Four hundred of us, and eleven stands selling the same fraud product.” He put the phone down. “You’re the fern lanyards.”

“How do you know about the fern lanyards?”

“Fola on the desk told me. There are three sorts, and there’s been an incident.” He drank. “Retail?”

“E-commerce.”

“Growing?”

“Twenty-two per cent a year. Four years.”

“Ah,” said Michael. The *ah* had a whole paragraph in it.

Kate turned on her stool to face him.

• • •

She told him.

She had not planned to, and could not afterwards fully reconstruct how it happened. There was a step where he asked what the number was for next year, and a step where she said it out loud — *twenty-two* — and heard how it sounded in a bar at ten o’clock. A step where he said “and what’s the honest one?” and she said “fourteen, if Refill lands. Eleven if it doesn’t.” And then she was simply telling him, in detail, with the folder open, to a man whose surname she did not know.

Two things made it possible. She understood both of them at the time.

The first was that he could not hurt her. Not on her board. Not in her sector. Not in her network. No interest in her being right and no use for her being wrong.

The second was that he was old.

Not old-old. But old enough that the thing she had carried for the best part of a year, the low constant humming sense of being watched by people deciding whether she was going to be one of the ones who make it, simply did not exist between them.

He had already found out how his went.

“Right,” said Michael, when she stopped. “Can I ask you four questions, and you’re allowed to tell me to shut up.”

“Go on.”

“One. Has the board ever set the number, or have you always brought it to them?”

Kate opened her mouth and closed it.

“I’ve always brought it.”

“So the twenty-two is yours.”

“It’s — the twenty-two came out of the model I built in—” She stopped. “The twenty-two is mine.”

“Right. Two. Does Harriet want twenty-two per cent, or does Harriet want to not be surprised?”

“She’d say both.”

“They all say both. Which one gets someone fired?”

There was a pause in which the barman moved a glass.

“Being surprised.”

“Three.” He turned his glass a quarter turn on the marble. She noticed it, and would notice it again later. “When you go in on Sunday and say fourteen, what is the first question?”

“Why.”

“No,” said Michael. “That’s the second question. The first question is *since when*.”

He let that sit.

“Because there is no board on earth that punishes you for the number. They punish you for the interval between when you knew and when they knew. That’s the entire thing. That’s thirty years of my life in one sentence, and you can have it for a gin and tonic.”

Kate put the pen down.

“I’ve known since March,” she said.

“Then don’t say March.”

“You’ve just told me the whole thing is—”

“I’ve told you they punish the interval; I haven’t told you to hand them a knife and stand still.” He leaned back. “You don’t say *I’ve known since March*. You say: *since March we’ve been running a piece of work to see whether twenty-two was recoverable. It isn’t. Here’s what we found, here’s what it cost us to find out, and here is the thing we found instead*.” He looked at her. “Which is option three, incidentally, and it’s why you couldn’t write it. You’ve been trying to write a defence. It isn’t a defence, it’s a finding. You did a piece of work and it produced an answer they don’t like. That’s not failure; that’s what work is.”

Kate looked down at the sheet of paper with the 3 on it.

“That’s—” she said.

“It’s not clever,” said Michael. “It’s just old. I’d have taken a year to learn it, and I’d have learned it wrong first.”

“Did you learn it wrong first?”

“I told a board in 2009 that a number was fine in April and not fine in June, and I lost a very good chief executive her job;

and it wasn't her fault, it was mine; and she wrote me a Christmas card for nine years afterwards, which I found harder than if she'd never spoken to me again." He drank. "Anyway. There's four hundred pounds of consultancy. Where's Denny gone."

. . .

The bar thinned out. Somewhere behind them a group of banking delegates were doing the thing where four men agree loudly.

Kate closed the folder.

"Can I ask *you* one?"

"You can ask."

"What do you do?"

"I'm a chief operating officer," said Michael. "It's a job with two halves. In the first half you find out what's actually happening in a large organisation; and in the second half you tell people about it; and the second half is where the money is, because nobody wants to know."

"How long?"

"Six years in this one. Forty-two in total. I've been in banks since Thatcher, which means I've personally overseen the closure of about four hundred branches — so if you've ever stood outside a shuttered building in a market town feeling wistful about the death of the high street, that was me. I did that. On purpose. For money."

Kate laughed.

"And are you—" She was aware of choosing the word carefully, and of not knowing why. "Is it good? Now?"

“It’s marvellous,” said Michael. “I’m speaking on Monday. Closing keynote. Two o’clock.” He raised his glass an inch. “It’s the slot they give you when they’d like you at the conference, but they’ve stopped being frightened of you.”

Kate laughed again.

And then, in the second after she laughed, heard it.

She could not have explained it to anybody. It was a joke. It was a good joke. The man had been making good jokes for an hour and every one of them had worked.

But this one had a floor under it. It went down a certain distance and then stopped on something solid, and the something solid was not funny.

And Michael’s face while she laughed did not change at all.

That was the tell. A man enjoying his own joke changes.

Two seconds to decide.

She had spent eleven months being asked *how are you, though* by people who wanted the answer, and had said *fine, big fortnight* to every one of them. She knew from the inside, with total precision, what the next question does when you are standing on the floor of your own joke and somebody taps it.

“Well,” said Kate, “I’m coming to that.”

“You are not.”

“Two o’clock Monday.”

“Nobody has ever come,” said Michael, and for the first time that evening his face changed while he said it.

And Denny arrived with the bill, and it was 11:50, and Kate went up to eleven and slept five hours, which was an hour and a half more than she had managed on any night that week.

9. Nineteen Moves

The atrium ran a different note from the ninth floor.

Bigger space, slower air, the plant somewhere behind the lift core sitting about a tone under what it did in the rooms. He had found it on Wednesday and had been quietly pleased about it since.

Twenty past eleven. The congress had finished for the night and the atrium had gone back to being an atrium. Four boards still out at the far end, where a handful of people were playing blitz for nothing.

Alex had come down because the wifi on the ninth floor had lost a build at ninety per cent and he had needed to put twenty metres between himself and a laptop.

He walked the length of it twice.

He got a coffee out of a machine that produced a substance. The machine had a fan in it that ran on for about forty seconds after the cup was gone, and then stopped, and the room got bigger.

Then he stopped at the boards.

One man at the end table with a position set up and nobody opposite him, moving pieces with one hand and writing on a sheet with the other. Fortyish. Reading glasses. A tournament badge on a fern-adjacent lanyard that was, on inspection, a fourth colour altogether.

Alex watched him for a minute.

He had played between nine and fifteen, in the way a certain sort of boy does. School club. A couple of county things. One weekend in Hastings where he came eleventh. He stopped when he found compilers. He still played online at three in the morning sometimes, fast and badly, in a way he would not have described to anybody as playing chess.

He was, in his own estimation, decent.

“Are you allowed to play people,” he said, “or is it all official?”

The man looked up.

“It’s a hotel,” he said. “You’re allowed to do anything.”

“Do you want a game?”

There was the smallest pause.

“All right,” said Nik.

• • •

It took nineteen moves.

He could reconstruct the first eight afterwards and never got much further. He played e5, which he had always played. He developed his knights, which is correct. On move six he pushed a pawn to gain a tempo, and it felt strong.

On move nine he was fine.

He was still, at move nine, telling himself a story in which he was fine, and in which the man opposite was a hobbyist in a hotel with a badge on a lanyard, and in which Alex Wójcik, who reasoned about lock-free data structures for a living, was about to have quite an enjoyable half hour.

On move twelve his position stopped having any moves in it.

That was the sensation, and it was not losing. Losing he knew. He looked at the board and there were, in the technical sense, about thirty legal moves available, and every one of them was worse than the last one, and there had not been a plan since roughly move seven, and the man opposite had not done anything he could point at.

“Sorry,” he said. “What happened?”

“On move six,” said Nik, “you took a pawn’s worth of space, and after that all your pieces had to go behind it.”

“Right.”

“It’s a very common thing.”

On move seventeen Nik put a knight on a square from which it attacked nothing at all, and Alex looked at it for two minutes, and then understood that it attacked nothing at all *yet*, and made a small involuntary noise.

He resigned on nineteen.

“That was—” He rubbed his face. “That was actually humiliating. Thank you.”

“You play quickly,” said Nik. “You’re not bad. You just play like it’s a race.”

“It’s the internet’s fault.”

“It’s always the internet’s fault.” Nik was already resetting, pieces going back with the fast economical hand of a man who has done it forty thousand times. “Again?”

“Can we do one where I last past move nine?”

“We can try.”

• • •

The second game took an hour and a half and neither of them was really playing it.

There was somewhere to look. That was all it was. Two or three minutes would go by with nobody saying anything and the gaps did not have to be filled, because a hand was moving a bishop about, and the machine's fan cut in and ran its forty seconds and cut out.

Alex found out that the man was called Nik, that he was a CFO, that he had two children, and that the younger one had been waking every night for eight months.

"Eight months," Alex said.

"Two hundred and forty nights. I did work it out. That was a mistake."

Then Nik said, moving the bishop and not looking up: "What is it you actually build?"

"You'll be bored."

"I've just spent two hours on move seventeen of a game I won. I have an infinite capacity for boredom."

So Alex started at the wrong end, because it was the only end he had.

"OK. So it sits underneath everything. Not in the app. Below the runtime."

And then it went.

Because the thing about below the runtime is that it is a road, and everything a program wants to do in the world has to come out onto that road and say what it is — open this file, talk to this address, start this child — and you are standing in the middle of it, and the whole game, the entire game, the only rule there is, is that you are not allowed to slow the traffic down — not by five per cent, not by two, because the day you cost a customer two per cent they measure you, and once they

have measured you they turn you off, and a security product that is turned off is a slide. So you cannot take a lock. Not once, not anywhere, not for a microsecond, because the instant one core has to stop and wait on another core the road stops, and it stops hardest exactly when it is busiest, which is exactly the minute you are supposed to be worth having. So there is a ring for every core and the writer never waits: one atomic add on a counter, which gives him a slot that is his and nobody else's, and he fills the slot at his leisure, and then publishes it with a single store with a release fence on it — one instruction, a nanosecond and a half, the cheapest promise in computing — and that store says *everything I wrote before this line is now true for you as well*. And the reader on the other side comes round behind him at his own speed, acquiring, never blocking, never once tapping anyone on the shoulder, and if the reader is slow the ring fills and the writer does not wait then either, he drops, and counts the drop, because a dropped event you know about is data and a stalled machine is a phone call at four in the morning. And underneath the whole arrangement is one number, a monotonic sequence, which is the only thing in the entire system that everybody agrees about, and every question you will ever be asked — did this process open that socket before or after it was reparented, was the binary swapped under it, is this the same file it was two seconds ago — comes down in the end to two of those numbers and which one is bigger.

Both hands were doing it by then, drawing the ring in the air at about the size of a dinner plate and going round it the way the reader goes round it, anticlockwise, which is wrong, and which he did every time.

“—and the beautiful part, the genuinely beautiful part, is that there’s no clock in it anywhere. Clocks lie. Two cores in the same box don’t agree what time it is, and they can’t, and there is no fixing it, because it isn’t a bug, it’s the shape of the universe. But *order* is free. Order you get for nothing, because it already happened. So you can be wrong about when and still be right about what came after what, and what came after what is the entire product.”

He stopped.

It came to him, somewhere around then, that he had been talking for four minutes.

He knew because he had heard it, the way you hear your own footsteps change coming out of a corridor into a hall. Nothing had come in over the top. The man opposite had a bishop between two fingers and had not put it down.

“Sorry,” he said. “That’s—”

“No,” said Nik. “That was the best thing I’ve heard all week. Keep going.”

Alex kept going for another two minutes and then ran out, honestly, the way a tape runs out.

Nik moved the bishop, and thought about something, and had nothing he needed to say.

Then he said:

“How is it, having a co-founder?”

And Alex said, with no preparation at all: “He talks over me.”

• • •

It got to about one in the morning. They had stopped pretending about the second game around midnight and the position sat between them like a table decoration.

"The thing that gets me," Alex said, "is that he's not — he's genuinely a good person. That's what makes it impossible. If he was a shark I could deal with a shark. Every single time, if you filmed it and showed it to a jury, he's done nothing. He asks what I think. He waits. Once, in March, he sat there for a full — I timed it — twenty-two seconds."

"And you didn't say it."

"I said about a third of it. In a voice." He looked at the board. "You know when you can hear yourself? From outside. My voice goes down while it's happening and I can't get hold of it. It's not that I'm scared of him. It's not fear. It's more like —"

He stopped.

"It's more like," he said again.

The plant went on behind the lift core.

"No," he said. "Sorry. I don't have it."

Nik put the bishop down.

"Yes," he said.

"You get that?"

"I got that for about five years," said Nik. "Different reason."

And then he said it.

"When I came here I had an accent that people had to work at. Not a bad one. But there'd be a — half a second, and they'd lean in, and say *sorry*? And the sentence would go into the room four seconds late and about ten per cent smaller than everyone else's. And that happened maybe forty times a week for five years." He turned a captured pawn over in his fingers.

“So I did what you do. I stopped talking. Which cost me a promotion in 2005 to a man who was worse than me, and I knew exactly why, and it was the correct decision by the company, because he’d said four thousand things and I’d said sixty.”

“So then what?”

“So then I found the other thing,” said Nik.

He put the pawn down.

“I polish,” he said.

Alex looked up.

“I don’t lie. I want to be very clear, because I’ve thought about this a great deal and it matters to me. I have never put a false number in front of a board in my life. It’s all in the pack. It’s all true. But if there’s a bad thing on page nineteen and a good thing on page four, I know exactly which one I’m putting on page four, and I know exactly what a room does when I say *healthy* instead of *adequate*. And I do it every single time.

“I did it eleven days ago. My chair asked me a direct question about a clawback that could take our runway from fourteen months to six, and I said I was *relaxed*.” He said the word with a delicacy that made it sound like something he had picked up off the floor. “And afterwards the chief executive rang me and said I make it feel like there’s a floor under everything.”

Two tables away a man put a set into a bag, and the pieces went in with the sound pieces make.

“Why?” said Alex.

“Because if I say the plain thing they might get it wrong.”

“That’s it. That’s the whole of it.” He looked at the board. “I have said, to a stranger, at one in the morning, in a hotel, a thing I have not said to my wife in fourteen years of marriage. I’d like it noted that I’m aware of how that looks.”

“Noted,” said Alex.

“Right.”

“It’s fine, though. I don’t count. You’ll never see me again.”

“No,” Nik agreed. “That’s the entire mechanism.”

• • •

At ten past one Alex said, “My parents get here Saturday.”

“Where from?”

“London. They flew in from — no, they live in London, they’ve lived in London for thirty years. My dad came over in ninety-four.” He turned his king over and stood it back up. “They booked a hotel in Alabama. Not on purpose.”

Nik laughed, and it was a different laugh from the one he had been using all evening.

“You’ll like him,” said Alex. And then heard it, and added, “sorry, that’s — I don’t know why I said that.”

“I might be here.”

“Yeah.” He stood up. He was bad at the end of things. There was always a beat where he did not know what the shape was. “Well — good luck. With the — with the guarding thing.”

Nik looked up sharply.

“I didn’t say a guarding thing.”

“You said you defend positions that don’t need defending. You said it about twenty minutes ago, about the game.”

“Did I.”

“Yeah.”

“Ah,” said Nik, and sat back, and did not say anything else.

The lift to the ninth floor ran with a hum in it at about the pitch of the atrium and a rattle at the door that arrived a beat after it stopped.

Room 914. The extractor going.

He got into bed with the laptop on his knees and did not open it. He lay there for a while.

Then he reached over to the chair, and got the jacket, and took the notebook out of the inside pocket, and held it on his chest without opening it, and fell asleep like that with the light on.

10. Something That Isn't a Race

The breakfast room at The Ardenne had been designed for a hotel running at sixty per cent, and on the Friday it was running at ninety-four, and the result was a scene from a documentary about a lifeboat.

Four hundred banking delegates had come down between half seven and eight, because the first session was at half eight. Sixty-one Bellwether people had been told the summit resumed at nine. A hundred and seventy-six chess players were mostly still asleep, apart from a dozen English juniors of about fourteen who could each eat their own body weight in bacon.

7:39, Friday. Kate had eleven minutes. She had allotted them. Eat standing if necessary, then an hour upstairs on the deck before the summit, which was the only clear hour in the day and the reason she had set an alarm for six.

She stood at the entrance with a plate in one hand and her phone in the other and performed the calculation everybody in the room had performed, which was that there were no tables.

Except one, at the far end by the window, with a man at it and three empty chairs.

“Is anyone—”

“No,” said Nik, moving a folder. “Please.”

• • •

He had eggs and beans and a book face down beside the plate, and she read the spine of it upside down before she sat, because she read everything.

“Is that chess?”

“It is.”

“Are you the chess?” She gestured with her fork toward the atrium. “There is an *enormous* amount of chess happening in this building.”

“A hundred and seventy-six of us.”

“Is that a lot?”

“For a Midlands weekend congress it’s about right.” He said it without any performance at all, which she noticed. “The British is fifteen hundred.”

She ate. She had not sat opposite a stranger at breakfast in perhaps six years. Her breakfasts happened standing up, or in cars, or in rooms where everybody already had a view of her.

“So do you win money?”

“There’s a prize fund. A hundred and eighty for first in my section. The entry’s forty-eight and the hotel’s a hundred and forty-one a night.”

“So you lose.”

“Everybody loses. It’s not a business.” He drank some tea. “The man who won it two years ago drove up from Bristol and slept in the car. He was extremely pleased. He’d worked out he was up about sixty quid, which he had, if you don’t count the car, the diesel, or the man.”

Kate laughed. Then her mind did the only thing it knew how to do, which was to go looking for the mechanism.

“So what is it? Presumably at some level it’s about winning, or you’d play at home.”

Nik put his cup down.

“Do you want the answer I give at work,” he said, “or the actual one?”

“Sorry — is that a real distinction?”

“Yes.”

“Then the actual one. Obviously.”

• • •

“It’s the quiet,” said Nik.

He said it and stopped, and looked out at the car park. Kate, whose instinct in any silence was to fill it, sat with her fork in her hand and, to her own surprise, waited.

“There’s a moment about forty minutes into a game. Everyone’s settled, the openings are done, the arbiter’s stopped walking about. You know when you take earplugs out and hear how loud it had been?” He turned his cup a little. “It’s that, in reverse. There are a hundred and seventy-six people in a room and not one of them is going to speak for three hours. Nobody’s going to ask me anything. Nobody’s going to be told something about me and then look at me.”

He hunted for a word, did not find it, and took the ordinary one.

“There’s no explaining.”

“Right,” said Kate.

“And the position is completely true. It doesn’t matter how I present it. There’s no page four and no page nineteen.” A short laugh at something she had no context for. “If I’m winning I’m winning, and if I’m lost I’m lost, and nobody has ever gone home from a chess tournament having got away with it.”

Kate had stopped eating.

“Is that restful,” she said, “or is it terrifying?”

“Restful. God. Restful.” He seemed slightly startled at himself, and reached for the toast. “There’s nothing to *hold*.”

• • •

I used to dance.

It came up in her whole and assembled and ready — the church hall in Amersham, the hairspray, Tuesdays and Saturdays, the tutor, the five weeks in March that nobody mentioned.

Under the table her weight had gone onto the ball of her left foot.

The story ended thirty years ago. He would look at her with the sympathy people reserve for a thing that is over.

“That’s nice,” she said. “That you’ve got something that isn’t a race.”

“You don’t?”

“I’ve got — I mean, I run. I’ve got a thing on the wall that tells me how I ran.” She heard how it sounded and went on anyway, at speed, in the warm voice, the good one. “I once went to a spa where a woman told me my shoulders were the worst she’d seen that year, and I took it as a competitive result.”

He laughed. It worked. It always worked. She had built it to work.

And he did not push, because there was nothing visible to push at. As far as Nik Raghavan could see, this was a funny, quick, formidable woman in a fern lanyard who ran.

She poured more coffee.

8:11. The eleven minutes had gone at some point she had not marked, and so had the hour, and she knew it and poured the coffee anyway.

• • •

8:20. The room emptied the way rooms do, all at once.

“I should go,” she said. “Sixty-one people and a whiteboard.”

“Doing what?”

“Deciding a number.” She stacked her cup on her plate, which was a thing her mother did. “Can I ask you something, since you’re a CFO and you’re not mine? When somebody tells a board a thing they don’t want to hear, and it goes badly — what actually made it go badly? Not the theory.”

Nik thought about it properly, which took a while.

“Being unable to answer the second question,” he said. “You can tell them anything. Anything at all. But you have to have already been where they’re going next. And if you haven’t, they stop listening to the answer and start looking at you.”

“That’s very good.”

“It’s not mine. Somebody told me that in 2009 and I’ve dined out on it ever since. I’ve had four dinners out of it. Possibly five.”

She stood and gathered her folder. And it was then, off-hand, in the middle of putting the chess book into his bag, that Nik said:

“Somebody asked me a question on Thursday night. I’ve been carrying it round the building ever since.”

“What was it?”

“I was playing like a man protecting something. I won, but.” He straightened up with the bag. “And an old boy in the analysis room said — *what is it you think you’re protecting?*”

Two seconds.

“Ha,” said Kate.

“Yes.”

“And what is it?”

“Nothing,” said Nik. “That’s the annoying part. I went and had a proper look. There’s nothing behind the door.” He put the bag on his shoulder. “Good luck with your number.”

“Good luck with round two.”

“Round two’s at two, against a fifteen-year-old from Coventry who beat a grandmaster’s son in April. So I’d say the pressure is distributed asymmetrically.”

He went.

Kate watched him cross the wreckage of the breakfast room, an unremarkable man of about forty in an unremarkable jumper, and then picked up her phone. Nine things on it. She dealt with four in the lift.

8:31. On eleven she put the folder on the desk. Car park below. Motorway in the distance.

Twenty-nine minutes until the Warwick Suite. Not enough to start.

What is it you think you’re protecting.

The answer came back so fast that she said it out loud to an empty hotel room.

“The company.”

She heard it. She looked at it for about as long as she looked at anything.

Then she picked up the folder and went down to the Warwick Suite and was, for eleven hours, magnificent, and did not write a word of the thing she had got up at six to write.

11. The Roof

“There’s a roof,” said Michael.

It was ten past nine on the Friday evening. Kate had come out of the Warwick Suite at eight-fifty, having spent eleven hours being certain in front of sixty-one people, and had walked into the lobby with the hollowed-out feeling of a woman who has just been excellent. Michael was coming the other way out of Hall 2 with a conference tote bag he had no intention of ever opening.

“There’s a what?”

“A roof. There’s a staff terrace above the ballroom. It’s on the fifth; you go up in the service lift, or you go through the door by the ice machine, which they have never once locked; and there’s a flat bit with a rail round it and an extractor and about four chairs, and you can see the whole thing from up there.”

“How do you know that?”

“I stayed here in 2004,” said Michael, “when it was a different hotel with the same concrete. There was a bloke called Ray who used to smoke up there and he showed me. Nobody’s changed the door.”

Kate looked at him.

“Is this legal?”

“It is *unspecified*,” said Michael.

• • •

It was not, in any sense that a photograph would support, a nice place.

There was an extractor housing the size of a transit van that made a low continuous roar and, every ninety seconds or so, a click. There was a rubber-membrane floor that gave slightly underfoot and smelled, faintly, of hot tar. There was a rail. There were, as promised, four chairs: three plastic and stacked, one a proper metal one that somebody had carried up here at some point in the last two decades for reasons of their own. There were eleven cigarette ends in a paint tin. There was a broom.

And there was a view.

The car park, then the ring road, then the M42. Then, because The Ardenne sat on slightly raised ground, and because it was ten past nine in July, everything else. The whole flat lit sprawl of it going off to the north-west. The tower blocks in the middle distance. The aircraft stacked over the airport in a slow queue with their lights on. And the sky doing the long orange thing it does in England in July at that hour, where it takes forty minutes to give up.

And there was already somebody there.

He was sitting in the metal chair with his elbows on his knees, and he stood up quickly when the door went, and it was the man from breakfast.

“Oh,” said Kate.

“Sorry — I’ll—”

“No. Don’t. Sit down.” She was laughing. “This is — I’m sorry, do you have a key to the roof?”

“I found it looking for a fire exit,” said Nik. “On Thursday. I’ve been up twice.”

“This is Michael. He also breaks into roofs. Michael, this is —”

“Nik.”

“Michael.”

The two men shook hands, which on a roof, at night, next to an extractor, is a slightly comic act. All three of them registered that, and nobody said anything about it.

• • •

Alex came up at twenty to ten, holding his phone above his head.

He came through the door already talking. “—yeah, no, I’ve got one bar, I’m going to lose you, I’m going to — Ben. *Ben*. I’ll do it in the morning.”

He stopped dead. Three faces.

“Oh. Sorry. God. Sorry.”

“He’s off the chess,” said Nik.

“He’s off the *what?*”

“He’s the one who lost in nineteen moves.”

“That’s—” Alex pointed. “That is a completely unfair way to introduce someone.”

“It’s how I’d want to be introduced,” said Michael, “if it were true of me, which it will be by Sunday. Sit down. There’s a chair; it’s plastic; it’s from 1998; I make no promises.”

And Alex, who had come up here to shout at a phone, and who had been intending, forty seconds earlier, to go back to his room and work until two, sat down.

• • •

Here is what nobody said, over the next hour and a half.

Nobody said what they did. Michael said “banks” once, in passing, in a sentence about the fraud stands in Hall 2. Kate said “e-commerce,” in a joke about warehouses. Nik said he was “with a games company,” and Alex said “I do security stuff,” and that was the entire exchange of professional information among four people whose combined direct reports numbered three hundred and eleven.

Nobody’s title came up. Not once. It was not tact. On a roof, at night, beside an extractor, with a paint tin full of somebody else’s cigarettes, the subject never turned to what anybody was worth.

What they talked about was the hotel.

The lanyards, at length, and the incident with the lanyards, which Michael had got the full account of from Fola and told very badly and very well. The fireplace with no fire in it. Whether the nine hundred glass rods in the lobby were, as Alex insisted, structurally supporting anything — and the fact that Nik knew, actually knew, from a man in the analysis room, that they were not, and that the man in question was an eighty-three-year-old structural engineer who had walked into the lobby on Thursday, looked up at them for four seconds, and said the word “decoration” with genuine contempt, having checked the slab himself in 1973 and never been paid for it.

They talked about Birmingham. They talked about a hotel in Frankfurt that Nik had once been stuck in for three days. Michael did four minutes on a conference in 1991 that had gone so wrong that a man had ended up in a fountain, and there was a point in it where Kate had to put her drink down.

And below them, coming up through the roof, very faintly, under the extractor, there was music.

The Bellwether summit had ended its second day with a thing in the ballroom, and the thing in the ballroom had a DJ, and what came through five inches of concrete and a rubber membrane was not the tune but the low end of it — the bass and the kick, arriving in the soles of the feet rather than the ears.

• • •

The bass came up through the membrane.

Kate was sitting on the low wall with a glass in her hand and Michael was halfway through a story about a man from Basildon.

Her right foot went flat.

Then it began to keep time. Not tapping. Keeping: heel down, the ball of the foot taking the beat. And then, at some point, the shoulder coming into it, a centimetre, on the two and the four.

She had done it in her sleep since she was six. She had done it in a church hall in Amersham in 1993.

Then her phone lit her lap, face up. Tom. The Marrowbone file. Her hand went to it out of thirty years of reflex, and the foot stopped, and she read the message and thumbed a reply and the moment closed over as though it had never been open.

The other three did not notice it happen.

Neither did she.

• • •

The rest of them let go more easily, being further from the office than she was.

Nik, with no requirement to be in the conversation, set up a position in his head: round two that afternoon, the fifteen-year-old from Coventry who had played the opening better than he had and then made the mistake a strong fifteen-year-old makes, which is to be certain. He replayed it from move twenty, giving her the better line, and found it was still fine for him, and gave her a better line again. He took no part in the talk for what must have been ten minutes, while making, somewhere in the middle of it, two remarks that everybody found funny and that he could not afterwards recall.

And Alex, during a gap when the other two were arguing about whether the M42 was worse than the M25, took the notebook out of his jacket, the first time in eighteen days, and turned past the last entry and wrote, in the small square handwriting, in the dark, badly:

syscall audit — batch on the ring buffer, flush on quiesce not interval. also ask him about the second-question thing.

Then he sat with it open on his knee for a while, and put it away.

• • •

And Michael went to the far end of the roof, past the extractor, because his phone was buzzing, and rang home.

It was twenty to eleven, which was too late. Claire picked up because she was up anyway.

“Dad? Is everything all right?”

“Everything’s fine. Is he awake?”

“He’s — Dad, it’s twenty to eleven.”

“I know. It’s just there’s — no, it’s nothing. I’ll ring tomorrow.”

There was a rustle, and then Claire’s voice further off; and then, very close and very loud, a six-year-old:

“HELLO?”

“Sam.”

“Grandad, I’m not asleep.”

“I can hear that.”

“I’m not asleep because Iris is doing the *piano*.”

“Is she any good?”

There was a pause of great seriousness.

“No,” said Sam.

Michael laughed out loud, standing on a roof in Birmingham next to an extractor; and then he said, “Where are you? Are you in bed?” and Sam said he was under the bed, and Michael said why, and Sam said because of a plan.

And then, for eleven minutes, Michael Halloway had a conversation.

He did not ask how school was. He did not ask what Sam had been doing, which is a question that means *give me a report*; and he did not say *and are you being good for Mummy*, which is a question that means *I have run out*. He asked about the plan. He asked what was under the bed. He was told, at length, about a shoe, and about the fact that Iris said the shoe was hers and it was not hers, it was found. He asked how you could tell a found shoe from an owned shoe, and was given a criterion, and objected to the criterion, and was overruled.

At the end of it Claire came back on and said, “What was that?”

“What was what?”

“Nothing,” said Claire, in a strange voice. “He’s very pleased with himself. Night, Dad.”

Michael put the phone in his pocket and stood at the rail for a moment, looking at the lights of the aircraft going round.

Then he took a breath in, and let it out, and went back to the others.

. . .

At ten past midnight they came down.

It was Kate who said it, at the door by the ice machine, with the fluorescent corridor light making all four of them look considerably worse than they had on the roof.

“Right,” she said. “Last night. Monday. All of us, down there, that bar, whatever time. Actual drink, not a — you know. Not a networking.”

“Yes,” said Nik, immediately.

“I’m speaking at two on Monday,” said Michael, “so I’ll either be celebrating or drinking, and both of those want company.”

“I’ll be here,” said Alex. “I mean, I’ll be — yeah. I’ll be here.”

And all four of them meant it, the way strangers mean things: without a calendar invitation, without a follow-up, without any of the machinery by which grown people usually make a plan, and therefore — as each of them understood perfectly well while agreeing to it — with a much higher probability of it actually happening.

12. The Whiteboard

The business centre at The Ardenne was a room off the first-floor landing with two desks, a printer that had been out of magenta since March, and a flip chart on an easel. Its window looked into the atrium. At half past twelve on the Friday night it contained one man, one laptop, and a level of quiet fury that would have frightened anybody who had only met him at a bar.

Michael was trying to open an attachment.

That was the whole of it. Fiona had sent the Group's revised delegation schedule at half past ten, with *worth a look before Monday* on it; and the attachment would not open on the laptop; and the reason it would not open — as Michael had established over the previous twenty-five minutes — was that the bank's mobile device management had decided that The Ardenne's wifi was an untrusted network, and had therefore put the file into a container; and the container wanted him to authenticate; and the authentication wanted a code from an app; and the app wanted the internet; and the internet was the thing it did not trust.

He had rung the service desk at ten past twelve. A very pleasant young man in Bangalore had asked him to describe what he saw on the screen, and Michael had described it, and the young man had said, "And can you see the padlock, sir?"

“I can see four padlocks,” Michael said. “This machine is a Victorian jail.”

Then he had said something else, which he regretted immediately and apologised for; and the young man had been extremely gracious; and Michael had put the phone down and sat in the business centre of a hotel at that hour with his hands on either side of a laptop.

It was not the attachment.

He knew it was not the attachment. He had been perfectly all right about the attachment for the first half of the twenty-five minutes. What had arrived at minute twelve, and had stayed, was a thing with a shape he did not care to look at directly; and its shape was: *there was a period of my life in which this would not have taken twenty-five minutes, and I do not know when it ended.*

That was when Alex went past the window.

• • •

Alex was going past the window because he could not sleep, and the lift lobby on the ninth had the only reliable signal in the building, and he had gone down the stairs looking for a better one and ended up on the first-floor landing.

He saw, through the glass, an old man staring at a laptop in a small bright room at half past midnight, and the set of the shoulders that means a person has stopped trying and has not yet stood up.

He nearly walked on. That was the truth of it, and he thought about it afterwards. He got two steps past the door.

Then he came back and put his head in.

“Are you — sorry. Is it the container thing?”

Michael looked up.

“Ah,” he said. “It’s the chess.”

“It’s the container thing, isn’t it. Where it says it can’t verify the workspace.”

“It says it can’t verify the workspace.”

“Yeah.” Alex came in. “Can I? It’s ninety seconds. It’s not you, it’s — everyone’s is broken. It’s a known thing.”

It took eighty. Alex did not touch the laptop. He stood beside it with his hands behind his back and said, “settings — no, the other settings, the gear — right, network — there’ll be a thing that says something like *use secure gateway*, turn it off, no, it won’t break anything, it’ll just be slower — now open it again.”

The file opened.

Michael sat back and looked at it, and then at Alex.

“Is that it?”

“That’s it.”

“Twenty-five minutes.”

“You’d never find it,” said Alex. “It’s not findable. It’s off by default for everyone except people whose device enrolled before some date, and nobody at your place knows that, and the service desk can’t see it because it’s a local setting.” He shrugged. “It’s not a you problem. It’s genuinely a bad system.”

And Michael, who had been told for three years, gently and by people who meant well, that these things were simply how it was now, felt something in his chest let go by about a quarter of an inch.

“Sit down,” he said. “I’ll buy you a drink.”

“The bar’s shut.”

“Then I’ll buy you a chair.”

• • •

It was Michael who brought up the Ledger Gap, and he brought it up as a man shows somebody a scar: as an anecdote, to be funny about.

“Do you want to hear about a genuinely hopeless problem,” he said. “Not a difficult one. A hopeless one.”

“Always.”

“Right. So. There’s a bank. It doesn’t matter which bank, and there are forty of them like this. It has a core ledger written in 1994, which is the actual heart of the thing — six-point-four million current accounts — and it is, by the way, *excellent*. It does not go wrong. In thirty years I have never once seen it lose a penny.”

“Mainframe?”

“Mainframe.”

“Right,” said Alex, sitting forward.

“And it does everything in a batch, overnight, in a window that starts at ten and has to be finished by four. And bolted onto the side of it, since about 2016, there’s a payments gateway that does everything in real time, because customers now expect their money to move while they’re looking at it — which, leave that. So you’ve got a real-time thing on the front and a batch thing at the back, and every morning at about half past four somebody has to work out whether they agree with each other.”

“And they don’t.”

“They agree about ninety-nine-point-nine-something of the time,” said Michael. “The rest is what we call the Gap. It’s about eleven thousand items a night. And there are nineteen people in Sheffield whose entire job is to sit down at six in the morning and work out what those eleven thousand things are.”

“It was eight thousand in May. A third of the difference is one merchant. A shopping business, homewares and then everything, that refunds people in bursts of about four hundred at eleven at night, through a processor we settle for. Sheffield has a name for it, and I’m not going to repeat it in a hotel.”

Alex had stopped moving.

“How do they do it?”

“There’s a spreadsheet,” said Michael, “which is on its fourth author. And the third author is dead.”

“How long has this been going on?”

“2014.”

“And nobody’s fixed it?”

“Three firms have fixed it,” said Michael. “The first fixed it for nine million pounds and it did not work. The second fixed it for four, and it worked for the current accounts but not for the ones with a joint holder, which is thirty-one per cent of them. The third was a very small, very clever outfit from Bristol, and they got closest; and their managing partner cried in a meeting room on the fourth floor in 2019, and I have never told anybody that, and you can’t either.”

“Why did he cry?”

“Because,” said Michael, “he’d worked out on day nine what it takes everyone a year to work out. Which is that the

problem isn't the reconciliation. The problem is that the two systems don't agree about what *time* it is."

Alex stood up.

• • •

He got the flip chart.

He did not ask whether he could get the flip chart. He wheeled the easel round so it faced the two of them, and took the cap off a marker with his teeth, and said, "Right — sorry — right. Can I ask you a dozen questions and some of them will be stupid?"

"Nobody's asked me a dozen questions in a row since 2013," said Michael. "Go on."

The first four were about the ledger. Michael answered them. The fifth was about the gateway, and Michael answered that one too. The sixth was:

"When the gateway writes a payment, does it write a timestamp, or does it write a sequence number?"

"A timestamp."

"With what precision?"

"Milliseconds."

"From what clock?"

Michael opened his mouth, and stopped.

"I don't know," he said.

"That's the answer," said Alex, and wrote on the flip chart, *WHOSE CLOCK*, and underlined it twice.

And from that point on he was not really talking to Michael at all.

• • •

Because the timestamp is a lie and everybody has agreed to believe it. Not a malicious lie. A civil one. The gateway writes 09:14:22.418 and the ledger writes 09:14:22.418 and the two machines are hundreds of miles apart with two different crystals in them drifting at two different rates, and the protocol that corrects them corrects them *towards* each other, on a schedule, in steps, and between two corrections the machines can be eleven milliseconds apart, and eleven milliseconds is enough. Eleven milliseconds is an eternity. Eleven milliseconds is four payments.

So the spreadsheet in Sheffield is trying to sort a list by a column that does not sort. Every morning nineteen people take a set of events which have a real order — a true, actual, physical order, because the money did move, and it moved in some sequence, and the sequence happened — and they try to recover it from two clocks that disagree, and they do it by hand, and they get it right, mostly, by knowing things. By knowing that this counterparty always posts late. By knowing that the Tuesday file is different. Nineteen people, encoding, in their heads, over eleven years, a correction table for the drift between two crystals. The spreadsheet is not a spreadsheet. It is a clock. A very slow, very expensive clock made out of people.

And the fix is not a better clock. That is the thing. Everybody buys a better clock. You could put atomic time on both ends tomorrow and you would take eleven thousand down to about nine hundred and you would have spent four million pounds to make the same mistake more accurately,

because the mistake is not the precision. The mistake is the *question*.

You are asking two systems *when did this happen*, and neither of them knows. They cannot know. Nothing knows when anything happened. But each of them knows something better, something they have never once been asked, which is: *what had I already seen when I did this*.

That is free. That is sitting there. The gateway, when it writes a payment, has already read a balance, and the balance came from somewhere, and it has an identity, and the ledger, when it posts, has already applied a batch, and the batch has an identity too. So you do not need a time. You need a pointer. Each event carries the last thing it heard from the other side — one field, sixteen bytes, you could ship it in a fortnight — and now every event is not a dot on a timeline, it is a link in a chain, and the chains interlock wherever the two systems actually touched, and *that* order is not an estimate. That order is a fact. It was true when it happened and it will be true in nine hundred years.

And what falls out of it is that most of the eleven thousand are not discrepancies at all. They are the same event seen twice from two frames, correctly, by two systems that were both right, and the only thing wrong was a human being at six in the morning in Sheffield being asked to referee a race between two clocks that were never in the same race.

And the joint accounts — the joint accounts are the *proof*. Because a joint account is the only place in the whole estate where two people can move the same money from two devices in the same second. It is the only genuine concurrency in a bank. Thirty-one per cent failure on joint holders is not a bug in the second firm's code. It is the system telling you, loudly,

for eleven years, in the one place it can, that time is not the thing you are looking for. Order is.

• • •

It went on for two hours and forty minutes.

Michael watched him.

That was, in the end, what the night was: Michael Holloway, sixty-four years old, in a plastic chair in the business centre of a hotel at one in the morning, watching a twenty-six-year-old in a hoodie fill four sheets of flip-chart paper, and tear them off, and stick them on the wall with the little bits of tape that come on the pad, and start a fifth.

He did not follow all of it. He followed about sixty per cent, which was more than he had expected, and considerably more than he had followed in any of the three consultancies' final presentations — because Alex kept stopping and saying “sorry, do you know what a vector clock is,” and then explaining it in forty seconds with a drawing of two people posting letters.

“You can't fix the disagreement,” Alex said, at about half past two, with his hair standing up on one side. “They're both right. They're right in different frames. So you stop trying to have one truth and you have one *order*.”

Michael looked at the thing with the two arrows and said “oh,” out loud, in the voice of a man who has been shown where his glasses are.

And then Alex said, “Sorry. Sorry, I've — you've been sat there for two hours.”

“Do you know what,” said Michael, “I've enjoyed that more than anything I've done since March.”

• • •

At ten to three Alex sat down on the floor with his back against the desk, which is a thing men of twenty-six do and men of sixty-four have to plan.

“Would it work?”

“Some of it. The clock thing works. The rest I’ve made up in two hours in a hotel, so, you know.” He was tearing a corner off a flip-chart sheet. “You’d want to actually look at the data. There’ll be four things in there that break it.”

“There always are.”

“Yeah.”

Michael looked at the wall. Five sheets of paper. Boxes, arrows, a thing that was either a diagram or a fish.

“What do you charge?” he said.

Alex laughed. Then he stopped laughing, because Michael had not.

“I don’t — I’m not a consultant. I’ve got a company.”

“I know. What’s on that wall—” Michael tipped his head at it. “Two of the three firms I paid never got as far as the first sheet. The one that did charged four million pounds, and it took them nine weeks, and there were fourteen of them. You’ve done it in two hours and forty minutes in a hotel with a marker pen, and you keep apologising.”

Alex looked at the floor.

He was aware, he was extremely aware, of a thing happening in his chest that he had not felt since he was a boy, and which was not pride exactly. Pride was familiar. He got pride off a benchmark. This was different, and it had a stranger in it. This was a man with no reason on earth to flatter him, who had not seen his CV, who did not know what his company had

raised or who his investors were or that he had once given a talk in Seattle that two thousand people watched — who had watched him do the thing he was actually good at for two hours and forty minutes, and had then, in the light of that and nothing else, said *what do you charge*.

“It’s just—” he said. “That’s just how I think. It’s not—”

“Yes,” said Michael. “That’s what it’s worth.”

He stood up, and put a hand briefly on the back of the chair, and looked at the five sheets.

“I’m going to make an introduction,” he said. “There’s a fellow at my place who runs the whole of that estate, and I’m going to write to him tonight before I lose the thread of it, and I’ll copy your — what’s it called?”

“Velum.”

“Velum. And after that it’s nothing to do with me, because I’m not on that committee any more, thank God. But he’ll take my call.” He took his laptop under his arm. “Get some sleep. Come and heckle my speech.”

“Two o’clock Monday,” said Alex.

“Nobody has ever come,” said Michael, and at the lift he stopped, and took a breath in, and let it out, and went up to bed.

Alex stayed on the floor of the business centre for another ten minutes, looking up at the five sheets.

Then he took the notebook out of his jacket and wrote, standing up, leaning on the desk:

Told a stranger how I think for 2h40 and he asked what I charge. Nobody at V has ever asked what I charge. Note: he wasn’t being nice. He wasn’t being anything. He just asked.

He tore the five sheets carefully off the wall, and folded them, and took them upstairs.

13. The Old Country

The lobby of The Ardenne had a note and the note was the doors.

Two sets of them, automatic, four metres apart, and every arrival opened both and let the car park in for a second and a half. Under that, the plant. Above the desk, nine hundred glass rods on wires, doing nothing, ticking very faintly against each other when the doors went.

They arrived at twenty past ten on the Saturday morning.

They had taken a train from Euston at 7:41, to be safe. Then a second train, to be safe. Then a taxi. Travelling since a quarter past six, for a journey of ninety minutes.

Ewa Wójcik was wearing the coat.

“Mama, it’s twenty-four degrees.”

“It’s a coat for arriving,” said his mother.

Marek Wójcik was sixty-eight and had a bad shoulder from the print works and carried both bags. When Alex tried to take one there was a short, complete, wordless struggle in the middle of the lobby, which Marek won, as he had won it every time since 2009.

They checked in. It took a while.

Ewa wanted to know about breakfast, and then wanted to know about breakfast again in a different way. Marek stood four feet back from the desk with the bags and watched the

transaction with the total unblinking attention of a man who has been overcharged in three countries.

Then Ewa went up to look at the room and to unpack, which would take forty minutes and could not be hurried.

Alex and his father sat down in two chairs by the fireplace with no fire in it.

“So,” said Marek.

“So.”

“It’s a big hotel.”

“It’s a big hotel.”

His father looked up at the glass rods for a while.

“Twenty-nine pounds,” he said.

“There was an offer.”

“Mm,” said Marek.

• • •

Nik came through the lobby at eleven on his way to the atrium, and Alex did the thing you do, the half-lift of the hand that gives the other person a way out.

Nik did not take the way out. He came over.

“Round three’s at two,” he said, “so I’m free for exactly two hours and then I’m no use to anybody.”

“This is my dad. Papa — this is Nik. He beat me at chess in nineteen moves.”

Marek Wójcik stood up, which took him a second, and shook hands.

“Nineteen. That’s good. When he was ten, if it went past thirty he was crying.”

“*Papa.*”

“It’s true.”

Forty seconds, and the two of them had found it.

Alex sat and watched it happen and could not have said afterwards where the turn was. Somewhere in the first few minutes his father said *when we came*, and Nik said *when did you come*, and Marek said 1994, and Nik said 1999, and there was a small pause. And then the two of them were off into a country Alex had lived beside his whole life and had never once been able to enter.

They did not talk about hardship.

He had assumed, insofar as he had ever imagined this conversation at all, that it would be a comparing of wounds.

It was almost all logistics, and it was very funny.

They talked about the first flat. Marek’s had been in Leyton, two rooms, with a meter that took fifty-pence pieces, and the landlord had been a man called Costas who was, Marek said, “not a bad man. But always he is thinking I steal the fifty pence. From my own meter.” Nik’s had been his uncle’s box room in Leicester, with a wardrobe he could not fully open because of the bed.

They talked about the documents. Both of them, it emerged, had a plastic wallet. Marek’s was blue and lived in a drawer in the kitchen and had done for thirty-one years, and contained every piece of paper the Home Office had ever sent him, in order, including the envelopes. Nik’s was clear and lived in a fireproof box. When he admitted the fireproof box, Marek nodded slowly and said, “Yes. Yes. I should think about this,” in the tone of a man conceding a technical point.

And they talked about the language.

“The words were fine,” Marek said. “Words you learn.” He stopped, and made a small quick circling gesture with two fin-

gers, and did not find what he wanted, and went on without it. “It’s the speed. They talk, and you have the words, all of them, every one, and then they finish — and you are still one sentence behind.”

He turned his hand over.

“And then they look.”

“And then they look,” said Nik.

“So you say nothing.”

“So you say nothing.”

“For me, six years.” Marek shrugged with the good shoulder. “At the works there was a man, Tony. He thought there was something wrong with me. Six years he thought this. Then one day the machine breaks and I fix it, and everybody is standing there, and Tony says: *Marek, you’re a dark horse.*” A pause. “Twenty years we were friends. He came to Alek’s christening. But six years.”

• • •

Nik watched him.

He watched him for the whole two hours, in fact, and would have been unable to explain why he did not go and prepare for round three.

Marek Wójcik was sixty-eight. He had come over at thirty-seven with a wife, no English, and a trade that did not transfer. He had done nights at a bakery on Bethnal Green Road and days at a print works for ten years — which Nik had done the arithmetic on within about ninety seconds of hearing it, ten years of four hours’ sleep, and had then done again as a total, and had then stopped. He had bought a flat in 2006 and

paid it off in 2021, and was now retired, and had a bad shoulder, and had come to Birmingham on two trains to see his son for a weekend.

And he was *calm*.

Nik kept looking for the other thing and could not find it. He knew what he was looking for, because he carried it: the low hum under everything, the running total, the eye that goes to the price on the menu first.

He had assumed, without ever putting it into a sentence, that the hum was simply what this life did to a man. That in thirty years he would be a version of himself with more money and the same hum. That this was the deal.

Marek Wójcik did not have the hum.

He had an opinion about the coffee. He had a long and detailed complaint about a train company. He asked Nik four questions about Chennai and listened to all four answers. And when Ewa came down and said the room was fine but the pillows were “like a paper”, he said, “So we ask for another pillow” — and Nik watched a man solve a problem in six words at a volume of about thirty per cent, and understood, and covered the understanding by drinking some water.

The fear ends, Nik thought.

Not: the fear was never justified. It had been justified. Six years of saying nothing at a print works in Leyton is not a misunderstanding.

It ends.

He had not known, at forty-two, that this was available.

• • •

Alex sat slightly outside the conversation with a coffee going cold.

He knew what he had always felt in this situation. He had catalogued it at eleven, at fourteen, at nineteen, at every parents' evening and every school gate and every one of the times his father had come into the Velum office. A hot, tight, contemptible, automatic wish that his father would say the sentence slightly differently.

He had heard the gap where the gesture went. Of course he had. He heard every one.

And nothing happened.

He waited for the flinch and it did not come, and in the space where the flinch had always been there was the other man, leaning forward with his elbows on his knees, listening.

And then it went, the way they went, sideways and complete and ninety seconds after he had stopped looking for it.

Because what the other man was listening to was a person who had arrived at thirty-seven in a country whose language ran at a speed he could not hold, with a wife and a trade in his hands that the country would not accept as a trade, and who had gone and got a job that started at eleven at night and a second job that started at seven in the morning, and had done both of them for ten years without once being late, and had in that decade learned an entire second country the way you learn a machine — from underneath, by taking the covers off, by finding out what the fifty-pence meter actually did and what the landlord could and could not legally do about it and which of the four men on the night shift would tell you the truth about overtime — and had come out of it able to rewire a flat and rebuild a gearbox and diagnose a broken web press by the sound it made through a wall, and had put a dead Compaq

Presario on a kitchen table in front of an eight-year-old and said *this one's yours, it doesn't work*, which was the single most useful sentence anybody had ever said to Alex Wójcik, and had then gone out to work and left him to it for eleven weeks, and had never once come in to see how it was going.

His father was interesting.

He had spent twenty years hearing him as a mistake.

Ewa took a photograph of the three of them without asking, badly, at an angle. It is the photograph that would eventually sit on a shelf in a flat in Bow.

. . .

They got round to it because Nik asked, plainly, the way he had asked about everything else.

“So how is it going, the company?”

And Alex, who had said *it's great* to these people on the phone eleven days ago, said, “It's — there's a thing with my co-founder.”

He told it badly, in the version that made everybody reasonable. The whiteboard. The compliance module. The twenty-two seconds of silence. The fact that Ben was a good man. The fact that there was nothing you could photograph.

Marek listened without moving.

At the end he said, “Is he a liar?”

“No. Genuinely no.”

“Is he stupid?”

“He's the least stupid person I know.”

“Mm.” Marek looked at the fireplace with no fire in it. “So he is fast. And you are—”

He hunted for it, and did not find it in English, and used the Polish word. Alex translated it in his head as something between *thorough* and *slow*. It was accurate and it was not an insult.

“So. He is fast, and you are that. And the room goes to who is fast.”

“Yes.”

“Yes,” said his father. “This I know.”

He turned in the chair.

“Aleksander.” He said it to the fireplace rather than to his son. “You don’t have to be loud to be right.”

Alex looked at the floor.

“That doesn’t help, though,” he said, more sharply than he meant to. “That’s a nice thing to say, but the room *does* go to who’s fast. Being right quietly is just being wrong slowly.”

“I didn’t finish,” said Marek.

“Sorry.”

His father took a while over it. He was not building to anything. He was looking for words in a language that had never quite fitted him.

“You say it one time,” he said. “Slow. Then you stop, and you don’t say it again.”

A pause.

“If you say it one time and stop, they have to look at it. Three times, it is noise.” He turned his hand over. “And if you don’t say it, then it was never in the room. And after, you are angry with them. For a thing they never saw.”

Two feet away, Nikhil Raghavan put his water down.

“At the works I said nothing, six years,” Marek went on, to nobody in particular. “Then the machine was broken.”

The doors went, and let the car park in, and shut.

• • •

Nik went off to round three at twenty to two and lost, comprehensively, to a man he should have beaten, because he was not there.

Marek and Ewa and Alex had lunch in the restaurant, under a ceiling with a return vent in it that ran a full tone above the lobby. Ewa asked about the food four times. Marek asked about the compliance module and was told about it and understood roughly none of it and asked two further questions anyway.

And at the end, when Ewa had gone to find the toilets, Marek Wójcik said, looking at his son across a table:

“You are all right?”

And Alex said, “Yeah. Tired. It’s a big year.”

And his father — who had spent thirty-one years, four hours of sleep at a time, on exactly one thing in this world, and who had known since the moment he walked into that lobby that something was badly wrong with his son — looked at him for a second and a half.

“Good,” he said. “Then we go and look at this canal your mother has read about.”

14. The Second Board

She found him on the Saturday afternoon in the worst chair in the building.

The Ardenne had a first-floor landing with a window that looked down into the atrium, and somebody in 1998 had put two armchairs there facing the glass, and nobody had sat in them since, because they faced the wrong way and there was a draught. Michael was in one of them with a conference programme he was not reading, watching a hundred and seventy-six people play chess in silence four metres below him.

“This is a terrible chair,” said Kate.

“It’s a magnificent chair. It’s the only place in this hotel where nobody can find you.”

“I found you.”

“Yes,” said Michael, “well,” and moved the programme off the other one.

15:40. The board arrived at five for dinner. She had two hours, less the twenty minutes it would take to change.

Eleven hours of it on Friday. Six on Saturday. Certain, in front of sixty-one people, for seventeen hours in two days. She had come up the stairs to find somewhere quiet to read the deck for the ninth time, and had seen him through the glass, and had not read the deck.

They watched the chess for a while. From above it looked like a system. A hundred and seventy-six people bent over

eighty-eight boards under the strip lights. Every so often, somewhere in the grid, one of them stood up and stretched and walked about. You could tell from the walk who was winning.

“Can I ask you something properly?”

“That’s ominous.”

“It is.”

Michael put the programme down.

• • •

“If I do this well,” said Kate, “what happens?”

“Do what well?”

“This. Say I’m right about everything. Refill lands in September. The board takes fourteen on Sunday and doesn’t put a knife in me for it. We do fourteen, then twelve, then we buy someone and I run it, and it works. Say I don’t fail.” She was looking down at the boards. “What happens? At the end?”

“Of the company?”

“Of me.”

Michael did not answer immediately.

“How old are you?”

“Forty-one.”

“Right.” He looked at the atrium. “Then the honest answer is that you’ll be extremely good at it. That’s not a compliment, it’s a diagnosis. In about four years you’ll notice you’re better than everyone in the room at almost everything; and it will be true; and it will be the most dangerous thing that has ever happened to you, because from then on the fastest way to get

anything done correctly will always, always be to do it yourself.”

“Yes,” said Kate quietly.

“And you’ll be careful about it. You’ll have an operating rhythm. You’ll have a document. And you’ll put in a review, because there was an incident, and the review will be temporary.” He glanced sideways. “Was there an incident?”

“There was a payments migration.”

“There’s always a payments migration.”

“And then you tell me it all goes wrong.”

“No,” said Michael. “That’s the bit nobody tells you. It works. Everything gets better. The numbers get better, the board gets happier, the thing gets bigger. And what you will not be able to see from inside it is that every time you put your hand on something, you take one unit of judgement off somebody else; and they don’t grow it back; and eventually you’re running a company of two hundred very capable people who all wait.”

“For how long?”

“Until you’re forty-nine, and there’s a Sunday night in November where you’re on a call at eleven o’clock about a thing that happened in a room you weren’t in, and you think —”

He stopped.

“What?”

“I should have been there,” said Michael.

Kate turned her head.

“How do you know that sentence?”

“Because it’s mine.”

He said it lightly. That was what she noticed. The same voice he had used the night before to describe closing four hundred branches. Then he did not follow it with a joke. The absence of the joke was so loud that Kate found herself holding her breath.

“Right,” he said. “You asked me what happens at the end. I’ll tell you once and then we’re talking about something else, because I have a rule and I’ve already broken it twice this weekend.”

“You don’t have to.”

“I know I don’t have to.”

He turned the conference programme over.

“You’re looking at it. I optimised everything except the part that was the point. I got it all right — every single decision, taken on its own, at the time, with the information I had, right; and I’d take most of them again. And they add up to a man of sixty-four who is deeply respected by four hundred people, who had to be told twice about his own granddaughter’s recital before he registered that he wanted to go, and who at some point in the last five years stopped being consulted about anything that matters and has been too proud to notice out loud.”

“And the cost was worth it.”

“The cost was fine. I want to be clear about that, because people get it wrong in the other direction and it’s just as stupid. Nobody in my family has ever been frightened of a letter. That’s what I bought. It was worth having.” The strip lights hummed. Below them, somebody won something. “I’m not sad, either. Sad would be a great deal easier; sad you can do something with. I’m just extremely well organised, and it’s four o’clock, and I don’t know what to do with the afternoon.”

Kate sat with her hands in her lap.

“That’s the most frightening thing anybody’s ever said to me.”

“Yes, well,” said Michael. “That’s why I’ve got a rule.”

• • •

They did not talk for a bit, which she found she could do with him.

Then Kate said: “Come and work for me.”

“No.”

“You haven’t heard it.”

“I’ve heard several hundred of them.”

“Not as an operator.” She had turned round in the chair. “I’ve got a board of seven people. Two of them are money. Three are excellent and busy. Harriet is a force of nature. And there is not one single person on it who has ever *run* anything the size of the thing I’m running. They have all governed. None of them has ever had a Sunday night.”

Michael was quiet.

“I want you as an advisor. Not a NED — I don’t want you in the governance, I don’t want you liable for anything, I don’t want you reading a hundred-page pack at eleven at night. I want to be able to ring you. That’s it. That’s the whole job. Four board meetings a year if you can be bothered, and a phone that answers.”

“You’d be paying for a phone call.”

“I’d be paying for the answer to *since when*,” said Kate. “Which I got last night for a gin and tonic, and which is going to save me on Sunday morning, and which I could not have

got from anybody I work with, or anybody who works for me, or anybody on that board — because every single one of them would have been forming a view about me while I asked.”

There was a long pause.

“That,” said Michael, “is a very well constructed argument; and I notice that you have made it without once using the words *mentor* or *journey*, and I’m grateful.”

“Is that a yes?”

“It’s a—”

He looked down at the chess.

“Can I tell you the actual reason I’m hesitating? It isn’t the time. I’ve got nothing but time; that’s the joke.” He turned the programme over again, and stopped turning it. “It’s that I have been *rung*, for eleven years. There’s a phrase people use. *Only Michael can sign that. We’ll need Michael in the room.* And I would like to tell you that I found it wearing, and I did, and I also—”

His mouth did something.

“There’s a thing that happens to a man when the phone stops. And I have spent about two years pretending that I had stopped answering it, when in fact it had stopped ringing. Those are extremely different. I have never said that out loud in my life.”

Kate did not say anything.

“Yes,” said Michael. “All right. Yes.”

“Really?”

“On one condition, which is that you never once ring me to make you feel better. If you want to be told you’re doing well, ring your mother.”

Kate laughed, and the laugh had a crack down the middle of it that neither of them chose to look at.

“My mother,” she said, “is not really in that line of work.”
“No,” said Michael. “Mine wasn’t either.”

• • •

He said the last thing on the stairs, as she was going down and he was not.

“Kate.”

She stopped four steps below him.

“Your problem last night. The number.” He had his hand on the rail. “That was the first thing in about five years that somebody wanted *me* for, and not the job. I’d like it noted that I know the difference. That’s all.”

Then he made a joke about the chair, and she laughed, and went down.

19:00. She went into a dinner with seven board members and was, for three hours, delightful. Harriet Nash said, over the coffee, “You seem well,” and Kate said, “I’ve had four hours’ sleep and I feel wonderful, which is medically concerning,” and Harriet laughed. **23:30.** Kate went up to eleven, read the deck twice, and slept six hours without waking once, which had not happened since March.

And on the fourth floor, Michael Halloway sat on the end of a hotel bed and rang Ruth and told her about a woman who had offered him a job that consisted of a telephone. Ruth said, “And what did you say?” and Michael said, “I said yes.”

There was a pause on the line.

“Michael,” said Ruth, in a voice he had not heard in some years. Then she said she had to go, because there was something in the oven, which there was not.

15. Version 4 (Final) (Final v2)

At 8:49 on the Sunday morning Kate Merrick opened the folder to put the deck on the lectern machine, and the deck was wrong.

She knew it in about a second and a half, from the third slide, before she had read a word of it. The third slide was the market map. The market map on the screen had four boxes. The market map she had built on Wednesday had six, and the two extra boxes were the entire argument.

She scrolled.

Slide seven had the old growth bridge. Slide eleven had a table of Refill assumptions with an August launch in it. Slide fourteen. The one that mattered, the one she had rebuilt four times, the one Michael had unlocked for her in a bar on Thursday night, the one that said *since March we have been running a piece of work to establish whether twenty-two was recoverable, and here is what it cost us to find out, and here is what we found instead* —

Slide fourteen did not exist. In its place was a chart titled *FY26 — Path to Target*.

It was the version from the second of July.

Eleven minutes.

• • •

The first thing she felt was not panic. It was a kind of clean bright fury, and it had a name in it.

Dawn.

She had sent the final on Wednesday night at 11:40. She had sent it with the words *this is the one. Please make sure this is what's in the board folder and kill the others.* She could see her own message. She could see it with total clarity, as you can see anything at 8:49 on a Sunday morning eleven minutes before a board.

She rang.

Voicemail on the second ring. Which meant the phone had been declined. Which meant, and her mind produced this instantly with the wrong emphasis on every word, *she's asleep.*

She rang again. Voicemail again.

And then, in the way these things arrive, in the exact worst order, the memory came up. Tuesday. The corridor by the lifts. Dawn with her coat half on and a phone in her hand, saying something. Kate walking, reading.

Dawn had said it. She had actually said it, the words were there, they had been sitting in a drawer all week. *"So I'm going to be off Sunday, Marcus has got the thing with his chest again, they've said to keep him home and Steve's away, so I won't be reachable, is that going to be—"*

And Kate, walking, reading, had said: "Course. Fine. Do what you need to."

She had half-heard it between two other things. She had heard it and filed it and it had not survived contact with Thursday.

Nine minutes.

• • •

There was nobody to call.

That is a sentence that means nothing to most people and everything to about four hundred thousand people in this country. Kate stood in the service corridor behind the Warwick Suite. Grey carpet tiles, a stacked trolley of chairs, a fire door. She went through it properly, because she was a person who went through things properly.

Gareth had the file. Gareth was in London. Gareth would take four minutes to answer on a Sunday and would then need to be told where to look. The file was in a personal drive. He did not have access to the personal drive. Setting up access to the personal drive required — she thought this through, to the end — Dawn.

Tom did not have it. Tom had never had it.

The board were in the room. Harriet was in the room. She had seen her go in at 8:44 with a coffee.

There was a version of this in which Kate walked in at nine and said *the wrong file's in the folder, give me fifteen minutes*, and it was, objectively, survivable, and would have been forgotten by Tuesday.

She knew that. She knew it *at the time*. She stood in a service corridor and knew that the reasonable move was to walk in and say a true sentence.

And she could not do it. Because in eleven minutes seven people were going to be told that a number she had personally put in front of them for four consecutive years was wrong, and the only asset she had in that room was that she was the person who did not drop things.

Seven minutes.

And that was when it started.

• • •

It came up from the feet. Nobody had told her that.

Her hands went first. Not shaking — *gone*. A sort of hot absence in them. Then her chest closed by about a third. Then her vision did something at the edges. Then her heart went at a rate that she noted, with the part of her that never stopped taking minutes, was well over a hundred and forty.

She got a hand on the trolley of stacked chairs.

She had done fourteen-hour days for eleven years. She had done a fire in a warehouse. She had done the week in 2022 when the funding fell over. She had never once, not for a second, had her body simply refuse. The horror was not the symptoms. It was the *insubordination*. The discovery that the thing she had been driving for twenty years had a view.

She got her breath by counting the carpet tiles. Not a technique. Just what was there.

And then her hands, which had done this ten thousand times, did the thing they did.

They took out the phone. They found the name. They pressed and held.

• • •

She spoke for ninety-one seconds.

She did not shout. That is what would matter later. That is what made it what it was. If she had shouted it would have been a bad moment from a woman under pressure. Dawn would have forgiven it before it finished playing.

Kate Merrick's voice, on the recording, is perfectly level. It is warm at the start. It is the voice she uses on stage.

"Dawn — it's me. It's eight fifty-two on Sunday. I'm standing outside the board and the deck in the folder is the second of July version."

A pause of two seconds.

"I need you to understand what that means, so I'm going to say it once. Slide fourteen isn't in it. I built slide fourteen over four days last week and it is the only reason this meeting doesn't end my career, and I sent it to you on Wednesday night with a message that said, and I'm reading it, *please make sure this is what's in the board folder and kill the others*. And you've either not read it or not done it, and either way I've got—" a breath "—six minutes.

"And I can't call you, because you're not available, because I'm apparently the only person in this company for whom Sunday is a working day.

"I have never once said this to you, so I'm going to say it now. There is a difference between a job and a role. A job is a list of things and you do them and you go home at five with your tupperware and your shoebox. A role is where you are accountable for an outcome and you carry it, and it does not stop at five, and I have been carrying yours for two years and pretending it was mine.

"I'm going to go into this room now and do the best forty minutes of my life from memory. And when I come out we are going to have a completely different conversation about what you are for.

"Do not ring me back."

She stopped the recording. She looked at it for one second. She sent it.

Then she put the phone in her jacket, and straightened her jacket, and walked in at 8:59.

• • •

She was magnificent.

There is no other word and there were seven witnesses. She stood at the front of the Warwick Suite with the wrong deck on the screen behind her and said, at 9:01:

“You’ve got a version in front of you that’s two weeks old. Ignore it. I’ll send the right one this afternoon. I’d rather talk than click.”

And then she did it from memory. Forty-four minutes.

She rebuilt the market map on the flip chart with a marker in four minutes. Six boxes. It was better on the flip chart than it had been on the slide, because you could watch it being built. She did the growth bridge as numbers spoken out loud, in order. When Simon from Hollis asked for the September Refill sensitivity she gave him three scenarios to one decimal place without notes.

And at 9:26 she said the sentence.

“Since March we’ve been running a piece of work to find out whether twenty-two was recoverable. It isn’t. I want to take you through what it cost us to find that out, and what we found instead.”

Nobody moved.

At 9:31 Harriet Nash said, “Since March,” in a voice with nothing in it.

And Kate said, calmly, having been told the answer by an old man in a bar on Thursday, and having had thirty-six hours

to make it hers:

“Yes. I could have brought you a worry in March. I brought you a finding in July. The interval is mine and I’ll own it; and if you’d rather have the worry next time, tell me now and you’ll get it, and I’d advise against it.”

Harriet looked at her for four seconds.

“No,” she said. “You’re right.”

• • •

At 10:40 they broke for coffee.

Kate went out into the corridor with the good, high, floating feeling of a fight won, and got her laptop off the side table, and thought: *right. Send them the actual deck.*

She opened the drive.

Board / FY26 / Summit / Final.

There were four files in it.

*FY26 Board — v3.pptx FY26 Board — v4 FINAL.pptx
FY26 Board — v4 FINAL v2.pptx FY26 Board — v4 FINAL v2
(KM edits).pptx*

She opened the last one. Slide fourteen. Six boxes. Every number she had built on Wednesday night, exactly where she had left it. Timestamped 23:41 on Wednesday.

She sat down slowly on the edge of the side table.

Then she opened her sent messages and read the one from Wednesday night, and read it again, and then a third time, very slowly, until the word stopped meaning anything.

Dawn — this is the one, please make sure this is what’s in the board folder and kill the others.

Under it, at 23:42, Dawn's reply. Which Kate had not opened at the time, and had not opened since.

Will do first thing. Just so you know I can't get into your personal drive (never could) so I can only put in what you drop into the shared one. Have dropped in what's there now, shout if it's not the right one.

And under that, at 23:44, from Kate herself. One word, sent from a bed, at the end of a fourteen-hour day, in the four seconds it took to reach across and turn out a light:

Perfect.

. . .

She had dropped v4 FINAL into the shared folder on the second of July.

She had built v4 FINAL v2 (KM edits) on the Wednesday. In her own drive. At 11:41 at night. She had saved it and told a woman with no access to that drive to make sure it was the one in the folder. Then she had read a reply saying *I can only put in what you drop into the shared one*, and had typed the word *Perfect*.

There was no error. No forgetting, no dropped ball, no assistant who did not care. There was a woman who had done exactly what she said she would do. Who had flagged the risk in writing at 23:42 on a Wednesday. And who had then, on a Sunday morning, with a sick seven-year-old on a sofa and her husband away, received ninety-one seconds of the calmest voice in England explaining the difference between a job and a role.

Kate sat on the side table in the corridor of the Warwick Suite.

She opened the phone. She went to the message. She looked at the little grey icon, the waveform, the *1:31*. At the word underneath, which said *Delivered*. And below that, in smaller grey letters:

Played 09:14.

Played at 9:14. On a Sunday morning. Fifteen minutes after Kate walked into the room.

There was no button.

She looked for one anyway, going through the menus of an application she had used four thousand times, looking for a thing she knew perfectly well was not there.

“Kate?” said Harriet Nash from the doorway. “They’re ready when you are.”

16. What the Board Gave Her

10:52. The board of Bellwether went back in. It came out at 12:31. In between it did the thing it had been assembled to do, which was to hold a chief executive to account.

It went well.

They took fourteen. They took it after fifty minutes of proper work. Simon from Hollis pushed hard on the September sensitivity and was right to. Kate gave him a worse answer than she wanted to, and said so, and he accepted it. There was a difficult eleven minutes about the Kettering warehouse. Harriet Nash asked one question about Gareth Pryce that had four other questions inside it, and Kate answered the outer one and let the inner ones stand, and Harriet let her.

At 12:24 Harriet closed her folder.

“Right,” she said. “Before we break. I want to say something, and I want to say it while everybody’s in the room, because I’m not going to say it in a call.”

Kate, who had been picking up her pen, put it down.

“Four years ago this business did eleven million and had a warehouse in Erith with a hole in the roof.” Harriet was not looking at her notes. “This morning we were told a number we didn’t want to hear, by the person who found it, before we had to ask for it, with the work behind it and the alternative already built. That is not a common experience for a board. I

have sat on eleven of these and I have had it perhaps three times.”

Somebody made a small noise of agreement.

“I want it minuted that this board considers the chief executive’s handling of the FY26 planning cycle to be exceptional,” said Harriet. “And personally—” and here she did look at Kate “—I’d like to say the thing that boards never say, which is that I don’t know what we’d do without you. I genuinely don’t. I’ve thought about it, because it’s my job to think about it, and I don’t have an answer.”

Simon said, “Hear, hear,” in the slightly embarrassed way that people say it.

And one of the money people clapped. Twice. Then stopped, having established at speed that nobody else was going to. He turned the second clap into a movement towards his water glass. A save so smooth, so instantly deployed, that Kate thought with real admiration: *you have done that before*.

“Thank you,” she said. “That means a great deal.”

• • •

Here is what she felt.

Nothing.

Not modesty. She checked. Not the thing where a compliment arrives late and lands in the evening. She waited for it in the evening too.

Nothing at all. A flat, clean, echoing nothing, of the kind you get when you put your hand into a pocket you were certain had something in it.

She sat at the table in the Warwick Suite while seven people gathered their laptops. She looked at the words in the air where Harriet had left them. *Exceptional. I don't know what we'd do without you.* She turned them over like a coin in a foreign currency.

There was no denomination on them.

Exceptional. A teacher had written that word on a piece of paper in an italic hand when she was nine. Her mother read it at the table and was warmly delighted. Then she asked about the maths.

Thirty-two years. Every distinction, every promotion, every round, every fourteen-hour day.

This morning a board of seven had said the words in the correct order, in a minuted meeting, unprompted.

They were not a payment.

. . .

The lift from the ballroom level to the eleventh floor takes fifty-one seconds when it stops nowhere, and it stopped nowhere.

She rode up alone with a laptop under her arm and did the whole thing in fifty-one seconds. That is what happens when a structure that has stood for thirty years lets go. It does not come down slowly.

I chose them.

She had recruited Harriet Nash in 2021 out of a shortlist of four, over a perfectly good chairman from retail. She had said it out loud to the search consultant. It was in the notes, under *strengths*. “She’ll be harder on me.” She had taken Hollis over

a cheaper term sheet because they were known to be demanding.

Four years ago, with her own hands, in daylight. She had assembled seven intelligent people whose function was to be difficult to please. Installed them above her. Given them the authority to grade her.

And what about the maths.

They would take fourteen. They would take fourteen and say *exceptional*. On Tuesday the pre-work for the next cycle would start. In November there would be a number, and the number would be a function of the last one. Nowhere in the whole apparatus was there a score at which anybody said *that's enough now*.

The lift said *eleven* in a woman's voice.

Kate did not get out. She stood there and let the doors open onto an empty corridor with a trolley on it, and put her hand into her jacket pocket for the key card.

And her hand found the phone.

. . .

She stood in the open lift doorway holding it.

It was still there. It was going to be there tomorrow, and next Tuesday, and in a year. A small grey rectangle with a waveform in it and *1:31* underneath, and, under that, in letters of a size that has no business carrying that much:

Played 09:14.

She had gone into a room this morning and given the performance of her life. She had come out with the only two sentences she had ever wanted. Neither made any difference to

the ninety-one seconds. Sent at 8:52. To a woman on a sofa with a seven-year-old who could not breathe properly. Saying, in the calmest voice in England, that she did not understand the difference between a job and a role.

The verdict and the bill. Same morning.

She got out of the lift. She went down the corridor. In the room she put the laptop on the desk and sat on the end of the bed with her coat still on. She did not cry. She could not, and had not since 2016, and had once mentioned this to a doctor in a way she had made funny.

At 1:14 she wrote a message to Dawn.

I'm so sorry. I was completely wrong and I've just found out how wrong. Please ignore everything I said. How's Marcus?

She looked at it for a while.

Then she deleted it, and wrote:

How's Marcus?

And deleted that.

Because Dawn would answer it inside four minutes. She always did. It would be kind. Kate would read it and feel better. That would be the whole transaction. Relief for Kate, on a Sunday, billed to a woman with a sick child who had done nothing wrong.

The same machine. Running the other way.

She put the phone face down on the bed.

She would have to do it in a room. With her face. On Tuesday.

13:25. She sat there for eleven minutes, which was the longest she had sat still and done nothing since a flight to Singapore in 2023. Then she got up and opened the laptop.

There were forty-one messages. The alternative was to go on sitting there.

• • •

At 6:40 she went down and had dinner with Harriet, at Harriet's suggestion, in the restaurant, and it was the best conversation the two of them had ever had.

Harriet talked about her divorce, which Kate had not known about. Harriet said, "You know you don't have to be at everything," and Kate said, "I know," and Harriet said, "You don't, though," and Kate laughed and said, "I really do know."

Then Harriet told her about the 2011 shareholder meeting. A man had stood up during the resolutions and read out, at length and with feeling, a list of grievances concerning a car park.

"Not our car park," said Harriet. "That's the thing. He'd come to the wrong AGM. He was extremely well prepared. He had photographs."

"What did you do?"

"We let him finish. He got a round of applause." Harriet drank some wine. "He was right about the car park, as it turned out. Somebody looked into it."

At 9:15 Harriet said, "That was lovely. You seem — I don't know. Different this weekend."

And Kate said:

"It's the hotel. It's got a roof you can get onto."

And Harriet said, "How do you know that?" and Kate said, "A man told me," and made it funny, and made Harriet laugh. Then she went up to bed.

17. CC

Room 914 had an extractor in the bathroom that came on with the light and stayed on for eleven minutes after it went off.

He had timed it on the Thursday. Eleven minutes, and a small dry tick in it at the top of the impeller, and under that the ninth floor's air handling, and under that nothing.

He read the thread on the Sunday afternoon because he was avoiding his parents.

That was the true and shabby reason.

They had gone to a canal on Saturday and loved it. On Sunday morning his mother had produced a printed itinerary that included a garden centre. At two o'clock Alex said he had one work thing, and went up, and opened the laptop.

Forty-one milliseconds to London.

Velum ran on a shared workspace with about four hundred channels in it. He had built the workspace when there were nine of them and was still in all four hundred, because leaving a channel is an act with a meaning and rejoining one is worse.

The channel was `#bd-pipeline`. He had not read it in five months.

The first message was Ben's, from Saturday morning.

 warm intro from a COO at **Lauriston** (the bank) overnight — straight to me + Saul. Alex do you know anything about this?? Says he met one of us at a hotel. Decade-old reconciliation prob-

lem, 19 FTE in Sheffield, three consultancies burned, and he says our architecture is “the first thing anyone’s shown me that starts in the right place.” Reading between the lines this is eight figures.

And pasted under it, Michael’s email. Four short paragraphs, no adjectives except the load-bearing ones, one joke. It said he had spent an evening with the CTO of a company called Velum. It said this person had got further into the problem in two hours and forty minutes than three firms had in eleven years.

It ended: *The man you want is Aleksander Wójcik. Talk to him, not about him.*

Alex read that last line twice.

Then he scrolled.

Saul (09:31): this is unreal **Ben** (09:34): I know. ok I’ve come back proposing Tues 9.30, me + Saul, at theirs **Saul** (09:36): can we get Alex? feels like an Alex meeting **Ben** (09:41): he’s at a hotel thing with his parents til Tues, taking them to the airport Tues am. Don’t want to pull him out, he never takes time off and I’ve been leaning on him hard. Bring him in for round 2. **Ben** (09:44): also for a first meeting with a bank we want the commercial conversation, not a 2hr architecture session where they think we’re a consultancy **Saul** (09:45): 100% **Ben** (14:20): call w/ their programme director just now — the recon thing’s real but what they’re actually *buying* this year is com-

pliance evidencing, new regime lands Q1, budget's sitting in that line. Told them we ship a compliance module this quarter (true), recon is phase 2. He lit up. **Ben** (14:31): and if this converts the Arcus story changes completely. team + tech + a bank. different multiple. Let's not say that out loud yet.

Alex sat on the end of the bed.

He's at a hotel thing with his parents.

True. Kindly meant. He had said it to Ben himself, in a corridor, on the Wednesday.

The extractor was still going. Four minutes left on it.

• • •

Then he opened a new tab, because he wanted to be fair, and went and found the demo.

It was in a branch called `causal-order`. He had pushed the first cut on the Saturday after the business centre, having come up from the business centre at three and not slept, and had kept at it in the evenings while his parents were in bed.

Nine hundred lines.

And it was the cleanest thing he had written since the interceptor, because the whole of it turned on refusing to answer the question everybody asks, which is *when did this happen*, and asking instead the one both machines can answer for nothing, which is *what had I already seen when I did this*. You take the gateway's write and you hang on it the identity of the last batch it heard about. You take the ledger's post and you hang on it the identity of the last balance it read. Sixteen

bytes on each side, a field nobody has to compute, because both numbers are already sitting in memory at the moment of writing and are currently being thrown away. And then you do not sort. Sorting is the mistake. You walk the two chains and wherever they touch you have a fact — not an estimate, not a tolerance, a fact, the same fact in nine hundred years — and everywhere they do not touch you have two events that never met and never could have, and which the nineteen people in Sheffield have been reconciling every morning since 2014 because a column of milliseconds told them the two things happened in an order that nothing in the universe actually put them in.

It took two synthetic ledgers with deliberately disagreeing clocks, and eleven thousand items a night of drift, and ordered them by causality, and produced one number. How many items a human being in Sheffield would have to look at in the morning.

The number was fourteen.

He ran it again while he sat there, because it was the only thing available to do with his hands, and watched it come out at fourteen, and it took eleven seconds.

He had built the thing Michael's email was about. He had built it in thirty hours, unasked, on holiday, for free.

There was a meeting on Tuesday morning about compliance evidencing. He was not in it.

• • •

He rang Ben.

“Alex! Mate, are your folks having a nice time? Where are you, still up north?”

“Yeah. Listen — I saw bd-pipeline. The Lauriston thing.” He had stood up. He always stood up for the ones that mattered. “That intro’s mine. The COO — I did the architecture with him on a flip chart on Friday night, that’s who it’s from. And I’ve built a working demo of the recon fix. Thirty hours. It takes eleven thousand items a night down to fourteen. It’s in a branch, it runs. So I think — I should be in the room Tuesday. I can move the airport, my dad’ll understand, I’ll—”

“Alex, that’s *incredible*.”

And Ben meant it. You could hear that he meant it.

“Fourteen? From eleven thousand? Mate, that’s the whole — OK. OK. So here’s what I’m thinking, and tell me if I’m wrong—”

And he was off. Warm, fast, unbeatable.

That Tuesday was a *commercial* first meeting. That if Alex walked in and opened a demo they would read Velum as a consultancy and anchor on a services price instead of a platform price. That the demo was “genuinely the round-two trump card, we do not want to burn it in the room where they’re deciding whether we’re serious people.” That Alex should absolutely present it — “you, not me, it’s yours” — at the second meeting, once the commercial frame was set. And that in the meantime he would be with his mum and dad, “which, mate, you *never* do, I’m not letting you sack that off for a first-meeting handshake I can do in my sleep.”

“But it’s—” said Alex.

And he heard it go.

In real time. On the phone. Standing in room 914 with the extractor going.

The volume coming out of his own voice. And the sentence he had built on the stairs — *it's not a services deal and it never was, the recon fix is the platform, the compliance thing is the mannequin, you're selling the wrong thing and it has my name on it* — arriving in his mouth as

nothing.

Not blocked. Not swallowed. Not there. And there was no way to say that, because saying it would have needed

“—yeah,” he said. “No, you’re right. Round two.”

“You’re a legend. Enjoy your folks. We’ll do this properly next week, with you driving.” A grin down the line. “And Alex — genuinely. Fourteen. You’re a machine.”

“Yeah,” said Alex. “Thanks.”

He put the phone down.

• • •

He sat on the end of the bed.

The extractor ran. It had four minutes on it and then it would stop and the room would get bigger.

He waited for it the way he waited for the other thing, sideways and complete and ninety seconds after you stop hunting.

The extractor stopped.

Nothing arrived.

• • •

His phone went. His mother.

We are at the front. Papa says the garden centre closes at 5. It is 4. He says we go now or we don't go.

Alex looked at it for a moment.

coming, he typed.

He went down in the lift and across the lobby past the fireplace with no fire in it, and out through both sets of doors into the car park, where his father was standing beside a taxi with the door already open, holding it, in the sun, waiting.

"Everything all right at the work?" said Marek.

"Yeah," said Alex. "Nothing important."

18. That's Nice, Nik

Sunday was a double-round day, and Nikhil Raghavan won both of them.

He won round four in the morning against a very solid man from Nuneaton who had beaten him in 2023, and he won it with a piece sacrifice on move twenty-two that he had not calculated. That was the part he kept coming back to. He had sat there with eleven minutes on his clock and had seen four moves of it, and had thought *and if it doesn't work* — and had then, for the first time in about six years, thought: *then it doesn't work*.

It worked. It was worth one point. The point was worth nothing, and he sat looking at the position for a while anyway.

He won round five in the afternoon in eighty minutes, against a junior who played the opening off a video and had no idea at all what to do when it ran out. There is a particular expression on the face of a fifteen-year-old at the exact move his preparation stops, and Nik, who had worn that expression himself in three currencies and on two continents, enjoyed it a good deal more than he was proud of.

Between the two he had a jacket potato in the atrium café with Wilf Tanner, who had drawn both his games and was disgusted about it. The potato was six pounds fifty and had been under a lamp since about eleven. Nik ate all of it.

“Two draws,” said Wilf, in the voice of a man reporting a bereavement.

“They happen.”

“They happen to other people.” He said four things about the Nuneaton game, all of them technical, and one about the sacrifice, which was: “You’d have played Rc1 on Thursday.”

“I know.”

“Mm,” said Wilf, and ate his soup.

Walking out of the playing hall at the end of the afternoon, into a corridor with a window in it, Nik discovered that he was — the word arrived, and he inspected it and turned it over and found no fault in it — *happy*. That he had been happy for most of a day. And that this had last happened on some date he could not produce.

He rang home at six.

• • •

Meera picked up on the fourth ring with a noise behind her that was Rohan doing something to a saucepan.

“Hi. Hang on. *Rohan*. Hi.”

“Is it a bad time?”

“It’s six o’clock. It’s always a bad time. How’s the chess?”

And Nikhil Raghavan, standing in a corridor with a window in it, at the end of the best day he had had in a year, opened his mouth and heard himself say:

“Really good, actually. I won both. I’m in the top group now.”

There is no top group at the Midlands Open. There is one Swiss, and after five rounds Nik was on four out of five, which

put him equal second on the live standings on a laptop by the arbiter's desk. Equal second is a true and excellent thing and it takes seven words.

"That's brilliant. Wait — both? In one day?"

"Two rounds today. And the morning one was against a guy who's beaten me before, and he's — I mean, he's rated about two hundred points above where I am."

He was rated forty points above. A hundred and sixty points, added in the half-second between one clause and the next, at no cost, the way a figure gets rounded up in a room where nobody has the source data.

"So that's a proper scalp. Nik, that's amazing."

"And I've been playing well. Like — actually well. Attacking." That part was true. "The hotel's a bit grim, but there's a decent restaurant and I've been going to bed at eleven, so I've had about thirty-five hours of sleep in four days."

Four and a half a night. Up until one on the Thursday with a boy at a chessboard, and half past twelve on the Friday, which is eighteen hours across four nights against the thirty-five he had just put in the air. The restaurant was fine. He had eaten in it once, for nineteen pounds, and had afterwards thought about the nineteen pounds for considerably longer than he had thought about the meal.

"You sound completely different."

"I feel completely different."

"Good." A crash somewhere. "*Rohan*. — Sorry. And there's people to talk to? You're not just sitting in the room?"

And here it came.

"Yeah, no, it's been really social. There's a whole crowd of us — there's an old boy who's a retired engineer, he's fantastic, and I've been having dinner with a group of them, and there's

a guy who's the CTO of a security startup, and a woman who's a CEO, and this COO from one of the big banks. We all went up on the roof on Friday and stayed up there half the night."

Sentence by sentence, true.

"Wow," said Meera. "Look at you."

"I know."

"That's nice, Nik."

• • •

He did not notice for about four seconds.

He was already going on — something about the standings, something about Tuesday — and there was a delay, the way there is when you walk past a shop you used to know. Then the sentence came back round and hit him in the side of the head.

That's nice, Nik.

Flat. Warm. Not cold, no edge on it anywhere. The exact tone in which you say *that's nice* to a four-year-old who has told you about a dream. Pleasant, and complete, and it asked nothing further.

And then, stacked up behind it like carriages, every other time.

That's nice, Nik, about the promotion in 2021.

That's nice, Nik, about the chief executive ringing him personally.

That's nice, Nik, four years ago, when he came home about the funding round, said while looking for a shoe.

She was tired. She was extremely tired, and he had built a good deal on it.

A tired woman asks *and then what happened.*

She had run the test a few hundred times — *is this the size he says it is* — and got the same answer, and stopped running it, without a decision and without a row.

“Nik?”

“Sorry. I’m here.”

“You went quiet.”

“Signal,” said Nik.

“Right.” A pause, and then, in a different voice, the real one, the one from before: “Are you all right? You sound—”

“I’m fine. I’m great. I’m going to go and get some food.”

“OK. Well done today. Genuinely.” And then, half off the phone: “*Rohan. Give it to Mummy.*”

She went.

• • •

He did not go and get food.

He went up to room 812 and sat at the little desk and opened *2020 household v3*, because he had promised himself in a kitchen in Woking that he would do it properly at the hotel, and because after twenty minutes in a corridor doing it properly seemed suddenly possible. A clean, cold, adult act.

He opened the credit card. He typed the number into the cell.

Nothing exploded. The twelve-month view at the bottom went from a small positive to a number in brackets, and *closing balance, month 12* turned red, because he had written the conditional formatting himself in 2020.

He looked at it for a minute.

Then he began to work.

He ran it four times.

Run one. As is. Chennai at nine hundred a month, plus one lakh sixty for the physiotherapy in August. Anaya's school at eleven-forty. Croatia in the last week of August, four thousand two hundred all in, booked in January, one instalment paid. Result: they ran out in the third week of September, the card went up by about three thousand, and the twelve-month closing sat in brackets at five figures.

Run two. Cancel Croatia. He got the cancellation terms up in another tab. Fifty per cent retained after the first of July, so cancelling recovered two thousand one hundred pounds and cost the family the only week of the year in which Meera did not do bedtime alone. It worked. It worked to the tune of a hundred and forty pounds a month of slack.

Run three. Keep Croatia, take Anaya out of the school. Eleven-forty a month, straight out, from September. The model went green so hard it was almost funny. He sat and looked at it, and wrote in the notes column, in the language of a professional: *state alternative available from Sept, wait list, mid-year entry.*

Then he sat and thought about the actual thing. A nine-year-old told in August that she will not be going back to where Sofia and Nell and the whole of her life are, told it by a father who earns a hundred and eleven thousand pounds a year.

Run four. Cut Chennai. Nine hundred to four hundred, no physiotherapy package, which meant the government hospital, which meant nine months on a knee already stopping his father walking to the end of the road. He typed it in and looked at the green cells and sat back.

There was no version.

That was the finding, and he was a man who respected a finding. No arrangement of these numbers gave his father a knee, his daughter a school, and his wife one week, and he had been avoiding that since March in the way that only a man who is extremely good at arithmetic can avoid arithmetic.

He was the chief financial officer of a company with eleven million pounds in the bank. Nine people had listened to him on a call ten days ago and gone away reassured.

It was ten to nine on a Sunday evening and he could not afford his own life.

• • •

The message came at 8:56.

Meera: The school payment's been declined. They've emailed. It says the direct debit was returned on Friday and there's a £25 charge and it has to be cleared by Thursday or she can't start the term. It's £1,140.

Meera: Nik there isn't £1,140 in the joint account. There's £310.

Meera: What's going on?

He did not move.

The transfer had gone on the Wednesday. Seventeen hundred pounds, to Chennai, out of the joint account instead of the other one, because he had done it standing in a kitchen at eleven at night, in the app, on the phone, with the reference typed in as *ROUTINE*.

Three hundred and ten pounds.

He did not convert it into anything. The machine had run every figure he had met for twenty-six years, and it looked at this one and had nothing to say about it at all.

Nikhil Raghavan sat at the desk in room 812 of The Ardenne, with a spreadsheet in front of him in which the numbers had at some point stopped being numbers, and a phone in his hand, and a suitcase against the wall with a name tape sewn into the lid.

Outside the window the car park, and the ring road, and the aircraft going round.

Somewhere below him, four floors down, a hundred and seventy-six people were putting the pieces back on the boards for the morning.

19. A Profile Very Like His

He rang home at half past nine on the Sunday, and Claire answered, because Sunday was Ruth's swimming and Claire was there.

"Dad? Twice in one week."

"I know. I'm going peculiar."

"How's Birmingham?"

"Birmingham is enormous and beige, and there's a chess tournament in the lobby. Listen — I wanted to ask about the twenty-seventh."

"The twenty-seventh?"

"Iris. The recital. St Barnabas."

"Oh!" said Claire. And then, "Oh — no, Dad, don't worry, it's fine."

"No, I know, I just — I've looked at the calendar and there's nothing, so I thought I'd—"

"Honestly, don't. It's a church hall and it's forty minutes and half of it is a boy called Rufus doing 'Für Elise' at a speed nobody has ever attempted. It's not a thing."

"I'd like to come."

There was a pause of about a second and a half; and it was in that second and a half, before she had said anything at all, that Michael, who had spent forty-two years reading rooms for a living, understood that something was about to be said that he was not going to be able to put down.

“Dad,” said Claire, kindly, warmly, without a single grain of anger in it, “we figured you couldn’t. It’s fine. We didn’t even put you down for a seat.”

• • •

He said, “Right.”

“They only give you four,” said Claire, “and it’s me and Danny and Mum and Sam, and Sam won’t sit anyway, so honestly, it’s—”

“No, of course.”

“If you’re around we’ll just — I’ll ask, they might do a fifth, but they were quite—”

“Don’t ask anybody for anything,” said Michael. “That’s completely fine. That’s — you were right.”

“Was that all right? I didn’t mean—”

“It was entirely all right. Give her my love. Tell her I want a recording; and tell her that if there is a boy called Rufus playing ‘Für Elise’ too fast, I want that in the recording as well, uncut, because I intend to be unkind about it.”

Claire laughed. “I’ll ring you tomorrow.”

“Do.”

He put the phone down on the bed.

Then he sat on the end of it in room 402 with his hands on his knees, and looked at the wall, and did the arithmetic, because he was constitutionally incapable of not doing arithmetic.

There had been no fight. That was the whole of it. There was not, anywhere in that conversation, a single thing to appeal against: no accusation, no reproach, no *you never came*

to *anything*, no held breath, no woman on the other end of a telephone saying *well, it's a bit late now, Dad*. If there had been, he could have done something with it. He had spent his working life in rooms where somebody was angry; and an angry room is a room where you still matter.

Claire had not been angry, because Claire had finished.

At some point — five years ago, eight, he had no idea, and would never find out, because the moment had not been marked, because these moments never are — his family had run out of the version of him that came, and had rebuilt itself, competently, around the version that did not. They had four seats and four people. The arrangement was stable. It had been stable for years. It was not a wound they were nursing; it was a shape they had settled into, the way a house settles, the way a village builds its road around a hill.

He had not been excluded. He had been *routed around*, in the way you route around weather: without resentment, as a fact about the world.

He had taught Claire to swim. He wanted that noted; and he noted it, sitting on the end of a hotel bed in Birmingham with the phone in his hand. He had. In 1993, at the pool in Bushey, with a float; and he had probably said something encouraging; and she had probably swallowed a good deal of water.

He could not remember one afternoon of it.

He got up, and looked at himself in the mirror of a hotel bathroom for slightly too long, and then took a breath in, and let it out, and went and put on a clean shirt, because at two o'clock he had to give a speech.

The keynote went well.

The Warwick Suite held four hundred and there were perhaps two hundred and eighty in it, which for the closing slot of a four-day conference is a triumph; and Colin, who had asked for him by name, introduced him and mispronounced the bank's name.

Michael was funny for six minutes, and then serious for eleven, and then funny again; and the eleven serious minutes were the best public speaking he had done in a decade. He did the history of retail operations since 1986 and did not once mention transformation. He said the sentence about the main-frame and got the laugh he had banked on, and it went up the room like a wave — because every single person in that hall was running their actual business on something written before the audience's juniors were born, and nobody had said it out loud in four days.

He did nine minutes on the Ledger Gap, honestly, with the thirteen million pounds in it and the man from Bristol left out; and at the end of that section a woman in the fourth row put her hand up in a keynote, which does not happen, and asked a real question, and he answered it, and she wrote it down.

And then he came to the end, and did the thing he had planned in the shower, which was to say:

"They asked me for a closing reflection on why we do this. I've been trying to write it for three weeks and I couldn't; and at about four o'clock this morning I worked out that this was because it's the wrong question. The right question is *who did you tell.*"

A beat.

"Because the whole of our job, all of it, every day, is that we find out what's actually happening and then we tell somebody.

That's it. That's the trade. And the reason it's hard is not that finding out is hard. Finding out is the easy half."

It was good. It got a proper hand.

He came off and a queue of people wanted to talk to him and he was charming to all of them; and a man from a building society in the north-west said, "That was the only useful thing anyone's said all week," and shook his hand with both of his.

And Michael went back to room 402 and sat down and thought: *there was no paragraph about why we do this.*

He had written round it. He had done forty minutes, and taken the exact question he had been asked, and turned it, with great skill and real charm, into a different one that he could answer; and two hundred and eighty operations people had applauded, and eleven had queued, and one had said it was the only useful thing all week — and not a single human being in that room had noticed that a man had stood in front of them for forty minutes and declined to say why he had spent his life doing this.

Because he still did not know.

• • •

Terry Nwosu rang at twenty past six.

Michael was in The Long Room by then, with a gin and tonic and the conference programme, in the good chair at the end of the bar; and he looked at the screen and felt, for about a second, straightforwardly pleased.

He had hired Terry in 2003 into a job Terry was not ready for, over the objection of two people; and had then spent years

quietly making sure he did not drown. Terry now ran the whole of the retail estate at a bank three times the size of Lauriston. They spoke perhaps twice a year, and Terry sent a case of wine at Christmas that was always slightly too good.

“Terrence.”

“Michael. Where are you? It sounds like a bar.”

“It is a bar. I have just given the closing keynote at the Banking Operations Forum, which is a sentence I’d like you to sit with.”

“Was it any good?”

“It was superb, and I shall be forgotten by Thursday.”

Terry laughed. Then he did not say anything for a moment; and Michael put his glass down on the bar mat, because he had known Terry Nwosu for twenty-two years, and there were a handful of things that man did with a silence, and this was the bad one.

“Go on,” said Michael.

“Right. OK.” Terry breathed out. “I’m going to tell you a thing, and I want to say up front: I don’t know it. I want that on the record. I don’t know it, and it may be absolutely nothing.”

“Understood.”

“Marguerite Bell rang me on Thursday. She’s at Harrow Vance now, doing exec search — she was at Ridgeway when we used her in 2018.”

“I know Marguerite.”

“She rang me to sound me out about someone. Not for a job — she wanted a reference on a candidate, and the candidate’s someone I worked with at Lloyds, and it’s fine, it’s a good reference, I gave it.” Terry paused. “And at the end I said, out of politeness, *what’s the role?* And she said she couldn’t say.

And then she said — and this is the whole of it, Michael, this is everything I have — she said: *it's a group operations role at a mid-size UK bank, and it's a confidential one, so I can't.*"

The bar hummed. Denny put a glass down somewhere.

"And you thought of me," said Michael.

"I thought: there are eleven banks that fit that. And then I thought about the profile she was asking about — early fifties, big transformation background, ran a core migration, spent two years in the Group transformation office of a competitor — and I thought, that isn't a hire. That's a *replacement*. Because nobody builds that spec for a new seat."

"No," Michael agreed. "They don't."

"It might be Skipton. It might be four other places. It might be a first-line risk job with a stupid title." Terry's voice was tight. "I nearly didn't ring. Amara said don't ring, you'll put a thing in his head for six months and it'll be nothing."

"You were right to ring."

"Was I?"

"Yes," said Michael. "You were right to ring, and I'd have done the same, and thank you; and now we are going to talk about something else, because there are exactly two things I can do with this information and neither of them is available on a Monday evening in a hotel in Birmingham."

They talked about something else for eleven minutes. Terry's eldest had got into Durham. Michael said the correct things and meant them.

"Michael," said Terry, at the end.

"Mm."

"Are you all right?"

"I'm marvellous," said Michael. "I've had a lovely day. I taught four hundred bankers about the 1994 core ledger, and a

woman in row four asked me a question.”

“Right,” said Terry, and let him have it; because he had known him twenty-two years, and there was no other way this had ever gone.

• • •

Michael put the phone face down on the bar.

He picked up the gin and tonic and found that it was empty, and that he did not remember it becoming empty.

“Denny,” he said. “Same again. And then I want you to tell me something. How long have you worked here?”

“Nine years.”

“Nine years. Right. So in nine years you have watched several thousand men in this exact chair receive a telephone call and then order another one, and I want to know what the record is.”

Denny grinned. “For drinks, or for phone calls?”

“For the interval between the two.”

“About four seconds,” said Denny. “It was a man from a print company. He didn’t take the phone away from his ear.”

“Ha!” said Michael.

It came out of him at full volume: the bark with the rise on the end, the convincing noise made by a professional. It went across the bar and reached a group of banking delegates by the window, one of whom turned round and smiled at him — a nice man, a man from a building society in the north-west, who had said that afternoon that it was the only useful thing anyone had said all week.

And Michael heard the laugh die.

He heard it go out flat across the carpet and land on nothing, in an empty bar at twenty to seven; and he sat with the sound of it still in the room, and understood, with the same clean administrative clarity with which he had once understood a set of accounts, that he had just made a joke to a barman about the telephone call in which he had been told he was being replaced, and that there was nobody at all in the building he was going to tell.

Then he remembered that there was a drink at nine, with three people whose surnames he did not know.

“Denny,” he said. “Make it a large one.”

20. Everything Said

Nik got there first, at five to nine, because he had been sitting in his room since half past seven unable to be in it.

He took the round table in the corner of The Long Room, the one under the bad print of a canal, and ordered a lime and soda, which was two pounds ten. He looked at it. Then he ordered a beer as well, which was six pounds forty, and did not look at that.

He had not replied to Meera. That fact had been underneath everything for twenty-six hours: nine things typed and none sent, and then, that morning, *I'll sort it, don't worry, I'll call you tonight*, and back, a single word, *ok*, which had sat in his phone all day like a stone in a shoe.

Alex came in at four minutes past nine, fast, jacket still on, and sat without taking it off. In his pocket was a phone with `#bd-pipeline` on it and a message from Ben at 6:12: *Tomorrow's going to be big. Enjoy the family time mate, you've earned it 🙏*

Michael arrived at 9:11 from the far end of the bar, where he had been since twenty past six, carrying a fresh drink and a face that would have got him through a board meeting.

Kate came in at 9:20, twenty minutes late, off a call, sliding the phone into her bag as she sat.

And for eleven minutes it was fine.

Michael did a routine about the conference's closing lunch, in which a man from Nationwide had been served a plated dessert during his own presentation. Alex told the Alabama story, and Nik laughed, and the coat came into it. Kate said "the roof" and everyone spoke at once.

Then Michael said, "Right. It's the last night, and we've none of us said one true thing since Friday, and I propose we keep it that way."

Everyone laughed.

And Kate leaned back and said, "Oh, I don't know. I'd quite like to."

• • •

She had gone thirty hours in the presence of a thing she was forbidden to fix.

She had not, in four years, gone thirty hours without fixing something.

"Alex. Your co-founder's going to sell the company. Eleven months, tops. He'll be lovely about it the whole way and you'll find out from a document. The tell isn't that he talks over you. The tell is the twenty-two seconds. Nobody waits twenty-two seconds unless they've already decided and they need it on the record that they asked. You built something in a hotel this weekend for *free*. What did you charge?"

"I don't—"

"Nik." She turned. Her glass had not moved from where she put it down. "You told me at breakfast what your job's like the way people describe weather. If you can't say a number to

your own board — and I’ve watched you not say one to *me*, twice, and I don’t even work with you—”

“Kate,” said Michael.

“—then you’re not a CFO, you’re a very expensive narrator, and somebody finds out in a quarter that hurts. And Michael, you should retire. You’ve told me yourself you’re respected and not needed and it’s four o’clock and you don’t know what to do with the afternoon. So *go*. Before they teach the whole company to plan around you and then one day stop—”

“You’re doing the thing,” said Alex.

“—I’m being useful.”

“You’re doing the thing you do. You’re solving us so you don’t have to sit here.” Alex’s voice had gone somewhere odd. Not loud. “You’ve diagnosed three people in ninety seconds and you’re *pleased*.”

“That’s not—”

“It’s a bit contemptuous, actually,” said Alex.

And Kate stopped, because it was, and she knew it was, and there was nowhere in her to put it.

• • •

It could have ended there.

The glass washer under the bar ran its cycle and stopped.

“You made an introduction,” Alex said, to Michael.

Michael put his glass down.

“I did.”

“At three in the morning. And by nine the next day my co-founder had it, and by half nine he’d booked a meeting for tomorrow that I’m not in, and by two he’d turned it into a com-

pliance sale — the thing I said in June was a mannequin — and the reason I’m not in the room is *you*.”

He was leaning forward. The jacket was still on.

“You handed him the only thing I’ve ever built that anyone outside a computer has valued. You put my name in the email — *talk to him, not about him*, I read it — and it took him eleven hours to route around me with it.”

“Alex, I said I’d write. You said two o’clock Monday—”

“Why didn’t you send it to *me*?”

Michael did not answer.

“You didn’t do it for me,” he said. “You did it because you liked being the man who makes an introduction at three in the morning. No committee, no phone ringing, so you found a kid with a marker pen and got to be somebody’s benefactor for four hours. And then you sent it to the CEO instead of the engineer, because that’s who men like you send things to.

“You’re a mascot. You’re the funny old man everyone’s fond of who hasn’t said one real thing all weekend, and you’d rather be liked than useful, and I know exactly what it is because I do the same thing with silence—”

“That’s enough,” said Kate.

“No, it isn’t,” said Alex, and stood up, and then did not have anywhere to go, and sat down again.

• • •

“Right,” said Nik, into it, too quickly, half up, patting his jacket. “I’m getting these. My shout — I’ve had a good week, four out of six, and it’s been a good year, we came off a strong quarter, so this one’s on the studio—”

“Lodestone Games,” said Kate.

Nik stopped, half standing.

“That’s who you’re at. You said the studio and the Sunward milestone at breakfast, and I looked it up, because I look everything up. Your publisher’s got a clawback on that milestone at the end of November — it was in a piece in January — two-point-four million, against a runway that’s six months if it slips. And it’ll slip, because the producer’s missed every date they’ve set. And Hollis are on your board. Hollis are on mine. I know what they’re like in a quarter where a date moves.” She had not raised her voice either. “And you’ve just told this table you’re buying a round off a strong quarter, in front of two people who can’t check and one who can. Why?”

“Kate,” said Michael. “Leave it—”

“Because I have three hundred and ten pounds,” said Nik.

The table went quiet in a different way.

“That’s what’s in the account.”

He sat back down. His voice had gone flat and careful, and the accent was a shade more there than it had been all weekend.

“My daughter’s school payment bounced on Friday. I sent my father money on Wednesday out of the wrong account. I’ve run the family budget four times in that room upstairs and there’s no version that works. So — no. It has not been a strong quarter. And I don’t know why I said it, except that I always say it. And my wife said *that’s nice, Nik*, and I’ve been thinking about the way she said it for two days.”

“Nik, I’m sorry,” said Kate. “That was—”

“It’s fine.”

“It isn’t.”

“No,” he said. “It isn’t. But there’s nothing else to say, so.”

• • •

Michael had not spoken for four minutes.

When he did, it was in a voice none of them had heard, because it had nothing in front of it: no warmth, no timing, no joke waiting at the end of the sentence to take the weight off it.

“You’re right,” he said, to Alex. “I should have sent it to you. I knew the reason while I was doing it, and you’ve said it out loud, and I’ll not sleep tonight. So — yes. I’m sorry. And I’ll fix the part I can fix.”

Alex, who had braced against everything except that, said nothing.

Michael turned the glass a quarter turn on the table.

“And now I’m going to give you the other half, because you’ve earned it, and because nobody else in your life is ever going to.” He did not raise his voice. “Nobody talks over you. I’ve watched you for four days and I don’t believe it. What happens is that everyone in your company waits, and you don’t come. And after a while they get on with it, because a business has to. You have trained forty people to spare you. It isn’t cruelty; it’s a service they provide. You’ve been accepting it for two years and calling it being silenced.”

“That’s—” Alex’s mouth was open.

“The day you stop, it stops. And then you’ll find out whether you were right, which is the thing you have actually been avoiding.”

Nobody said anything. Somebody at the bar ordered two of something.

He turned to Nik.

“And you didn’t lie to your wife to spare her. You’ve told yourself that for years and it’s the wrong way round. You did it

because a man who says the plain thing has to sit there afterwards while somebody decides what to make of him; and you would rather be three hundred pounds from the edge on your own than looked at for four seconds by somebody who loves —”

“You don’t know my marriage,” said Nik, sharp.

Michael stopped.

There was a second where it could have gone either way.

“No,” said Michael. “I don’t. I take that back. That was mine, not yours.”

He looked at Kate last. This one he got out whole.

“You solved three strangers tonight, brilliantly, because on Sunday you did something you can’t fix from a hotel, and you’d rather take a room apart than sit with it. And you have asked me to be your advisor, and I’ll do it; and you’ll ring me for twenty years and take nothing, because you don’t want advice. You want a witness who’ll tell you that you were right to be tired.”

Kate did not move.

“There,” said Michael.

He stood, and put a note under his glass, more than the drinks.

“That’s everything I’ve thought all weekend. Most of it’s true. None of you asked for it. I’ll be ashamed of it in the morning, and I’ll not take a word of it back except the one I already did.”

“Michael—” said Kate.

“Goodnight,” said Michael Halloway.

And went.

And they heard him say something to Denny at the bar on his way past — something ordinary, something with a lift on

the end of it — and heard Denny laugh.

• • •

They sat there.

Denny came and cleared two glasses, and left the third where it was with the note under it, and did not ask if they wanted anything.

“He was right,” Nik said eventually.

“About all of it,” said Kate.

Alex was staring at the door. “I shouldn’t have said mascot.”

Nobody told him it was all right.

They tried twice more to talk. Kate said something about the roof. Nik said something about the last round in the morning. Both times the thing got up onto its feet and sat back down.

The note under Michael’s glass was a twenty. Nik had seen that from across the table without meaning to, the way he saw everything, and it was, near enough, the round he had stood up to buy, and none of them touched it.

Then they went up.

21. Checkout

Michael checked out at ten to six.

There was one person on the desk, a young man called Bogdan who had been on since ten the previous night; and he printed the folio and said, “Was everything all right with your stay, sir?” and Michael said, “Yes. Thank you. It was a good hotel,” which was not a joke; and Bogdan, who had been dealing with a coach party since four, did not notice that anything had happened.

He thought about leaving a note.

There were three room numbers he could have found in ninety seconds. He worked out what the three lines would have to say, and could not write the first one, because the first one would have had to begin *I was told on Monday evening that* — and he had not said that sentence out loud to anybody, including Ruth; including Terry, who had told it to him.

So he put the folio in his coat and went out at 5:54 into the dead grey light, and the M42 was already going.

• • •

Kate’s car came at ten past seven, the first pickup of the day, and the driver was Vasyl again, which she took as an omen without deciding what kind.

She had been packed since half past five.

She did not knock on anybody's door. She thought about it in the lift. What stopped her was not shame, or not only. It was that she had run the conversation and could not make it end anywhere. *I'm sorry* leads to *it's fine*. *It's fine* leads to nothing. And Kate Merrick did not initiate processes that had no defined output.

That fact about herself arrived while she was standing in a lift. She looked straight at it. She got out on the ground floor anyway.

Somewhere past the airport turn she closed the laptop and said, out loud, to a field with a pylon in it:

"I'm being useful."

"Sorry?" said Vasyl.

"Nothing," said Kate. "Talking to myself."

"Is fine," said Vasyl. "I do it also."

• • •

Round seven began at half past nine, and Nikhil Raghavan lost it in fifty-four moves.

He had white on board fourteen against a Norwegian woman of about thirty who was half a point ahead of him on the live standings. A win put him equal first. A draw got him about ninety pounds. A loss got him nothing and left him on four out of seven, which is a perfectly ordinary result that nobody remembers.

On move nineteen he was slightly worse, and had a choice.

He could shore it up. There was a move — g3, small and ugly and reliable — that would have made the position solid and dull and about fifteen per cent worse for the next four

hours, and would almost certainly have ended in a draw around move sixty. On the evidence of six years of score sheets, it was what he did.

Or he could push the pawn.

Pushing the pawn opened his own king. It was, he calculated for twenty minutes, probably objectively worse. It made the position sharp in the way where being sharp is the only thing that saves you, and if it went wrong it would go wrong in about six moves, and everybody in the hall would be able to see it.

And if it doesn't work.

Then it doesn't work, thought Nikhil Raghavan, and pushed the pawn.

For nineteen moves it was the best chess of his life. He knew it while it was happening, which is rare. He had a rook doing something on the h-file that he had never in his life had a rook doing.

The Norwegian went into a thirty-four-minute think on move twenty-nine and came out having found the only move. Then the only move again. Then on thirty-five she found something he had not looked at, and it was over, slowly, across the next nineteen moves, in a dignified way.

He resigned at 1:20 in the afternoon.

And walking out of the playing hall into the corridor with the window in it, he checked, the way you check a limb.

Nothing.

Not nothing as in numbness. There was disappointment, sitting there quite plainly, the size of a lost chess game, which is not a large size. What was absent was the other thing: the hot crawling backwash he had carried out of every loss since about 2019, the one that was not about chess at all, that used

to last two days and used to make him short with Anaya on a Sunday evening for no reason she could see.

He had lost, in public, having taken a risk, in front of a hall.
And he was fine.

• • •

Wilf Tanner was in the analysis room with the position already set up, which meant he had been watching.

“Nineteen,” he said.

“I know.”

“Was it sound?”

“No,” said Nik, sitting down. “I think g3 was better. By about a third of a pawn.”

“Mm,” said Wilf, and moved a piece, and moved it back.

They went through it. It took twenty minutes and Wilf found two improvements, one of which was beautiful, and neither of which changed the result.

Then he began putting the pieces away, and said, without any particular emphasis, in the same voice he had used to say *don't eat the fish*:

“So did you work it out? What you were protecting.”

Nik sat with his hands on the table.

“I've got about half of it.”

“Go on.”

“I thought it was money.” He watched the old man's hands. “That's the obvious one, and it's true — there's a genuine amount of money involved and I'm not going to pretend otherwise. But that's not it, because the money's been fine for a decade and I've been doing this for twenty-six years.”

He stopped.

"I think what I'm protecting is the four seconds."

"What four seconds?"

"When you've said a thing and they haven't got it yet. And they're looking at you, deciding." He looked at the half-cleared board. "I found out at about twenty-two that if you polish it, they never do that. And I've built an entire professional personality out of never letting anybody have those four seconds. And it's cost me my wife, more or less, and it nearly cost my daughter a school, and I only found that out on Sunday."

"That's more than half," said Wilf.

"It doesn't feel like it."

"No," said Wilf. "It never does."

He put the box in his bag and did the zip.

He did not say *and now you must stop doing it*. He did not say *well done*. He did not say *I'm sure it'll all work out*. And Nik, who had braced for all three, sat in the enormous space where none of them was.

"Same time next year," said Wilf. "You're on four. That's a decent event."

"I lost the one that mattered."

"You lost the one that was interesting," said Wilf, and stood up, which took him a while, and shook hands, and went.

• • •

Alex's parents flew at 6:40 from Terminal 2, and they got there at 2:15, because Ewa Wójcik had a view about airports formed in 1994 and never revised.

They had four hours. They had a coffee, and a second coffee. Ewa found a shop and bought a scarf for a neighbour and consulted Alex about it at length, and Alex said the right things. At about half past four she went to look at the perfumes, which she did at every airport in the world and had never once bought anything.

Marek and Alex sat in two moulded plastic chairs at the end of a row.

Terminal 2 ran at about a hundred hertz and never stopped. Air handling, the travelators, a floor polisher two gates down, the PA coming over the top of all of it every ninety seconds to say the same four things to different people.

Marek did not say anything for a long time. He sat with his hands on his knees, in the good jacket, an old man with a bad shoulder in an airport.

He waited.

He had been waiting four days. He had waited on the Saturday by the fireplace, and at the canal, and outside the garden centre on the Sunday afternoon when his son came out of the hotel with a face like a closed shop, and at the museum on the Monday. He had counted, without meaning to, the number of times Alex checked his phone on the Monday.

It was fifty-one.

He had a single conviction about his son and it had not changed since a kitchen table in 2007: *he will tell me when he can*.

So he waited.

At 4:50 Alex said, "Papa."

"Mm."

There was a pause of about ten seconds.

“Do you want the last of that?” said Alex, and pushed the crisps over.

“Ah,” said Marek. “Yes.”

They ate the crisps, under the hundred hertz.

At 5:20 Ewa came back with nothing, as always, and said the perfume section was a disgrace, and it was time. And there was the business of the bags, and the short struggle over who carried what, which Marek won.

At the barrier his mother held on slightly too long and said into his shoulder, “You’ll come at Christmas. Properly, not one day,” and Alex said, “I’ll come at Christmas.”

And his father shook his hand, because they had never been a family that embraced at barriers, and held it a second longer than the handshake, and then they went through, and his mother turned round twice and waved, and his father did not turn round at all, because he could not have managed it.

• • •

The hotel reset its lobby at four o’clock.

The congress came out of the atrium in ninety minutes: eighty-eight trestle tables back into the van from Coleshill, the SILENCE PLEASE easel folded, the pairings off the notice-board and into a bin bag. Housekeeping did the bedroom block floor by floor. The Warwick Suite went back to round tables of ten for a pharmaceutical distributor’s regional awards on the Wednesday, and the fern lanyards and the banking lanyards and the third colour all went into the same box.

By six the fireplace with no fire in it had four new people sitting in front of it, and the nine hundred glass rods were doing what they did. Nothing.

• • •

At 4:41, on a train out of Birmingham New Street, Nikhil Raghavan created a group.

He had all four numbers, swapped on the roof on the Friday — quickly, with the phones held up in the dark, and Michael complaining about the size of the letters.

He typed the numbers in. He looked at the field that said *Group name*, and typed *The Roof*, and deleted it, and typed *Ardenne*, and left it.

Then he sat with his thumbs over the keyboard.

He got as far as *Well* — and deleted it. He got as far as *I want to say sorry to all of you and* and deleted that. He tried a joke about the fireplace and deleted the joke.

The train went through Coventry.

At 5:09 he put the phone in his pocket with the group created, four names in it, and nothing sent.

Nobody wrote in it that day. Nobody wrote in it that week.

And the four of them went home — one to a flat in Bow, one to a house in Woking, one to a flat by the river with a hundred and forty messages in it, one to a house in Hertfordshire where his wife had made a shepherd's pie because he was early — with the armour off, all of it, every plate of it, and nothing underneath it yet.

22. The Message I Sent

Dawn Fowler's desk was on the second floor by the window, and it had on it: two screens, a keyboard with a wrist rest, a mug that said WORLD'S OKAYEST MUM, a photograph of two children on a beach in weather that was clearly not warm, and a plant that had been there since 2021 and was, by any reasonable measure, thriving.

Kate came down at 9:15 on the Wednesday morning.

She had rehearsed it in the car. She had rehearsed it for two days, and every version she built had the same architecture, because it was the only architecture she owned. An opening that established the context. A middle that acknowledged the impact. A close that proposed a way forward.

At one point on the Tuesday evening she had opened a document.

"Dawn," she said. "Have you got twenty minutes? Not — it's not a work thing. I need to say something and it needs a room."

Dawn looked up.

"Oh God," she said. "Am I being made redundant?"

"No. No. Christ, no. Opposite. Sort of."

They went into the Aquarium, the room on the second floor with the whale on the wall. Kate shut the door. Dawn sat down with a notebook, which she always brought. Kate looked at the notebook and something in her chest turned over.

“You won’t need that.”

“I always need it.”

“Right,” said Kate.

And then she found that every single one of the versions she had built was gone.

• • •

What she did instead was this.

She took her phone out. She opened it. She found the message. She put the phone on the table between them, face up.

She pressed play.

“Kate—”

“Please just let it.”

Dawn — it’s me. It’s eight fifty-two on Sunday. I’m standing outside the board and the deck in the folder is the second of July version.

It is a very strange thing to sit in a room and listen to your own voice at that volume.

Kate had never once heard it. She had recorded four or five voice messages a day for six years and had listened back to perhaps three of them in her life. What she had not understood — what she had not understood, in a way that would never be fully repaired — was what the thing sounded like at the other end.

In her head it had been a fast note dictated in a corridor.

Out loud, in a quiet room, at nine in the morning, it was a woman speaking very slowly and extremely clearly, without a single stumble, for ninety-one seconds, into a phone, to somebody who could not answer.

I need you to understand what that means, so I'm going to say it once.

Dawn was looking at the table.

A job is a list of things and you do them and you go home at five with your tupperware and your shoebox.

There was a small movement in Dawn's jaw.

I have been carrying yours for two years and pretending it was mine.

Kate made herself watch the whole of it. That was the only decision she made in the room and it was the only one that mattered. She did not look away. She did not look at the phone. She looked at Dawn Fowler's face for the last forty seconds of a recording that she had made herself.

Do not ring me back.

It stopped.

The room did the thing rooms do.

"Right," said Kate. Her voice had gone. "I'm not going to explain any of it. I know I'm going to want to, in about nine seconds, so I'm telling you now that I'm not going to, because everything I could say is a way of making you carry it with me.

"There was no mistake. You did exactly what you said you'd do, and you told me in writing at eighteen minutes to twelve on the Wednesday night that you couldn't get into my drive, and I read it and typed *Perfect*, and then on Sunday morning I decided, in about two seconds, that it was you. And it took me until eleven o'clock that morning to find out that it was me. And by then you'd played it. At fourteen minutes past nine on a Sunday morning with a sick child in the house.

"I'm sorry. Not for the pressure I was under, or the fortnight I'd had, or any of it. For what I did to you. I'm sorry."

She stopped, because there was nothing after it.

• • •

Dawn Fowler said: "Oh, Kate."

That was all. She said it as you say it when somebody has dropped something.

"I mean — it was horrible," she said. "I'm not going to pretend. I cried in the airing cupboard, because Marcus was on the sofa and I didn't want him to see. And then Steve rang and I told him and he said something rude about you, and I got quite defensive, which he thought was hilarious." She shrugged. "And then Monday I came in and did the Ocean file."

"That's—"

"You've been like a wire since March," said Dawn. "I've watched you not eat for four months. Honestly, I thought something was going to happen. I just thought it'd be your heart."

"That's not a reason."

"No," Dawn agreed, comfortably. "It's not a reason. It's just why I'm not surprised." She picked up the mug. It was empty. "It's fine. It's genuinely fine. Are we all right?"

And Kate Merrick, who two hours ago had been unable to eat, said, "Yes."

"Good. Do you want a coffee?"

"Dawn—"

"Because I'm having one, and if I go now I'll get the machine before the second floor does that thing at half nine."

And she got up, and went.

It had taken four minutes.

• • •

That was what took her apart.

Kate sat in the Aquarium for ten minutes after Dawn had gone.

She had prepared for a difficult conversation. She was excellent at difficult conversations. She had done four hundred of them. There is a *shape* to a difficult conversation and Kate could take one from anywhere to anywhere in twenty minutes. She had come down the stairs armoured for cold politeness, or for tears, or for a resignation, or for a long negotiation in which she would have had, at some point, to do something skilful.

What she had got was a woman saying *oh, Kate*, and being sorry for her, and going to get a coffee.

There was no work available in it. Nothing to earn, or level, or close out, or put on a list. It had been handed over free, by a woman with a plant on her desk, and gone to get a coffee.

A board of seven had said *exceptional* eight days earlier and she had felt nothing at all.

She sat there with her hand over her mouth.

• • •

The crisis broke on the Thursday at 3:40, which was the first properly load-bearing thing to happen since the board.

A certificate expired in a piece of software two suppliers down from Bellwether, which nobody at Bellwether had heard of, and every card payment on the mobile app stopped working. At a quarter to four. On a Thursday. In July.

Kate was on the second floor when Tom Ferreira found her.

“We’ve got—”

“I know,” said Kate. “I’ve got the alert.”

“So the fix is—”

“Tom.” She put her phone in her pocket. That was the whole action, physically: she put a phone into a jacket pocket.

“It’s yours.”

He looked at her.

“It’s yours,” she said again. “I’m not going to be in it.”

“Kate, it’s the *app*—”

“I know what it is.”

“Do you want me to—”

“No.”

And she walked away, which was the single hardest professional act of her career, and which took her past the window where she could see him standing there.

It took two hours and twenty minutes and it was not clean.

Tom wobbled at 4:20. There is a recording of a call where he says “I’ll need to check with—” and then stops, audibly, and there are two seconds of dead air on the line, and then he says, “No. Do it.”

He got the sequence wrong at 5:05 and had to back one thing out. He made a call about customer comms at 5:30 that Kate — watching the channel from a room upstairs with her hands in her lap — would not have made, and which was, she looked at it for a long time, defensible.

Possibly better.

At 5:51 the app was back.

At 5:58 Tom put a message in the channel: *Back up. Root cause was a cert at Marrowbone’s security vendor, their*

agent failed closed, we've got an alert on it now which we should have had since 2022. My call on the comms, I'll write it up. Sorry for the two hours.

Kate read it four times.

He had wobbled, and held, and got there. It had cost the business about twenty thousand pounds more than it would have cost if she had done it herself.

She thought about the twenty thousand pounds for a while.

Then she thought about what it had cost her, every time, for four years, to save it.

• • •

She rang her parents on the Sunday.

It was a fortnightly call and it had a structure both parties had honoured since about 2011. Her mother asked how work was. Kate gave a version — a good version, funny, self-deprecating, containing at least one achievement placed where it would not look placed. Her mother said something warm. Then her mother said the next thing.

“So how’s it all going?” said Elizabeth Merrick.

And Kate said: “It’s fine. It’s busy. How’s the garden?”

There was a small pause.

“The garden’s a disaster, the box has got something. But how’s — what happened with the board thing? Wasn’t there a board thing?”

“There was. It went fine.” Kate was standing at her window. “Tell me about the box.”

Her mother told her about the box.

It took ten minutes and involved a man called Gordon who had a theory. Kate asked three questions about it. She did not report a single thing and did not ask for a single thing. At the end her mother said, “Well — you sound busy, darling,” slightly puzzled, because the shape of the call had been wrong.

“I am,” said Kate. “Love to Dad.”

She put the phone down and sat on the sofa.

After thirty-two years, on a Sunday afternoon, for eleven minutes, she had stopped servicing the debt.

Nobody had been told. Nobody had noticed. The debt was still there and would be there at Christmas.

• • •

The dance class was on Wednesdays at 6:30 in a hall behind a leisure centre in Bermondsey, and was called *Adult Beginners / Improvers — Contemporary*, which Kate had read four times looking for a way out.

She booked it on the Monday. She nearly cancelled it on the Tuesday. On the Wednesday at 5:50 she left the office in front of forty people, which had not happened in nine years, and Dawn watched her go and said nothing.

At 6:14, running down Tooley Street with a bag, she got the call.

“Kate, sorry — it’s Tom. The Marrowbone people are saying Lauriston’s rejected the settlement file—”

She stopped on the pavement.

There was a version of her, four weeks old, that was already turning round.

“Tom,” she said. “My working day is over. Figure it out yourself.”

There was silence on the line.

“...OK,” said Tom.

“You’ll be fine.”

“Yeah. No, I — yeah.”

She hung up and stood there on Tooley Street with her heart going. And then she laughed, out loud, on her own, and a man walking past looked at her.

She went to the class and was, for fifty minutes, the worst person in the room by a distance so comical that the teacher, a woman of about sixty called Ines, twice used the phrase “and Kate is *exploring*.”

She could not do the turn. She could not do the thing with the arms at all. At one point, going the wrong way across the floor, she collided with a retired postman.

She came out at 7:35 with her hair wrecked and a graze on one elbow and her whole body ringing. She stood in the car park behind the leisure centre in the July evening and thought: *nobody in that room knows what I do*.

• • •

She mentioned it on the Friday, in passing, to Dawn, because she had to tell somebody and there was nobody else.

“I’ve started a dance class.”

Dawn looked up from her screen.

“Have you,” she said.

“It’s — I’m horrifically bad. Wednesdays.”

Dawn took her glasses off.

“Kate,” she said. “I’ve danced on Wednesdays for eight years.”

There was a pause of about four seconds.

“You *what*?”

“Wednesdays. Half seven, at the church hall on Milkwood Road. It’s ballroom and Latin and it’s mostly people over fifty, and there’s a man called Colin who’s genuinely nationally ranked and does not let you forget it.” Dawn was smiling in a way Kate had never seen. “Eight years. It’s why I go at five on a Wednesday.”

Kate stood there.

“You’ve gone at five on a Wednesday for eight years,” she said, “and I have never once asked you why.”

“No,” said Dawn cheerfully. “You haven’t.”

And then she said: “Do you want to come?”

23. The Real Number

He got in on the Tuesday evening, and Meera was standing in the kitchen with her arms folded, which she never did.

“Anaya’s at Nell’s,” she said. “Rohan’s asleep. So.”

“Right.”

“Nik, what’s going on?”

And Nikhil Raghavan put the maroon suitcase down in the hall, and came into the kitchen, and did not sit down, and said:

“Can I have twenty minutes where you don’t say anything? Not because I don’t want you to. Because if you say something in the middle I’ll adjust it, and I’ve been adjusting it for fourteen years, and I want to say it once.”

Meera looked at him.

She uncrossed her arms and sat down at the kitchen table.

“Twenty minutes,” she said.

• • •

It took thirty-four.

He did it the way he would have done a board pack, which was the only way he knew, and which turned out to be the right way, because the format was the one thing in the room that was not frightening.

He started with the household, and he gave her the figures, because the figures were the only part of this he had never once got wrong.

Six thousand nine hundred and forty a month after tax and pension. Rent twenty-one fifty. Anaya eleven-forty from August, which was eleven-forty and not ten-eighty because there had been a letter in May. Chennai nine hundred in a normal month, and there had not been a normal month since February. The car and the insurance and the nursery days, and a food shop that was two hundred and thirty a week and had been a hundred and sixty when Rohan was born.

“Four hundred pounds,” he said. “That’s what’s meant to be left. That’s the whole of the space between us and something going wrong.”

Then he told her it had not been four hundred since March. Since March it had been minus a hundred and ten a month, and the difference had been going onto the card in increments of two and three hundred pounds, every one of which he could have named, none of which had been extravagant.

He said the card balance out loud.

He had never said it out loud. It came out of his mouth and stood in the kitchen and was, in the event, a number. Which is all it had ever been.

He said he had sent seventeen hundred pounds to Chennai on the Wednesday out of the joint account instead of the other one, and that this was why the school payment bounced, and that the bounce had cost twenty-five pounds and would cost another twenty-five if it was not cleared by Thursday. That his father needed a further one lakh sixty for the physiotherapy, which was fifteen hundred and twenty pounds plus the fee plus the spread they took and did not print. That this was not

a one-off, and that he had built a row in the spreadsheet called *Chennai* — *one-off* which had two entries in it, and that when he had looked at the two entries in a hotel room on Sunday he had known exactly what that row was going to be next year.

He said there was no cushion. If the boiler goes, we borrow.

He said the boiler was eleven years old and the man had quoted three and a half thousand in 2023, which meant it was four and a half now.

Then he did the studio.

He said Lodestone was not in danger this month or next, and that this was true, and he wanted it on the record before the rest. Then he said the runway was fourteen months on paper and six if Sunward slipped past the thirtieth of November. That Sunward had missed three dates out of three. That he had known since March. That eleven days ago a non-executive director had asked him a direct question about it and he had said he was relaxed.

“I wasn’t relaxed,” he said. “I’ve been awake at four in the morning since March.”

Meera did not say anything, which he had asked for and had not expected to get.

“And then the last part,” said Nik.

He put his hands on the back of the chair.

“I’ve been lying to you. Not about — there’s nothing else, there’s no other person, there’s nothing like that. I’ve been lying about the size of things. For fourteen years. I’ve been making everything about four per cent better than it is, every single time, so you wouldn’t worry.”

He looked at the table.

“And I told myself that was what I was for. And what it’s done is, you stopped asking me the second question. Years ago. I noticed on Sunday and I’ve thought about nothing else since.”

He made himself say it.

“I’ve been lying to keep you from worrying, and all it did was keep you away from me.”

• • •

Meera Raghavan said: “I know.”

“I—”

“You said twenty minutes. It’s been thirty-four. It’s my turn.”

She turned her chair round.

“I know about the polishing,” she said. “I’ve known since Coventry. You told me you were a manager and you weren’t, and I knew that night. And then eight months later you told me in the car, and you were so upset about it, and I thought, oh — he doesn’t know that I know.”

“Then why did you—”

“Because I thought it was a small thing.” She was very calm. “I thought it was a nervous thing. Like something you’d grow out of when you felt safe. And then you got the CFO job and I thought, right. Now he’ll feel safe.”

She pushed her hair back.

“And you didn’t. You got worse.”

Nik sat down.

“The money I didn’t know,” said Meera. “Not the amounts. I knew there wasn’t as much as you said there was, because I

do the food shop and I've got eyes. I didn't know about the card." She looked at him. "And I want to say — Nik, honestly, I'm not upset about the card. I'm upset about *four in the morning since March*. You've been doing that in this house. Next to me. For five months."

"I didn't want you to—"

"I know what you didn't want." She said it hard, and then softer: "That's what I'm saying. You've been protecting me from a thing that was never going to hurt me as much as being protected."

There was a long silence in the kitchen.

"I married *you*," said Meera. "I didn't marry the report."

• • •

He wrote the memo on the Wednesday and sent it on the Thursday morning before anybody else was in.

Two pages, and it said in the first line, without any preamble at all: *I have been presenting our position more confidently than the evidence supports. This memo corrects that.*

Then it set out the clawback, and the probability he actually assigned to the November date, which was forty per cent, with his working. The eleven open roles making the runway look longer than it was. The Dublin facility at forty basis points worse. It ended with three options and a recommendation, which was to go to the publisher in August, before the slip, and renegotiate from a position of eleven months of cash rather than four.

He copied the chair and Bridget.

Then he sat at his desk in Guildford and had, for about two hours, the worst morning of his professional life, in which his mind produced in sequence every version of the catastrophe he had been storyboarding since 2021. The phone call. The emergency board meeting. Gus's face. The phrase *loss of confidence*. Being walked to the car park. The conversation with Meera. Chennai at forty-two, in disgrace.

Gus rang at 9:52.

"Nik."

"Gus."

"Right, so I've read it twice." A pause. "First thing. Is there more?"

"No. That's all of it."

"You're sure. Because I can deal with anything except more."

"That's all of it."

"OK." Gus let out a breath. "OK. Then I'm going to say something and I want you to hear it properly, because I know what you'll do with it otherwise. That's the most useful thing anyone's sent me in three years, and I'm furious, and both of those are true."

"I know."

"Not furious that it's bad. Furious that in March you had a forty per cent and I had a *fine*." Something rustled. "Because in March I could have gone to the publisher and said *let's talk about November* and it would have looked like housekeeping. Now it looks like a warning. That's four months, Nik. That's the whole cost of it, and it's not fatal, it's just expensive."

"I know."

"Right." A chair moved. "Bridget's already replied to me, by the way. Do you want to know what she said?"

“Not really.”

“She said: *Good. Now we can work.*”

• • •

There was no catastrophe.

There was a bill, and it arrived in instalments.

The first came the following week, when the plan that fell out of the honest memo required taking eleven open roles off the board permanently. The roles Nik had been quietly holding to make the runway look longer. Gus made him do it himself. “It’s your number,” he said, not unkindly. “You go and be the face of it.”

So Nik spent a Thursday telling four heads of department that the eleven people they had been promised since March were not coming, and watched a producer he liked go grey across about nine seconds, and heard himself say *I should have told you in the spring* four times, and meant it all four times, and it helped nobody at all.

His honesty, converted into consequence, landed on people who had done nothing.

The second was smaller and lasted longer. Hollis asked for a monthly cash pack instead of a quarterly one, which is about a day and a half of Priyesh every month, call it eleven thousand a year of a man’s time to tell people something they already had. Nobody framed it as a punishment and everybody understood it as one, and it stayed in place for a year.

They went to the publisher on the eleventh of August. Three meetings, and a considerable amount of unpleasantness in the second one, and they came out with the milestone

moved to the thirty-first of January in exchange for a revenue share point and a hard cap on scope. A point is about four hundred thousand pounds over the life of the title if the title does what they think it will do, and Nik had that figure in the room, and signed anyway, because the alternative was the thirtieth of November with four months of cash and no story. A worse deal than the one they had. A very much better deal than the one they would have had in December.

Gus made him present it to the board himself. It was not a triumph. Hollis's man on the Lodestone board, Aaron, spent twenty minutes on why the studio had not seen this in the spring, and Nik said, "Because I didn't tell you," four times, in four different ways. Each time it got slightly easier and remained entirely horrible.

He kept his job. His standing in the room was lower than it had been in June, he thought, and considerably more real.

• • •

The thing that actually cost him came on the Saturday, three days after the memo, and it came from nowhere.

Anaya was doing homework at the kitchen table and Nik was making tea, and she said, without looking up:

"Appa, are we poor?"

He nearly said *no*. He had it loaded.

"No," he said. And then made himself do the second half. "We're not poor. We're tight. There's a difference and I'll explain it if you want."

"Sofia said your suitcase means you're poor."

"Sofia is nine and has been to Dubai."

Anaya snorted.

Then she said, “Amma said you’ve been worried about money for ages and you didn’t tell us.”

“That’s true.”

“Why didn’t you tell us?”

And Nik stood by the kettle and found that he did not have an answer a nine-year-old would accept, which is the strictest test there is.

“Because I thought that was my job,” he said. “I thought if I gave you everything you needed and never let you see any of the worry, that was the whole thing. That was me doing it right.”

Anaya thought about this.

“That’s a bit weird,” she said, and went back to her homework.

• • •

He cooked on the Sunday.

He had not cooked since about 2019. He made his mother’s sambar off a phone call, ringing Chennai and making her go through it a step at a time, and she was so pleased to be asked that she talked for forty minutes at whatever the tariff is now and made him promise to use less water. At the end she said, “Why are you cooking?” and he said, “Because I want to,” and she said “*Ayyo*,” and told his father, who said nothing.

It took three hours and cost about eleven pounds in ingredients, of which he wasted perhaps four on a first attempt at the tamarind, and it was too sour.

They ate it at the kitchen table, all four of them, at half past six on a Sunday. Anaya said it was “actually really nice” in the tone of a girl who has decided to be supportive, which is the most damning verdict available. Meera had two bowls and said nothing about the water.

And Rohan, who was three, and who had eaten four spoonfuls and rearranged the rest, put his spoon down and said:

“Appa. Stay.”

“I’m here, kanna.”

“No,” said Rohan, with the enormous patience of a three-year-old explaining something obvious, and pointed at the chair. “Stay *there*.”

Nik looked at the chair.

Forty times a week for fourteen years, which he had, out of habit, already totalled at somewhere over twenty-nine thousand, and which was the first sum he had ever done that did not resolve into money.

How was work.

Not one of them had been a request for money. He had answered every single one as though it were, and had gone and got some, and had come back pleased with himself.

“OK,” he said.

Rohan, satisfied, returned to the destruction of the sambar.

And Nik sat there and did not trust himself to say anything else for about a minute. And Meera, on the other side of the table, saw it, and did not say a word, and put her hand flat on the wood between them, palm down, and left it there.

24. Say It Once, Slowly

The fridge in the flat in Bow had a compressor that cut in every eleven minutes and ran for four.

Two states. He could tell which one from the hall.

Alex did not go to the Tuesday meeting, because by the time he got back to London it had already happened. He read the notes on the Wednesday, sitting on the floor with his back against the sofa. Ben had written them up warmly, the way he wrote everything. *Great first session with Lauriston. They're keen. Compliance-first lands well — programme director wants a proposal for the evidencing module by end of month. Recon is "phase 2" in their heads which is exactly where we want it. Big one, team.*

He read it twice, and closed it, and sat on the floor with the laptop shut on his knees while the compressor ran its four minutes and stopped.

Then he did a thing he had not done in three years, which was to open the calendar and book a meeting room for an hour at four on the Thursday and put exactly one other name on it, and no agenda, because an agenda would have let it be answered before it was said.

• • •

The room called Riga had a projector that stayed powered even when nothing was plugged into it, and its fan ran at a pitch about a tone and a half above the building's air handling, and the two of them beat against each other slowly, and you could hear the beat if you stopped talking for long enough. Nobody ever stopped talking for long enough.

They sat with no laptops.

That made both of them aware of their hands, and left the room with nothing in it to look at except the other person and a whiteboard wiped so many times it had gone the colour of weak tea.

He had thought about how to start for a day.

He had discarded every version that began with the grievance. He had worked that out from two people — from watching Kate take three people apart in a hotel bar, and from his father waiting four days in an airport without asking him anything.

The grievance was what made him easy to manage. It invited *mate, I hear you, and here's the context*. The context was always true. Being managed by true context was the whole of his life.

So he did not start with the grievance.

"I built the recon fix," he said. "The Lauriston thing. The thing the introduction was actually about. I built a working demo in thirty hours over that weekend, it takes eleven thousand items a night down to fourteen, it's in a branch called causal-order, and I didn't tell you, because I don't tell anyone anything until it's finished."

Ben's eyebrows went up. "Alex. That's—"

"Let me do the whole thing. Then you talk."

Ben closed his mouth.

And, Alex watched him do it, actually sat back.

There was a clock in the room. Alex had never noticed the clock.

• • •

“You went into that bank on Tuesday and sold a report,” he said. “Which was the right commercial call. I want to say that first, because it’s true, and because I’ve spent two years letting you make right commercial calls and then hating you for it in private, and I’m not doing that any more.”

“But,” said Ben.

“But.”

And then it came, and it came the way they came, sideways and complete and about ninety seconds after he had stopped hunting for it, except that this time the thing assembling itself was not a lock-free queue.

Because the problem was not the meeting. The meeting was an output. The problem was that there was a machine in this company that nobody had designed, and it had been running for two years, and it worked like this: a decision comes up, and the decision needs a technical view, and the technical view lives in one head, and getting it out of that head takes between forty seconds and four minutes of a room being quiet, and a room of eight people costs about two pounds a second to keep quiet, and nobody has ever put it that way but everybody has felt it, so the room does the economically rational thing, which is to route around the cost — Ben supplies a version of the technical view, which is eighty per cent right and arrives in nine seconds, and the meeting proceeds, and the decision is a

good decision, and nothing anywhere in the system records that the twenty per cent was lost, because the twenty per cent was never said, and a thing that is never said leaves no trace at all. And then it happens again. And each time it happens the room gets slightly better at predicting what Alex would have said, and slightly worse at being right about it, and Alex gets slightly better at not saying it, because a man who has been correctly predicted eleven times stops volunteering the twelfth, and the two curves cross somewhere in the second year, and after they cross the company is running on a model of its own CTO instead of its CTO, and the model does not have the four thousand lines of C in it, and cannot be asked what happens under memory pressure, and will answer anyway.

“And you all did it to be kind,” he said. “That’s the part I can’t get round. Every single person here made a small generous decision to spare me the room. And I let them, because being in the room is the thing I’m most frightened of. And between us we’ve built a company where the one person who can see the whole system spends his life finding out what was decided without him, and then being sad about it at one in the morning.”

He stopped.

The fan in the projector went on doing what it did, and the air handling went on underneath it, and the two of them beat against each other in the way they had been beating all morning and would go on beating after everybody had gone home.

“That’s it,” he said. “That’s the whole thing. You can talk now.”

• • •

Ben did not talk for a moment, which for Ben was extraordinary.

“OK,” he said. “Can I ask you something, and it’s a real question, I’m not managing you.”

“Go on.”

“Why didn’t you tell me about the demo?”

“Because you’d have taken it into the room,” said Alex. “And it would have been great. And it would have been yours. And then I’d have been the engine again.”

Ben flinched. A real one, and a small one, and the first Alex had seen in four years of watching him absorb things.

“Is that what you think you are?”

“It’s what I *am*.” Alex leaned forward. “Here’s the thing I actually came to say. You need my engine. Velum is four thousand lines of C that I wrote in eleven days and cannot fully reproduce, and if I get hit by a bus the company is a deck.

“And I need your voice. I’ve watched you make a room believe in something forty times and I can’t do it once. That’s real. That’s a real thing we have and it works.

“But you have to stop talking over me. Not because it’s rude. You don’t even know you’re doing it. Because every time you do it the company loses the only person who can see the thing you’re selling.”

He sat back.

“I’m done mumbling. I’ll say the thing once, slowly, and you have to actually stop and look at it. Not draw a box around it and move on.”

Ben was quiet for what was, by the clock Alex had not noticed until forty minutes ago and could now not stop noticing, the better part of fifteen seconds.

“Once, slowly,” he said.

“Once, slowly. My dad told me that.” Alex turned his hand over on the table, and did not know he was doing it. “I’ll say it once, clearly, and then I’ll shut up. And it’s your job — your actual job, as the one with the voice — to make sure the room looks at it before you decide.

“If you do that, I’ll come to every meeting you want. If you don’t, I’m going to keep building things in branches, and you’re going to keep finding out what I think from a demo six months later, and eventually one of those branches is going to have my resignation in it.”

• • •

It was not a clean victory.

He had prepared for the version where Ben said *you’re absolutely right, I’ve been terrible*. He had rehearsed a gracious response to it on the Northern line.

That version did not arrive. It was not true, and Ben did not deal in things that were not true, which was the quality that made him worth having and the quality that made him impossible.

What Ben said was:

“I think you’re about seventy per cent right, and thirty per cent you’re using this as a way to be angry about a meeting. And I think the seventy is the most important thing anybody has said to me since we started.”

He was turning a pen over. He noticed himself doing it and put it down.

“And I don’t fully know how to not do the thing I do. I’ll get it wrong. You’ll have to tell me when I do it. In the moment.

Out loud. In front of Saul.”

“Which I’ll hate.”

“Which you’ll hate.”

“I’ll do it once,” said Alex. “Slowly.”

Ben laughed, once, and then stopped.

“Right. So what do you actually want? Not the principle. The thing.”

Alex had it ready, because he had written it on the back of a receipt on the Northern line that morning, and had then transcribed it, because the receipt was already going furry.

“Two engineers on causal-order, starting Monday. And I present it at Lauriston round two. Me. Not you doing it with my slides.”

“No to the first.”

“Ben—”

“Let me do the whole thing.” Ben held up a hand — and then, catching himself, put it down again, deliberately, on the table. “Sorry. Go on.”

“No,” said Alex. “Say it.”

“Two engineers starting Monday means the compliance module ships in November instead of September. And the November date is in a contract with Meridian that I signed. So it’s not a priorities question. It’s a breach question.”

Alex sat with that. He turned it over and found no way through it that was not simply a wish.

It was, annoyingly, the answer he would have given from the other side of the table.

“January,” said Ben. “Two engineers, January, in the plan, written down. And I’ll say it at the all-hands, so it costs me something to renege.”

Four months. Four months in which the thing he had built in thirty hours would sit in a branch, doing nothing, being right.

“And round two?”

“Round two is yours.” Ben said it immediately. And then, after a beat: “And I want something.”

“Go on.”

“The Arcus diligence. Six weeks. Forty calls with people who will ask you the same eleven questions, and you will want to die, and I want you in every single one of them.”

“Fenella can—”

“I know Fenella can. I’m not asking for the technical answers.” Ben looked at him. “If you’re not in those rooms, the story about who Velum is gets told without you again. And then we’re back here in a year having this exact conversation, and you’ll be right again, and it’ll be my fault again.”

That was the actual price, and Ben had found it almost at once, the way he found everything, in the time it took most people to decide whether they were going to be difficult about it.

Forty calls. The thing he was worst at in the world. The thing that made the words go.

And the only currency this was purchasable in.

“Fine,” he said.

“Yeah?”

“Two engineers in January, written down, said out loud. Round two is mine. And I’ll do the forty calls.” He put both hands on the table. “And the first time you answer one of those questions for me before I’ve finished, I’m going to stop talking and let the silence sit there until everyone on that call notices.”

Ben laughed — and then stopped laughing, because Alex was not laughing.

He put out his hand across the table.

They shook on it, which is a slightly absurd thing to do with a man you have known for four years, and they both did it anyway, and neither of them said anything about it then or afterwards.

The projector fan cut out. Neither of them noticed, having stopped hearing it about ninety minutes earlier.

Fenella was outside the door when they opened it, with a laptop open on one forearm.

“The control-plane certificate expired at twenty to four,” she said. “Every agent in Europe failed closed. Two hours. It’s back, I’ve done it by hand, and I’d like to know whose calendar that was in.”

Neither of them answered.

It had been in Alex’s. In 2023, on a laptop he had stopped using, in a calendar that had gone on knowing about it after everybody had stopped asking.

• • •

The pilot with Lauriston came the following spring. A small paid engagement to prove the recon approach on real data, on a subset, with a bank’s caution about it. It found four things that broke the model, exactly as he had said it would on a hotel floor in July, and three of them were the sort of thing you fix in an afternoon once you can see them. The fourth was a genuine limitation in the approach, and he wrote it up honestly and at length and without hedging.

Michael's programme director, a man Alex never met, wrote back one line: *this is the first time anyone's told us what it can't do.*

He printed it out on the office printer, which nobody had used since March and which took eleven seconds to wake up and then made the whole sequence of noises it had been making since 2019, the drum spinning up and the fuser coming to temperature and the sheet going through with a sound like a held breath, and he stood beside it for all of that with his hands in his pockets, and then folded the page twice and put it in the inside pocket of the jacket, next to the notebook, and did not mention it to anybody at all.

• • •

He rang his father on the Sunday.

On the floor, back against the sofa. Where he made difficult calls.

The fridge cut in at the fourth ring.

He had been putting it off for eleven days, and what he had been putting off was *it*, the one call and not the general run of them, because on the phone from the office in July he had said *it's great, it's going really well*, and there was a taking-back to do and no established procedure for doing it.

"Alek."

"Papa. Have you got a minute?"

"I have every minute. I am retired. Your mother is at the shop."

"Right." He closed his eyes. "I want to tell you something and it's not bad, so don't — Mama's not here, so you don't

have to do the face. It's not bad."

"OK."

"When you were here. And you asked how the company was, and I said great. It wasn't great. It's been really hard for about a year. There's this thing with Ben where I couldn't say what I thought, and I've been eating myself alive about it. And I said *it's fine, Papa* to you about nine times and it wasn't fine. And I'm taking it back. The *it's fine*. I shouldn't have said it to you."

There was a silence on the line, and it was not a wounded silence, and Alex, who had spent his life reading silences on this particular line, could hear that.

"Aleksander," said Marek. "I knew."

"...What?"

"I knew at the hotel. Saturday, by the fire that is not a fire, I knew. You checked your telephone fifty-one times."

"You counted?"

"I counted," said his father. "On Monday at the museum also. Fifty-one on the Saturday, more on the Monday. And you came out of the hotel on Sunday with a face, and I thought, something is wrong with the company. Or the — I thought maybe a girl. But no." A small sound that might have been a laugh. "So. I knew."

"Then why didn't you—"

"Because you were not ready," said Marek simply. "A man tells you when he can. If I ask you when you cannot, you say *it's fine, Papa*, and then you have said it, and then it is between us, the *it's fine*, and it is harder afterwards. So I wait. I am good at waiting. I waited six years for Tony to find out I could fix the machine."

Alex sat on the floor with the phone against his ear and the fridge running and a view of the underside of the sofa.

He did the arithmetic on six years of Tony and a broken machine in Leyton.

“That must have been—” He stopped. “That’s a horrible thing to be good at.”

“Yes,” said his father. “It is the worst thing I am good at. But it works.” And then, after a moment: “You said it now. So. You were ready. Good.”

• • •

They talked for another twenty minutes, about the company, properly, and Marek understood about a third of it and asked about the other two-thirds. And at the end he said the thing Alex would keep.

“Aleksander. The bakery, and the print. Ten years.” A pause. “You know I did not do it for a reason.”

“You did it for us.”

“No. That is what your mother says, and it is nice, and it is not exactly true. I did it because it was in front of me and there was nobody else to do it. And I did not think about it. Thinking is a luxury. I did the next thing, for ten years.”

Another pause.

“But you — you think it is a debt. I have seen it. You think, Papa did the bakery, so I must—”

He hunted, and this time he found it.

“You carry it like a loan you did not ask for.”

“I do,” said Alex quietly. “Yeah. I do.”

“So. Stop.” His father’s voice was very clear, four words at a time. “It is not a debt. You cannot pay me back. There is nobody to pay. It is a thing that is given.” A pause while he went looking again. “An inheritance. You don’t pay back an inheritance.”

“Then what do you do with it.”

“You spend it,” said Marek. “Not suffer the same. If you suffer the same, I bought nothing.”

Alex sat on the floor of a flat in Bow with the phone against his ear and did not say anything for a while.

And his father, who was good at waiting, waited.

The compressor cut in and ran its four minutes and cut out, and neither of them said anything in that time either, and the line stayed open the whole way through it.

25. The Recital

The advisory arrangement with Bellwether went through in the middle of August, on a single sheet of paper that Michael read twice and signed once, and which committed him to four board meetings a year and “such counsel as may reasonably be sought by telephone,” for a fee that he thought was too high and that Kate refused to lower.

And on the twenty-first of August, Michael Halloway told Lauriston he would retire at the end of March.

He told Fiona first, in her office, with the door shut; and she did not perform surprise, which he had been braced for and would have found unbearable, and for which he was accordingly more grateful than he could reasonably have explained.

“Is this because of the transformation-office thing? Because I can tell you that Callum’s not—”

“No. It’s genuinely not. It’s that I’m sixty-four, and I’ve been doing this since Thatcher, and I taught four hundred people about the 1994 ledger in July, and a woman in row four asked me a question, and it was the best afternoon I’d had in a decade. And I’d like more afternoons and fewer mornings.”

Which was true, and was not the whole of it; and Fiona — who had heard about a search from somebody, because people always have — let him have the version he offered, because she was decent, and because it was, as far as it went, real.

He did not mention Terry's telephone call. He never mentioned it to anybody.

In October a mid-size building society announced a new group operations director: an external hire, early fifties, big transformation background. Michael read the announcement on his phone on the 6:40 and felt the thing settle into place with a click, like a bone going back; and put the phone in the door pocket, and looked out of the window; and it was, he checked, all right.

It had been going to be somebody. It had turned out to be somebody at a building society and not at Lauriston; and by then it did not matter, because by then he had already jumped, and a man who has already jumped cannot be pushed.

. . .

His calendar, in September, began to acquire white space.

It terrified him for exactly one week, which was, he thought afterwards, about six days longer than a sensible man would have needed, and about fifty years less than he had feared.

There was a Wednesday afternoon, the second week, with nothing in it. Actually nothing: a blank rectangle from two o'clock. He sat in his office and looked at it and felt the old animal panic, the one from Bushey, the one that said *a man with an empty afternoon is a man without a wage*.

He very nearly filled it. He got as far as opening the diary of a colleague to offer to sit in on something.

Then he closed it, and went home at two o'clock on a Wednesday for the first time since 1987; and Ruth was not ex-

pecting him, and there was a moment at the door where she thought something was wrong, and then there wasn't, and they went for a walk.

It was on one of those afternoons that he rang the boy.

He had been carrying the last night at the hotel around for weeks — *he's a mascot*, and the rest of it, all accurate — and he got the voicemail, and was slightly relieved, because he had not fully worked out what he meant to say.

"Alex. It's Michael. From the — from the hotel. The mascot." A pause, and something that was almost the joke, and then not. "Listen. You were right about most of it, and I've thought about it a great deal, and I wanted to say so, and I wanted to say that the introduction — I should have sent it to you. Just you. You were right about that, and I knew the reason while I was doing it, and you named it, and it's cost me some sleep, which at my age is a genuine sacrifice." A breath. "Anyway. I hear the recon thing worked. Of course it did. Ring me back if you want to. And if you don't, that's — I'd understand that too. Right. That's the message. I'd say don't let it go to your head, but I've met your head, so — too late. Goodbye."

Alex was, that week, in the middle of a release and a fight with Saul about resourcing. He listened to it on a Thursday, standing up, half-hearing it, and thought *I'll ring him back at the weekend*, and meant it; and was still angry enough that the weekend was a convenient distance away.

• • •

The recital was on a Saturday in late September, at St Barnabas Hall, and Michael went unannounced.

He had thought about it carefully, which was itself the tell. The old Michael would have rung Claire and said *is it all right if I come*, and would have offered to sit at the back, and would have made a joke about Rufus; and would thereby have converted his own attendance into a small favour that the family granted him, so that if anything went wrong he would have been the man who was kind enough to offer, rather than the man who failed to come.

He did not do that. He drove to Watford, to a church hall four miles from the maisonette in Bushey where a man had once put a sticker on a television; and he arrived at 6:10 for a 6:30 start; and he stood at the back, because the four seats were, as promised, taken.

Claire saw him from across the hall and her face did something complicated, and she came over.

“Dad, you didn’t say—”

“No. I didn’t. I wanted to just be here, rather than be a whole thing about being here.”

Claire looked at him for a second.

“Right. OK,” she said. And then, “There’s a chair by the radiator. It’s the worst seat in the room.”

“It’s a magnificent seat,” said Michael, and went and sat on it.

Iris played third. She was nine, and she played a piece by somebody Michael had never heard of, and she got the fingering wrong in one place and did the thing good children do, which is not to stop: to keep the left hand going and let the right hand find its way back.

And Michael, on a plastic chair by a radiator in a church hall in Watford, discovered that he was not able to see very well.

A boy called Rufus did indeed play “Für Elise” at a speed that suggested a wager.

• • •

Afterwards there was squash and biscuits, and Iris came and found him, in the way children do when they know they have done a thing.

“You went wrong in the middle bit,” said Michael.

“I *know*.”

“And then you did the cleverest thing I’ve seen all year, which is that you kept the other hand going and you didn’t apologise. You just fixed it while nobody was looking. And that, Iris, is the entire secret of every job I have ever had, and you did it at nine, and I’m extremely proud of you.”

Iris considered this with the whole of her attention, in the manner of a person receiving evidence rather than a compliment; and it occurred to Michael, watching her do it, that she had got that from her mother, and that her mother had got it from Ruth.

“Grandad, are you crying?”

“Yes,” said Michael. “It’s the squash. It’s very strong squash.”

A little way off, Claire put her own hand over her mouth for a second. She had not seen her father cry in her entire life.

• • •

He said it to her on the porch afterwards, when the others had gone in.

“Claire. I got it wrong.”

“Dad—”

“No, let me. I’ve been practising, and if I don’t do it now I’ll do the joke.” He put the cup down on the windowsill. “I bought you and your brother everything. Every single thing. There was never a letter in that house that anybody was frightened of, and I did that on purpose, and I’d do it again. But I bought it with the only thing I actually had to give you, which was the time. I sold you the time to buy you the things. And now the things are here and the time is gone, and I can’t get it back.”

He looked at her.

“I’m not asking you to say it’s fine. I missed it. Most of it. And I’m sorry.”

Claire was quiet.

She did not say *it’s fine, Dad*.

“It wasn’t fine,” she said. “I want to be honest with you because you’re being honest with me. There were — Dad, there were a lot of empty chairs. And Sam doesn’t even — Sam thinks it’s normal that grandparents don’t come to things, because yours mostly didn’t, and I never corrected it, because I didn’t want him to feel it as a loss. So I sort of priced you out. To protect him.” She wiped her eye with the back of her wrist. “That was its own thing and I’m not proud of it either.”

“No,” said Michael. “You were right to.”

“I wasn’t right. I was coping.” She looked at him. “But you’re here. You came to a recital and stood at the back and made my daughter feel like the cleverest person in Watford, and you’re crying about squash. And I don’t — Dad, I don’t know what happened to you at that hotel, but.”

“A great many things happened to me at that hotel,” said Michael, “and I’ll tell you all of them. One of them was a young man with a marker pen. One of them was a woman who gave me a job that’s a telephone. And one of them was that I said some true things to some strangers that I’ll be ashamed of until I die.” He picked the cup back up. “But mostly I just stopped, for two days. And it turned out I could see from there.”

• • •

Danny was on the porch when Michael went to leave, having a moment to himself the way a man does when there are twelve people in his house.

Michael knew the look; he had, in a manner of speaking, invented it, and had worn it on a great many porches of his own over a period of about twenty-five years.

Danny was thirty-eight, and ran the south-east for a logistics firm called Ocean, and was, by every visible sign — the phone, the two-thumbed reply at a child’s recital, the specific grey around the eyes — working exactly the way Michael had worked at thirty-eight.

“Long week?” said Michael.

“Aren’t they all,” said Danny. “I’ve got a client who moves the Thursday call the way other people breathe.” He laughed.

It was a good laugh. It had a floor under it. Michael recognised the floor.

So he sat down on the step, which took him a second, and said, “Can I tell you something, and you can ignore it, because

I'm your wife's father, and this is exactly the sort of thing that is unbearable coming from your wife's father?"

Danny, wary, amused, said, "Go on."

And Michael Halloway took a breath in, and let it out.

And then he told him.

He told him all of it. Not as a warning, and not as a lesson, and not with a moral on the end, because he had learned in July that a man declines to hear the moral. He told him plainly, unedited, without a single joke: the branches; the years; the sticker on the television; the promise a boy made at a table in Bushey; the four hundred closures; the empty chairs; the phone that stopped ringing; the granddaughter he had to be told twice about; the recital he had nearly not come to. He told him that it had been the right decision every single time, and that it added up to a thing he could not undo.

"I was good at it," he said, somewhere in the middle of it. "If I'd been worse at it I'd have been home."

He talked for eleven minutes on a step in the dark, and Danny did not say anything at all.

At the end Michael said:

"I'm not telling you to leave your job. I left mine at sixty-four and made a mess of things I can't fix, so I'm the last man who should be advising anybody." He put his hands on his knees. "Do what you like with it."

Danny sat on the step for a while, turning a cup that had nothing in it, in the way of a man who has been handed something he did not ask for and has not yet decided what it weighs.

"Iris asks about you a lot," he said eventually. "I don't think you know that."

"No," said Michael. "I didn't."

“Yeah.” Danny looked at his hands. “Thanks.”

Michael drove home the long way, through Bushey, which he had not done on purpose in thirty years; and did not stop, and did not slow down much either.

26. The Same Weather

Nothing external had changed. None of them would have believed that in July.

. . .

The FY27 cycle opened in October exactly as FY26 had: a pre-read, a demand, and a gap between them. Harriet Nash was exactly as much of a force of nature as she had ever been. Bellwether was bigger, and therefore the problems were bigger, and there were still Sunday nights.

Kate danced on Wednesdays, badly, at the church hall on Milkwood Road, in a room mostly of people over fifty who did not care.

Colin was nationally ranked and had never once let anybody forget it. He had chaired something in banking for twenty years before he retired to this, and mentioned that about as often. On the third Wednesday he said, “You were at the Ardenne in July. The fern lanyards. I was running the thing in Hall 2,” and Kate had no memory of him at all. He had taken one look at her frame on the first evening and said, “Oh. We’ve got a controller,” in a voice of enormous satisfaction, and had been working on her for eight weeks.

“Stop,” he said, in the eighth week.

The room stopped, which Kate found she minded less than she used to.

“Kate. What are you doing with your right hand.”

“Following.”

“You are *steering*.” He came over and lifted her forearm off her partner’s shoulder by about an inch and let it go, and it went straight back. “There. Again. Off.”

“That’s where it goes.”

“That is where it goes if you are driving him to the station.” Somebody laughed. “Whose job is it to know where you are going next?”

“His.”

“And do you believe that?”

“No,” said Kate.

“No,” Colin agreed, delighted, and threw up both hands at the ceiling. “You are dancing as if the music might get it wrong.”

And Kate laughed so hard she had to sit down on the edge of the stage. In a church hall, on a Wednesday, in front of a dozen strangers and her own assistant, at forty-one years old.

She could not do the turn. She still could not really do the turn. But there was a moment, in the second half of a class, sometimes, when her body stopped asking permission, and she recognised it, from a church hall in Amersham, from being nine.

Every time it happened she thought: *there you are*.

She let Tom run things. He mostly did not drop them, and when he did the company did not end. And she had begun, slowly, to be able to watch a thing wobble without putting her hand on it, which was the single hardest skill she had ever tried to learn, and which she was worse at than the turn.

She had not rung the others.

The group Nik had made — *Ardenne*, four names — sat in her phone with nothing in it. She looked at it about once a fortnight. She thought about writing in it about once a fortnight, and did not, because the last night was in it, unspoken, sitting where it fell, and she did not know how to write a message that stepped over it, and could not bear to write one that stepped in it.

• • •

Nik filed the second honest quarterly memo in October.

It was easier than the first and still not easy. Aaron from Hollis gave him a hard time about a different thing, correctly, and Nik answered it plainly and survived it.

Sunward was now due at the end of January, and would probably, Nik thought, privately, assigning it a number the way he now made himself assign everything a number, slip to March. He had already started the conversation about March, in November, from a position of ten months of cash, which is a conversation you can have.

In the kitchen at Woking, in the second week of November, a woman from the boiler company said the boiler had four to five years left in it, and Nik said “That’s fine,” and then heard himself, and said, “Sorry. It isn’t fine. What does four to five years actually mean,” and got a real answer, and wrote it down.

He and Meera were not fixed, because people are not fixed. But she asked him the second question now, and waited for the answer.

And when he polished something — which he still did, sometimes, in company, the reflex firing off before he could stop it, she would catch his eye across a room and hold up, very slightly, one finger.

That was their private thing. It meant *say it once, slowly*.

His father's knee was done in September, privately, and the physiotherapy worked. Raghavan walked to the end of the road and back in November, and rang to report it as though it were a chess result: the distance, the time, and one observation about the surface.

The suitcase was still the maroon one. Anaya had stopped asking about it, and had, in a development nobody had predicted, begun to tell the suitcase's story at school as though it were a thing to be proud of, which Nik discovered at a parents' evening and did not know what to do with.

Nik had not rung the others either.

• • •

The new office had underfloor ventilation and the grilles were in the wrong places, so the room ran quiet at one end and loud at the other, and Alex sat at the loud end because it was the end where he could hear it.

In November, in a meeting about whether to take the Arcus number seriously, he went first.

Eight people, a Tuesday, nothing at stake beyond the next four years.

"I want to say one thing at the start and then I'll shut up about it. If we sell now we sell the compliance module, because that's what's demoed and that's what has revenue

against it. The engine is the asset, and the engine isn't legible yet. So the question isn't whether the number's good. It's whether we're willing to be bought for the mannequin."

And he stopped.

Ben had the pen up and the board behind him. Alex watched him get halfway into the movement. The shoulder already turning, the marker already at the surface, the box beginning. And stop.

It cost him something visible.

He put the pen down on the ledge.

"Say the last bit again," he said.

So Alex said it again, and the room actually looked at it, for something like ninety seconds, which was ninety seconds longer than it would have looked in June. Then they argued for an hour, and the decision went about half his way.

Nobody in the room noticed anything had happened.

The grilles went on doing what they did.

The notebook was filling up again — a fifth one in October, red, the fourth full. And in the back of the fourth, in small square handwriting, written badly in the dark on a roof in Birmingham in July: *ask him about the second-question thing.*

He never asked anybody. It had turned out not to be a question for anybody else.

He had not rung the others. He kept meaning to ring Michael back, and the meaning-to had gone from anger to awkwardness to the flat paralysis of a thing left too long.

• • •

And so it sat, for months, in a group chat with four names in it and nothing written.

Until a Thursday in the middle of November, when Kate Merrick, standing at her window at half past nine at night with the city below her, decided.

She did not write in the group. Four people who had blown up a room were not going to un-blow it in a group chat, all at once, in front of each other.

One at a time, then. Ringing, not writing.

She rang Alex first.

“It’s Kate,” she said. “From the hotel. Don’t hang up, I know it’s weird.”

“...Hi,” said Alex.

“I’ll be quick. I’m going to be in a pub on Friday, the week after next, near Liverpool Street. I’d like it if you came. There’s no agenda. I’m going to ring Nik and Michael and ask them too, and if none of you come I’ll have a drink on my own and it’ll be fine. That’s it. That’s the whole call.”

There was a pause.

“Yeah,” said Alex. “Yeah. I’ll come. I’ve — yeah. I owe Michael a phone call, actually, I keep—”

“Bring him. I’ll ring him too. Friday the twenty-ninth. Six o’clock. I’ll text you the place.”

“OK. Kate — thanks. For ringing. I wouldn’t have.”

“I know,” said Kate. “That’s why I did.”

She rang Nik second.

Nik said yes before she had finished the sentence. “Yes. God. Yes. I made a group, did you — I made a group in July and I couldn’t write in it, I’ve been looking at it for four months.”

“I know,” said Kate. “I’ve been looking at it too.”

There was a thing in both their voices.

“I’ll be there. Friday. I’ll come up from Guildford. Yes.”

Then she rang Michael.

• • •

Michael’s phone rang in a house in Hertfordshire at 9:52 on a Thursday night, and it was answered, and the voice was not Michael’s.

“Hello?”

“Oh — hello, sorry, I’m trying to reach Michael. Michael Halloway. It’s Kate Merrick, I’m — we met over the summer, I’m an advisor to—”

“Kate.” The voice was a woman’s, and it was steady in the way a voice is steady when it has been made to be. “Kate, yes. He mentioned you. I’m Claire. I’m his daughter.”

“Is he—”

There was a silence on the line of about two seconds. Kate Merrick read silences the way Nik read positions.

“I’m so sorry,” said Claire. “I don’t know how to — you didn’t know. Of course you didn’t. Dad died. Nine days ago.”

A breath, carefully managed.

“He’d been ill for quite a long time. A heart thing, and then it turned out to be more than a heart thing. And he didn’t tell anyone. He didn’t tell *us*, properly, until the summer, and even then he — you know what he was like. He made it a joke. He’d known for over a year and he told nobody, and he made his choices around it and never once said why, and we only understood afterwards what the last few months had been about.”

Kate did not say anything, because there was nothing.

“He talked about the hotel,” said Claire. “At the end. He talked about it a lot. There was a boy with a marker pen, and a man who played chess, and a woman who gave him a job that was a telephone.” A sound that was almost a laugh. “That was you.”

“That was me,” said Kate.

“He said it was the first thing in years that had needed *him* and not the job.” Claire’s voice went, for a second, and came back. “So. Thank you. For that. Whatever it was, that weekend — thank you. He came back different. We got a few good months that I don’t think we’d have got otherwise.”

Kate stood at her window with the phone against her ear and the whole lit city below her, and thought about a man turning a glass a quarter-turn on a marble bar. *They punish the interval. I optimised everything except the part that was the point. Nobody has ever come.*

“We were going to have a drink,” Kate said. “The four of us. Next Friday. He was going to come.”

“Then have it,” said Claire. “Please. Have it anyway.”

27. Friday

Nik got there first, at ten to six, because he had left Guildford absurdly early and had walked around Liverpool Street for forty minutes in the cold rather than be late.

The pub was called The Fen, on a corner off Sun Street, and it was old in the real way rather than the decorated way: dark wood gone darker, a fire that actually worked, a floor that sloped. Nik took a table by the fire, a table for four, and hung his coat over one of the chairs, and sat down, and did not look at the menu.

He waited.

He had brought, in his coat pocket, for no reason he could have defended, a small wooden chess piece. A white king from the travel set, worn pale on one side by a previous owner. He took it out and stood it on the table and looked at it and put it back in his pocket.

Alex came in at four minutes past six.

He came in the way he came into everywhere: fast, already apologising, scanning the room with the headphones round his neck. And then he saw Nik, and stopped, and his whole face changed, and neither of them managed to do the thing that men do, the nod, the *all right*, the cool version. Nik stood up too fast and knocked the table and Alex said “*mate*” in a voice that had nothing guarded in it at all, and they did not shake hands, they did the other thing, the brief hard clasp

with a hand on the shoulder, and then both sat down slightly embarrassed and enormously pleased.

“You look—” said Nik.

“Yeah, you too. You look — did you win?”

“I lost the last one. On purpose, sort of. I’ll tell you.” Nik was grinning. “Four out of seven. Not a penny.”

“Not a *penny*.”

“It’s not a business,” said Nik.

And Alex laughed, and it was, for an hour, exactly the way it had been on the roof.

• • •

They talked over each other, both at once, neither minding.

They had an hour before Kate came, and they spent it as you spend it with somebody you were honest with once, under strange conditions, and have not seen since: quickly, greedily, facts first.

Alex told him about Ben. About the meeting with no laptops. About *once, slowly*.

And Nik put his glass down and said, “That’s my — Alex, that’s the thing your dad said. I’ve been using that. I’ve been using it for four months, ask Meera.”

“I know,” said Alex. “I gave it to you. You gave it back.”

They both sat with that for a second.

Nik told him about the memo, and the number he had said out loud in his own kitchen, and the sambar with too much water, and Rohan pointing at the chair. He told him about Wilf, and *what is it you think you’re protecting*, and the empty room behind the door.

“Did you work it out? What it was?”

“The four seconds,” said Nik. “When they haven’t got it yet and they’re deciding about you.”

Alex went still.

“Oh,” he said. “Yeah. That’s — yeah. That’s mine too. That’s exactly mine.”

“How’s your dad?” said Nik.

“Good. His knee — no, that’s yours. His shoulder’s the same. He’s good. We talk properly now.” Alex turned his glass. “He said a thing about — he said the sacrifice isn’t a debt. That I can’t pay it back because there’s nobody to pay, and it’s not a loan, it’s an inheritance, and you don’t pay back an inheritance. You spend it.” He said it carefully, getting it right. “I think about it every day.”

“That’s a good father,” said Nik.

“Yeah,” said Alex. “He is.” And then, because he could, because it was that kind of hour: “So’s the one you’re being. For the record. The chair thing. Rohan pointing at the chair. You know that’s — you did that. You’re doing that.”

Nik looked at the fire for a moment.

“Where’s Michael?” he said. “He’s usually the one holding court by now. He’ll come in and there’ll be a thing with the barman and we’ll all end up—”

And the door opened, and it was Kate.

• • •

She came in out of the rain in a dark coat, and she saw them, and she came over, and she did not sit down.

They both knew. That was the thing Kate saw as she crossed the room, and it was almost the worst part: that they both stood up, smiling, ready to be glad, Nik already saying “Kate—”, and she watched the smiles begin to go as she got closer, because whatever was in her face was arriving ahead of her.

“Sit down,” she said. “Please. Sit down a second.”

They sat.

She stayed standing, with her hands on the back of the empty chair — the fourth chair, the one Nik had put his coat over an hour ago and then quietly taken back.

And she said it the way Michael had taught her to say the thing they don’t want to hear. Plainly. Once. Without making them wait for it. Without a preamble that would let them start hoping in the gap.

“Michael died,” she said. “Three weeks ago. I rang him to ask him here, and his daughter answered. He’d been ill for over a year. A heart thing that turned into something else. He knew. He’d known the whole time. He didn’t tell anyone.”

Nobody said anything.

The fire burned. Somewhere behind them a man laughed at a different table, in a different world.

“He’d have come tonight,” said Kate.

Her voice was level, the same level as the voicemail, except that this time she was using it on purpose, to get the words out whole.

“His daughter said he’d talked about the hotel, at the end. About all of us. The boy with the marker pen. The man who plays chess.” She looked at each of them. “The woman who gave him a job that was a telephone.”

She sat down, finally, in her own chair, and put her hands flat on the table.

Nik saw that they were not quite steady.

And that she had let him see it.

“He said it was the first thing in years that had needed him and not the job,” Kate said. “That’s what she told me. So.”

• • •

They sat with it.

Alex was looking at the table. His jaw was working. He had, everyone at the table could see, gone somewhere.

“I never called him back,” he said.

“Alex—”

“He left me a voicemail. In September. He rang and I didn’t pick up and he left a voicemail and I’ve listened to it three times and I never — I kept meaning to do it at the weekend. I was still angry. I said a thing to him, the last night, I called him a mascot, I said — and he rang me *in September* to say I’d been right, and to say sorry about the introduction, and I thought, I’ll call him back when I’m less—”

He stopped.

“I did the thing my dad warned me about. The debt that gets bigger the longer you leave it. I did it to Michael.”

Nobody told him it was all right.

Then Alex took out his phone.

“It’s forty seconds,” he said. “Do you want to—”

“Yes,” said Nik.

“Yes,” said Kate.

Alex put the phone in the middle of the table, on the dark wood, between the four glasses, and turned it up, and pressed play.

• • •

Alex. It's Michael. From the — from the hotel. The mascot.

His voice came out of the small speaker into the pub, and it was him: the warmth, the timing, the tiny pause before the joke that you could hear him choosing not to fully make.

Listen. You were right about most of it, and I've thought about it a great deal, and I wanted to say so, and I wanted to say that the introduction — I should have sent it to you. Just you. You were right about that, and I knew the reason while I was doing it, and you named it, and it's cost me some sleep, which at my age is a genuine sacrifice.

Kate had her hand over her mouth.

They had braced for last words. These were not last words. Whatever he had known in September, he had not known how little was left of it, and so there was nothing in the recording that was saying goodbye. Only a man on an ordinary Wednesday ringing somebody up and putting the true thing first, without going round by the joke.

Anyway. I hear the recon thing worked. Of course it did. Ring me back if you want to. And if you don't, that's — I'd understand that too.

A breath. You could hear him deciding.

And then, at the very end, because he could not help it:

Right. That's the message. I'd say don't let it go to your head, but I've met your head, so — too late. Goodbye.

You could hear him smiling. Pleased with the small joke.
In a room in Hertfordshire, in September, alive.
The message stopped.
Nobody at the table said anything.

• • •

There was a long time where nobody said anything.

The fire ticked. The phone screen went dark on the wood between them. At the bar somebody ordered a round, and it was all, distantly, going on: the whole ordinary Friday of it.

Then Nik got up, without a word, and went to the bar, and came back with four glasses on a tray, and set them down around the table. One in front of Kate. One in front of Alex. One in front of himself.

And one in front of the empty chair.

He poured. It was a bottle of red, the second-cheapest, though he did not know that Kate had noticed. He filled all four, including the fourth, right up, and set the bottle down, and sat.

The fourth glass stood in front of the empty chair. Full. Dark. Catching the light off the fire.

Nobody moved it. Nobody said *to Michael*, or *he'd have wanted*, or any of the sentences that exist to make a moment easier.

They left it where it was.

Alex, after a while, picked up his own glass and held it. Not raised. Just held, in both hands, to warm them on it.

"He put a joke on the end," he said. "For me. So I wouldn't
—"

He stopped.

“He did it for me.”

“Yes,” said Kate.

“He did it every time,” said Nik.

“Yes,” said Kate.

And they sat there, the three of them, with the fourth glass full in front of the empty chair, and the rain on the window, and the fire.

And after a long while Kate said, quietly, not as a toast, just as a fact she wanted said out loud in a room with a face in it:

“Same time next Friday.”

“Yes,” said Nik.

“Yeah,” said Alex.

Somebody paid for the fourth glass. It was Nik, at the end, quietly, when he settled the tab, and nobody argued about it, and nobody drank it.

The pub cleared it away after they had gone and thought nothing of it.